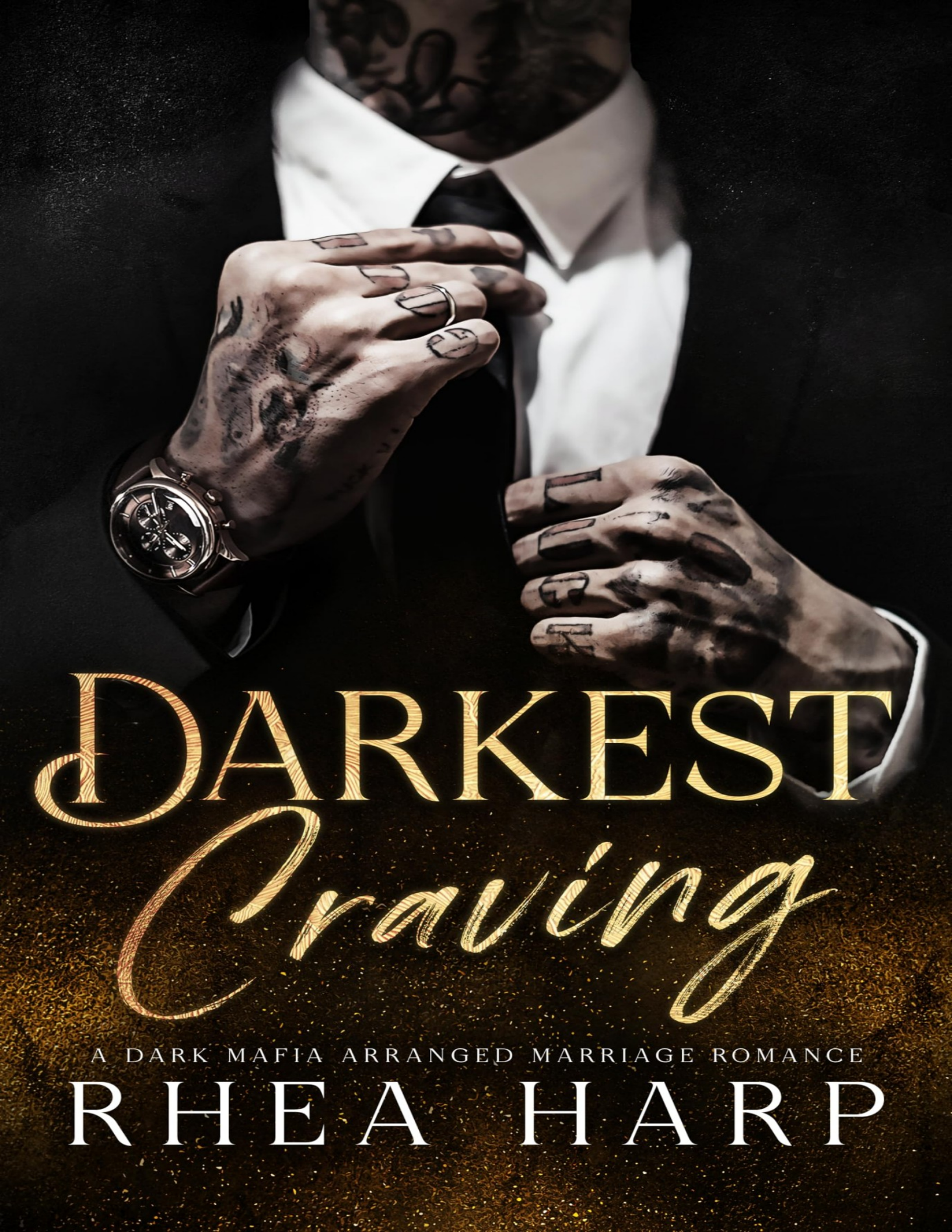
Darkest
Craving
A DARK MAFIA ARRANGED MARRIAGE ROMANCE
RHEA HARP

Darkest Craving

A dark mafia arranged marriage romance

Rhea Harp

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Author's Note

Welcome to Rhea Harp's world.

In this book, chaos, darkness, and ferocious love reign supreme. The characters are over-the-top, and their door is always open for you to experience the spice and angst you're probably here for.

If all that sounds good, turn the page. But be careful. This book explores dark themes, and if you want an extensive list of TWs before you begin, check out my website (rheaharp.com).

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1

VICTORIA

Two months ago

Piercing golden eyes bore into me. A wolf. I had seen it and kept quiet because if I reacted in any way, the horse—already throwing fits and doing whatever the hell he wanted—would've felt the panic in the strain of my muscles. And he would've knocked me off my saddle instantly.

He was a young, untrained stallion, and I had no idea where he came from, or why my father even purchased him.

But, if I was being honest, a big part of me hoped it was his way of making up for our strained relationship. That he had finally chosen to extend his love to me.

I clung to that thought, a bit desperately maybe, because I wanted it to be true.

Owning a horse had been my dream for far too long. Besides, my twenty-second birthday was coming up, so perhaps he'd dumped him as my gift in

the stables.

Sasha Kasparov, my instructor of many years, stood facing me, completely oblivious to the man watching our lesson. A man, yes, not an *actual* wolf—though he might as well have been one. His dark figure loomed over us like an evil spirit spawned by the forest surrounding my family's villa.

The sight frightened me.

Dangerous men came to our house all the time. It was not unusual to see one now and then, no matter how much my parents tried to keep their blood business from my sister and me.

But this man… this cunning *wolf* preying on us right now… he was different, though I couldn't put my finger on what made him so. All I knew was that his stance—his energy—had the hairs on the back of my neck standing up and the breath in my lungs trembling on its way out into the crisp air.

And he was tall—tall enough that he was at eye level with the stallion—and built like a monolith of muscle and sheer precision. It was visible even through the texture of his long winter coat.

Hands inside the pockets, he watched me as the wind caressed the tresses of his short, dark hair, surrounding him with even more mystery.

What was he doing out here so early in the morning? Why wasn't he in my father's office, like the rest?

The stallion shifted beneath me, snorting softly, his black coat gleaming in the muted sunlight. Taking a long breath in, I tried to relax, to give him the impression I was calm.

"Sit up taller, Victoria. Shoulders back," Sasha called from behind me, his sharp Russian accent slicing through the quiet.

I straightened up and relaxed my hands on the reins. “Come on, boy, let’s go.”

And I didn’t know why, but I suddenly felt the need to prove myself and show the stranger I was in control of my horse, even if I wasn’t.

I waited, albeit restlessly, giving the animal time to react to my command. But he didn’t budge.

Like a statue carved from arrogance, he stomped his hooves against the sand, snorting as if to mock me. It wasn’t the horse’s fault, that I knew. I simply hadn’t trained one before, even with all the knowledge I gathered over the years by leasing different breeds. It also didn’t help that I was impatient by nature.

I urged him again before the reins tightened in my grasp. The thought of being watched so closely and by someone so stoic made my pulse quicken in a way it hadn’t in a long time. Or ever. I felt exposed, vulnerable under his gaze, wishing Sasha would tell him to go away.

Teeth clenched, I kept encouraging the horse, firmer this time. Only now he was peeling back his ears, a clear sign he wanted nothing to do with me.

Shit.

Sasha grumbled, probably sensing my frustration. “You know better than to–”

His phone rang, stealing his attention.

Lifting a finger in the air to tell me he’d be right back, he walked away. And it was right at that moment that a low, composed whistle made its way to me on the wind, loud enough for only me and the horse to hear it.

Consequently, and to my utter disbelief, the stallion started walking. Just not in the direction I was steering him. No. This horse had shut me off

completely—*me*, a professional horse rider—and turned to walk toward the *wolf*, toward the stranger, instead. As if he knew him. Or as if the whistle had been commanding enough to deem him as his new master.

Familiar as my heartbeat, the rhythmic thud of hooves meeting the ground reached my ears as I swayed slowly from the movement.

The man exuded danger, and the horse was leading me straight to him.

He could hurt me, couldn't he? No one here could stop him. Surely not my sixty-three-year-old instructor, who wasn't as strong as he once was. And my father's goons weren't even here. Normally, there was no need to be guarded so closely on our own property.

Maybe it's time to change that.

But the closer the horse took me, the more something surged in me.

The sun peeked from behind a gray cloud, momentarily blinding me, and I squinted my eyes. Because this wolf… was he smiling? *Yes*, he sure was. One corner of his mouth was slightly up. And had I not picked up on the subtle incline of his eyes toward the stallion, I would've thought he was doing it for… me.

"There you are," the stranger said in a low voice that went past his lush lips—a voice like dark molasses poured slow and rich that coated every word in sins too heavy for me to want to imagine. The horse stopped in front of him, bowing his head in greeting, offering his submission. "Well done," he praised the animal.

I gulped.

Taking him in, I noticed how different he looked from the boys at college, and maybe it had to do with the fact that he wasn't one. He was a man, and he was older, maybe somewhere in his early thirties.

A wave of heat washed over me, my clothes suddenly heavy.

I was too hot with the winter vest on top of my jacket.

Too hot beneath the white breeches hugging my thighs.

Too hot with my helmet on, which I knew I shouldn't remove while still up on the horse. But I did it anyway so the cool air could kiss my forehead.

Everything was suffocating.

The motion got the stranger's attention. His gaze slowly lifted to me—piercing and deadly, painted in the pale yellow of dawn with uneven specks of spilled whiskey. What a strange color. Strange and… incredibly alluring.

His smile faded.

And his features—that sharp jawline with neatly trimmed stubble—hardened at the sight of me. It made me that much more defensive knowing he wasn't pleased with me, for whatever reason.

"And who are you?" he asked, sounding bored, as he retracted his palm from the horse's snout.

Who am I? Who am I when he's on our property, and he's *the intruder?*

I looked back at my instructor, hoping he'd intervene, but he was fully engaged in whatever heated conversation he was having over the phone on the other side of the arena.

The stranger tsked, a disappointed, corroding reaction that sent a flicker of shock through my body. "Cat got your tongue?"

Scowling, I kept my tone equally bland when I answered, "Victoria Romanov. And you're trespassing."

I swung my leg over the saddle, sliding down in one fluid motion, boots hitting the ground with a muted thud. A mistake, really, because now I was way below his size. The urge to climb on the horse was strong, but I would've looked stupid doing so. And insecure.

Heart in my throat, I waited for his reaction not knowing what to expect. I had been right earlier when I compared him to a wolf. He was attractive—cunningly so. The kind mothers wouldn't want their daughters hanging out with because he broke hearts.

But it wasn't just about the way he looked. It was his stance, his confidence. Nothing seemed to faze him. He moved with a grace so lethal he seemed to have all the time in the world to do what he pleased. And maybe he did.

Then there was his scent—the muted amber, the smoky sandalwood—it invited you in. In fact, everything about this man beckoned me closer. He was the kind of predator that could've lured you in without a sound, then devoured you slowly, savoring every inch, burying your bones somewhere no one would ever find them.

He had to know these things about himself.

"Tell me, *Victoria*, do you enjoy being told what to do?"

The air in my lungs whooshed out.

"Excuse me?"

The corner of his lush mouth went up as he jerked his head toward Sasha. "You looked at him before you answered me. Do you often seek approval from men to do what you want?"

I snorted an incredulous laugh, annoyed at my speechlessness. But I watched him closely, and I noticed how his smile barely widened, never reaching his eyes.

“You’re flashing your nervousness all over the arena,” he said, changing the subject so abruptly it took me aback. “The horse can smell it on you.”

I crossed my arms, holding the reins at my chest. “He hasn’t been trained. And he’s young—”

“Not willing to assume responsibility, I see. Perhaps you need a bit of training yourself.”

“*Perhaps*—” I blinked “—you should mind your own goddamn business and leave, before my father’s goons snap your neck.”

He fell quiet for a moment, almost as if lost in thought. What was he thinking? Who *was* this man?

“Victoria, get inside.” Sasha finally stepped forward, seeing the wolf for the first time just then. Shielding me as best as he could.

And I wanted to do just what he suggested. *God*, I really did, but I didn’t want this man to think I was scared. Cowering in front of a predator was never a good idea.

“Why should I be the one to leave? He’s the one who interrupted us.”

“*Now*, Victoria.”

Sasha had never raised his voice at me before.

Startled, my gaze shifted between the two men. The air was tense, thick with the promise of danger and blood. And the way this wolf continued to look through me still flustered me. The gesture itself was so simple, so distant, yet so utterly terrifying as if… as if he could see all that I had never revealed to the world about myself—my darkest thoughts, my hopes and dreams. Everything.

My lips parted. I almost stepped back, desperately wanting to leave. But the wolf clasped his hands in front of him calmly and said–

“He isn’t untrained. He just doesn’t understand English.”

I scowled. “W-what?”

The horse. He’s talking about the horse.

“He understands his commands in Russian.”

“And you know that, how?”

Behind him, a black, spotless Rolls-Royce stopped in the driveway. A driver, dressed in an impeccable coat, opened the door to the backseat.

“Because the horse is mine.”

My eyes shifted from the driveway to the stranger in front of me, widening at the new information. His long coat billowed behind him, caught in the gentle wind as he walked away. Lethal—so lethal was that walk, and the way he’d spoken, and the way he’d showed up with no one noticing.

I blinked once more before he disappeared into the car completely, and the engine roared back to life. The wind whooshed past my ears, and the chirping of sparrows resumed all around me, like a forest coming back to life after a predator left the area. But my goosebumps… they never stopped crawling down my spine. Because even though the windows were tinted and I couldn’t see inside the car, I knew those sunset-colored eyes kept watching.

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2

VICTORIA

One month ago

It had been a month since I saw the wolf, and I hadn't told anybody about him.

Sasha didn't come back. He was too busy playing local royalty, organizing the Alemont City Horse Trials like he did every damn year. If I'd cared about competing, I would've been out there too—measuring the terrain with the others, schmoozing with the judges, pretending to give a shit. But riding had never been about medals or applause.

It was escape. Control. It was indulgence, as my mother liked to spit with a glass of Chardonnay in hand—*an expensive little distraction*. And apparently, I wasn't allowed distractions.

I wanted to go to riding school in Europe after graduation. A dream I dared to whisper once that ended with my father laughing in my face. I wasn't even at the college I chose. He decided for me. Enrolled me, paid the fees, and expected me to thrive. All I had to do was show up and smile pretty.

And yet, the idea of finishing his degree made my stomach churn. Why force me through it, when he'd already anointed my sister?

Anya was the chosen one, the golden child. The future CEO of Romanov Enterprises. I was just a loose end, and a reputation risk. Apparently, my dream of becoming a riding instructor was childish. Embarrassing. "Not something you bring up around business partners." Because God forbid Nikolai Romanov's daughter got her hands dirty teaching kids how to saddle a horse. No, he'd rather choke me with expectations and call it legacy.

Still, I was going to do it as soon as I graduated, regardless of what he thought. Only a few months kept me away from that dream. And then… then I would be free. Free of family obligations, free of the scrutiny of other wealthy families in Alemont City. Free of the expectations people had of me.

I walked with that thought, my soul lighting up a little brighter. My winter boots scrunched through the thin layer of snow covering the stone that led up to our main entrance. I hadn't even realized I made it so close to the house. My mind had been entirely elsewhere these past few weeks.

I'd been thinking about the wolf… a lot.

His condescending tone angered me, even through my memories. I'd come up with much better comebacks when replaying our conversation. And I itched to throw them in his face and see him crumble under the weight of my words. Because it hadn't been a fair fight. He took me by surprise when he showed up, then had the nerve to *insult* me by saying I was somehow bound to the approval of men to do what I pleased—a far-fetched assumption.

That was one reason he was on my mind.

The other reason was… well, much more complicated. I didn't want to admit it then, but looking back at the situation, I could see it now. His

darkness drew me to him. It made me curious. For reasons I couldn't explain, I wanted to know who he was behind those mocking remarks and alluring gestures. And I wanted to live with that mystery for a while. It was thrilling.

Which is why I decided I would not entertain that thought any longer.

The goons Father assigned to drive me home finally scattered as I entered the house. My backpack hung heavy on my shoulder, loaded with history books I was supposed to study for tomorrow's exam, but I wasn't going to. I'd already read everything Sasha brought me about *The Medici Family Feuds* weeks ago. Devoured it, even. He did that a lot—taught me about history, and politics, and games that kept the mind sharp, despite never being compensated for the extra time he dedicated to me.

Taking the corner into the dining room, I saw my mother sitting with one leg crossed over the other at the long table, puffing out smoke from a cigarette.

Her fingers trembled around it, bringing it back to her mouth, which only told me this wasn't her first. Or her second. The muted fire ate more and more of the paper holding the nicotine together, her drag long and deep. When she exhaled, it took her a moment to see me through the thick cloud of smoke curling along her face.

"Is it two already?" she asked, her voice laced with exhaustion.

I narrowed my eyes, dropping my backpack on an empty chair. "What's going on?"

"Where's your sister?"

"I don't know. On her way back, I think. Mom… what's wrong?"

She tapped the cigarette against the ashtray. "For God's sake, Victoria, stop asking so many questions. Lunch is on the stove." She jerked her head

toward it, her platinum-blond hair—my hair, and my sister's hair—slipping from behind her ear. "Go get yourself some."

Hesitantly, I rounded the table and grabbed a bowl, then lifted the lid of a steaming pot. The beef stroganoff smelled delicious as I served myself a portion—not my mother's cooking.

We'd had a chef ever since my father's business began making heaps of money. And I was convinced Mom had been happier that day than the day she gave birth to me. It made sense, I guessed, since she had been forced to marry a man she never loved, then have kids with him on top of that.

Still, with Anya, it was different. Mother liked to spoil her, to praise every little thing she did. She called her beautiful when she combed her hair when we were kids. Tucked her in longer than she ever tucked me in.

It took most of my childhood to accept it. That the little love she had left to give was all for my sister. It's the reason I became so attached to Sasha, who felt more like a parent to me than my real ones ever did.

I ate my lunch in silence while Mom looked through me, lost in whatever troubled her mind on this Monday afternoon. Minutes later, Anya finally showed up.

"Jesus!" Anya scrunched her nose, waving her manicured hand in the air. "Open a window or something! I can't breathe in here."

Mother's eyes snapped to her, throat bobbing when she got up to pour herself scotch from the decanter across the room. "Sit down, Anya. Victoria, you can go to your room."

Anya threw me a questioning look, but I only shrugged in response.

"What is it this time?" my sister mused, plopping down on a chair next to me. "Are my grades not to your liking again?" She turned to me mouthing, *"Stay?"* and I was glad she asked because I didn't want to leave. Whatever

Mom had to say, it seemed serious enough that she'd fully given in to her vices today.

So I'd stay, then, if only just for damage control.

Mom turned around with her drink, rolling her eyes at seeing the decision etched on my face. "Fine. You were going to find out anyway." Then she just sat there with her head bowed toward her lap, delaying the inevitable.

A swirl of nervousness sprung in my gut, and it seemed my sister felt it too because she found my hand under the table and squeezed. An odd and rare gesture, but of course, I squeezed back.

"I guess you're old enough to hear the truth about your father's work."

"Yeah, we *know*," Anya drawled. "He's working for the Bratva. Do you really think we haven't noticed the kinds of men walking in and out of our home like they own the place?"

She was right. Besides, it was hard not to overhear the conversations our parents had in this house. I watched our mother like a hawk, curious to see what she'd say to that. But she merely offered a clipped nod. "Good."

Good? There was nothing good about this. Nothing at all.

"It's easier to explain, then. Because yes, the way your father and I have cared for this family—" I didn't miss the way she'd phrased it—like she wanted to make sure we knew she was involved as well— "has been through the help of the *Pakhan*. The hotel suite is his gift to us, and the way we launder his money. And in return, we get to live the life we have now." Her brows rose with the last words. She puffed out more smoke. "But now, your father… he… made a mistake."

My pulse quickened, and I squeezed my sister's hand harder.

I knew exactly what “a mistake” meant in this world. I’d seen enough movies, heard enough stories—gruesome ones—about the way the Bratva disposed of traitors. Anya and I shared a look, and it told me she’d heard the same.

“Why?” I asked. “We already had everything. Has he not made enough money? Why risk everything? For what?”

Mom snorted as she picked up a new cigarette from the pack. “You ask this as if you don’t know him. Greed took your father’s soul long ago, Victoria. It is what it is.”

“So… what does this mean for us?” Anya shook her head. “Do we leave the country? We’ve built a life here, Mom. We have *friends*. We can’t just—”

“We’re not going anywhere,” she deadpanned, looking down at the ashtray on the table. “I know it will be hard to hear, but you’ve had lots of privileges up to this day. Both of you. Now is one of those times when you have to settle the balance.” Her gaze rose, pinning Anya down. “So we’ve arranged for you to marry into the *Pakhan*’s family to make this all go away.”

The room fell silent.

Anya and I had never been very close. I wanted to, and often tried, but she preferred hanging out with her friends, leaving me to my own devices more times than I could count. But even so, she was my sister. And my parents were about to throw her to the wolves.

“What about her future? Mom… What the hell are you talking about?” I asked.

A pained scoff filled the dirty air. “You think I want this? I’m powerless in this, just like you. I don’t have a choice. I’ll have to give away my daughter!” She sniffed, quickly regaining control over her emotions. I’d never seen her cry.

Anya shook with anger. How could our mother do this when she'd been subjected to the same treatment from her parents? I realized it was mostly Father's doing, not her own, but still. She could've tried to do something about it—anything. Instead, she accepted it, gave up before even putting up a fight.

"No," Anya said plainly. "No. I won't do it."

Mom's jaw clenched. "It's already settled."

Anya shook her head, her hand retracting from mine in one swift motion as she got up.

"You can't make me. I will run away. I would rather *die* than marry some sleazy fossil past his expiration date. And why the fuck does it have to be me?!"

Her question slapped me across my face harder than she could've done it with her palm.

Sure, we had never been close, but this… this was a betrayal, because we were family, and I had never wished ill on her, ever, no matter how jealous I was of her being our parents' favorite. I should've hated her for saying that, and yet… maybe it was better that she did.

Maybe if my parents married me off instead of her, they would finally see me as well.

Mom's eyes shifted between the two of us. If she understood what had happened, how it made me feel, she said nothing about it.

"He wants to marry our heir," she explained, puffing out more smoke.

Simple as that. No room for debate.

"Fuck this." Anya stormed out, refusing to hear anything more.

Fuck this, indeed. If I was being honest, even through the haze of my pain, I couldn’t blame her for reacting this way. Hell, maybe I would’ve done the same thing. Neither of us was ready to be a bride, much less to a cruel man who had the power to ruin us.

Mom and I remained at the table in silence as I tried to make sense of all of this.

And maybe it was the many books Sasha had given me over the years—mentioning politics, and hidden intentions, and power plays—that made me consider everything was, somehow, connected. My encounter with the stranger, the gifted stallion, now this… Without second thoughts, I lifted my eyes from the table and pinned her with my gaze.

“Mom?” I asked. “Whose horse is in our stables right now?”

Her lips pressed into a thin line before she gulped the entirety of her scotch.

“It’s Wolfgang Rykov’s—the *Pakhan’s* eldest son.”

The way she said that name struck me as odd, because the word wasn’t English. And it wasn’t Russian either. She’d said *Volf-gung*—clipped, foreign, the "W" softened into a "V," the last syllable hitting the back of her throat like a swallowed word. I wondered why that was because if he really was the *Pakhan’s* son… his name made no sense at all.

“It was an early wedding gift,” she continued, then took one final drag of her cigarette. “And a symbol. Obviously.”

“A symbol…? A symbol for what?”

I held my breath as I waited for the answer, knowing deep in my bones it wouldn’t be good. When she exhaled again, she stubbed out her cigarette in the ashtray.

“Death, Victoria. A symbol for death.”

My fingers twitched in my lap, anxiety flowing freely through me as if a dam had broken. And as my mother kept on talking, every word she voiced felt like a stab.

“We either do this—let him take what he wants—or he’ll kill us. It’s either one of us… or all of us.”

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3

VICTORIA

Present Day

"Oh, yes, Anya is already going to the hotel offices with her father. And this one…" my mother squeezes my shoulders in a rare gesture of affection. "Now that she's graduating soon, she wants to leave us—go to Europe and become a professor!"

A riding instructor, but she refuses to call it for what it is. Especially in front of others.

I press my lips into a thin line, making eye contact with Alexei, one of my father's contractors. Based on the forced smile he offers in response, it's pretty clear he isn't interested in frivolous conversation. Too bad Mom spotted him in the crowd before Dad did.

An arm wraps around mine, and I turn my head to see Anya by my side.

"Excuse me, could I borrow my sister for a moment? I promise I'll bring her back."

Mom's smile widens as she waves a hand in the air. "Yes, yes, you girls go. Have fun. And save me some of that meringue, will you? People seem to love it."

"Of course." Anya nods, pulling me away.

We make our way to the other side of the living room, passing by the strangers at my twenty-second birthday party. An array of desserts decorate the buffet, all in different shapes and flavors, surrounding a lush chocolate cake with nothing written on it. Anya nonchalantly swipes a piece of raspberry meringue from the table and stuffs it in her mouth. Rolling her eyes, she lets out a clipped moan.

"I'm not saving her *anything*. This is divine. Try one?"

I tilt my head, watching her with a knowing smirk. "Is this why you pulled me away? For the meringues?"

"I was doing you a favor. You looked like you were in pain over there."

"Yeah, well…" I sigh. "You know Alexei. He's not much of a chatter."

I cross my arms and turn my body, facing the crowd—a crowd filled with our parents' acquaintances. A group of men, including my father, stand in a circle, smoking cigars and talking in their low, ragged voices over each other. The women, in pairs or groups of three, scatter around them, occasionally picking up champagne glasses from passing servers. I don't think they even know it's someone's birthday. Let alone mine.

Normally, I'd be upset about the situation, since this party clearly has nothing to do with me. But for the first time in weeks, Mom isn't smoking like a dragon with a nicotine addiction, and Dad is laughing with his associates. I didn't think I'd see my family at peace again after the news they dropped on us a few weeks ago.

But that's just the thing…

Nothing of what Mom said that day at the dining table ended up coming true. Wolfgang Rykov never came to claim Anya as his bride.

Weeks went by, and eventually, business resumed as usual… as if they completely forgave my father's "mistake," whatever that was. I try not to worry about it, but how could I not? We're still living with danger hanging over our heads, and it seems I'm the only one unable to shake it off.

And Wolfgang… *Wolfgang*…

Those amber eyes still show up in my dreams. Always haunting, always demanding something of me, as if the brief conversation we had somehow bound us forever. His presence lingers at the back of my mind, and it scares me. I shouldn't be thinking about him. What I found out about him tells me as much.

Even though there are no public records of him being convicted of anything, the way people talk about him only says one thing. He's a killer. A monster with no remorse. And likely, a psychopath. I secretly asked some of Father's goons, and that's the impression I got.

They've heard of him, of course. Turns out he's an important figure in the business world, owning a long line of companies both here, in Alemont City, and across the East Coast. How he and his family got that fortune… I didn't need to ask.

Whatever they do, men like Wolfgang don't get caught. They make calculated moves and tie up loose ends before they become liabilities. Their influence looms over the country like a spider web, and once one gets caught up in it like we did, it's practically impossible to escape. No matter how much my parents choose to deny it.

"Seems like they're having fun," I say, jerking my head toward Mom and Dad. "They look happy."

Anya scoffs. "About time. I was getting sick of the constant tension."

So was I.

But now, our parents carry themselves in a way I haven't seen them do since our trip to Italy, back when they started making their fortune. When they were still normal people… when we would still argue over things like who picked what movie to watch on Friday night. It feels like a lifetime ago. I'll never not miss it.

My sister looks back at me. "And you?"

"Me?"

"Yeah. Are *you* happy?"

I open my mouth to speak, but no words come out. Am I? I should be. I'll be leaving soon—I'm only three months away from living by myself in Europe and making a life for myself. So why am I not shouting it from the rooftops?

Anya quirks a brow, so I force a smile. "You know I am. Finally, I'll get some peace and quiet."

"Hmm. I think you'll miss me and the chaos in this house."

I roll my eyes. "I'm sure you'll be telling me all about it while I—"

The double doors to the living room barge open.

An army of goons walks inside, flooding the crowd and drawing screams from all around me. The women shrink back, clutching at their husbands' arms, their eyes darting toward the only exit as the men reach for their guns. Except… none are being taken out. As if they know exactly who's coming and they wouldn't dare put up a fight.

The goons spread through the room in what looks like a practiced formation, creating an empty corridor in the middle. I watch in utter horror,

waiting for someone to do something and save us all.

And then… silence.

Pure, undiluted silence, only speared by the rhythm of shoes clacking against the wooden floor. And with the sound, a tall, bloodthirsty shadow stretches out to the opposite side of the room, welcoming a silhouette I hoped I'd never see again.

"A party. How lovely," Wolfgang Rykov says with his hands folded patiently behind him. "Though it seems the *Pakhan*'s invitation has been… misplaced."

So hungry, so dominant is that figure in the dark, far from where the golden sun dares to shine. And that voice… that cadence… it rings low, lethal, promising destruction with every word—a stark contrast to the rushed cadence of my racing heart. It sears along my nerve endings, keeping my body wired, alert.

A subtle shift in his posture—a tilt of his head—brings a sun ray over his eyes. The same eyes that watched me that day, colored like a candle flame, like desert sand burning in torrid heat. I want to exhale, but the air is trapped in my lungs.

I can't breathe.

"An oversight, I'm sure," he adds, a smile in his voice that has nothing warm in it.

Standing in that same spot, he scans the room with icy indifference. Only when the sun moves a little, more of him appears in the dying light. And he looks more intimidating than when I last saw him.

A plain black shirt with the sleeves rolled up to his veiny forearms reveals all the tattoos I didn't get to see that day. The ink is dark—some faded, like they're old memories, some bright, as if he's never done inflicting pain on

himself. There are symbols, and then there's something long, thick, like endless roots coiling around his skin and stretching up his neck. In a way, it makes him look omniscient, like he's seen things the rest of us haven't.

Taut muscles hug his arms, the contrast between his effortless elegance and restrained violence woven into every inch of him.

Cautiously, I lift my gaze inch by inch, and suck in a breath when I realize his gaze is now on me. Only on me.

A flicker of electricity starts somewhere in my chest, traveling down to my shaking fingertips. I don't realize my lips are parted until I close them to swallow the bitter taste suddenly on my tongue.

"You'll have to forgive us," my father says, nervousness seeping out of every word. "We didn't think this would be worth your time. It's just a small gathering for our daughter—"

A step forward makes a few more people shrink back. Wolfgang's brows rise in slight amusement before continuing his trail, each step taking him closer, closer, closer…

The crowd moves around him, and his goons watch them like hawks, anticipating when or who will be stupid enough to strike first.

What is he doing? Why is he heading straight toward me?

Wolfgang's penetrative gaze welcomes me, and suddenly I'm drowning in the sunset of him. He's all I see, all I experience for what feels like an eternity, trapped in an hourglass that never runs out of sand.

"Happy birthday, love," he says, the final word pouring down my skin like warm chocolate. Like molten sin.

"T-thank you."

His hand rises next to my face, and my eyes instantly snap to the motion, giving away my restlessness. Still, I don't move away. Not a single inch. I'm frozen in place.

His calloused fingers brush the skin on my temple, gently gripping a rebel strand of platinum-blond hair and tucking it behind my ear. He lingers—just for a few seconds, but enough to show me he seems fascinated by the movement. The image of him trembles with my pupils, confusion coiling around me at the intimate gesture.

"Afraid of me?"

"Yes," I hush out.

The corner of his mouth twitches. "Honesty is a rare trait these days. It looks pretty on you."

His hand finally retracts, only so he can extend it out to the side. Almost immediately, one of his goons approaches with a flat box.

The lid is lifted, and blood-colored gemstones come into view. Five rubies cut in an emerald shape, linked by a string of clear diamonds.

Wolfgang picks it up with a slow, deliberate movement, then circles me, leaving a trail of faint sandalwood in his wake. The cologne lingers all around me, extending its tendrils out to envelop my body. It catches me in its haze like a web I can't escape before squeezing until my lungs expel all the oxygen and rely on it for survival. On this man's scent.

"May I?" Wolfgang's voice—lovely and carnal—tickles the shell of my ear.

Every sound in the room dulls under the weight of his proximity. I turn my head slightly—just enough to glance back at him.

His gaze meets mine. Steady. Intimate. Unflinching.

There’s no smile. No smirk. Just the unbearable intensity of a man who doesn’t ask questions unless he already knows the answer. A man who doesn’t wait for permission.

My breath hitches. Something hot and electric coils at the base of my spine.

And then—I move.

Not because I want to obey. Not because I’ve decided. But because he's looking at me like that. Because he expects it. Because some dark, terrifying part of me wants to be seen like this.

My fingers reach up, and I slowly gather my hair, dragging it over one shoulder. The back of my neck tingles as I expose it to the open air—to him.

I don’t look away. But his gaze lowers to my naked skin. It lingers there for a moment too long to be adventitious, showing me just how easy it would be to kill me if he wanted to. Then he wraps the jewelry around my neck, tight, fixed above my pulsing veins.

The stones are cold against my skin, and my first instinct is to take the necklace off, despite allowing him to put it on me. My hands reach for the clasp… but stop midway. The last thing I want to do right now is displease him.

When he’s gone, a cowardly voice says in my head. *I’ll take it off when he’s gone*.

“Aren’t you a precious little thing,” he drawls, coming back around to face me, tilting my chin up. Back to drowning me in his gaze. “Now, what do you say?”

Not a single voice from the crowd dares to intervene. Not my sister, nor my mother, and definitely not my father. I don’t understand what’s happening, but I square my shoulders and try to play it cool as best I can.

Keeping my outstretched hand on the stones, I say, “Thank you. It’s beautiful… You didn’t have to.”

A low hum of approval rumbles from his chest. I get the feeling he’s not responding to what I said, but to something else, something only he can see in his mind when he examines me so closely.

“Truly, a lovely gift,” my mother chirps from the distance. Wolfgang’s eyes don’t leave mine. “C-can we fix you a drink, perhaps? Lina,” she calls for one server, “Get Mr. Rykov some whiskey on the rocks—”

“That won’t be necessary,” he says, my chin dropping an inch when he retracts his hand. “I’m here to collect what’s mine.”

Anya’s whimper reaches my ears. “D-dad?” she calls out.

I turn my face to see him, and Dad has never looked smaller than he does right now.

He chuckles, his nerves obvious in the way he grips his cigar. “We expected you weeks ago, like we discussed. When you didn’t come, we assumed you’d changed your mind.”

“Only an arrogant vermin like yourself would think the *Pakhan* still tolerates you after what you’ve done. I’m here now. And no, I didn’t change my mind.”

My sister’s lip quivers as she looks at Dad with teary eyes. “Daddy, please…”

The sound seems to twist something in our father’s heart because his casual pretense dies, replaced by a grave expression where his brows draw together.

“Anything else. Take anything else you want, but leave my Anya alone. Please.”

“Ah, begging me already?” A hum of amusement vibrates from Wolfgang’s chest. “Keep going. I quite enjoy it.”

I look around at the crowd and see my father’s friends looking at him. Pitying him. Anger surges in me at the humiliation Wolfgang is so obviously determined to show in front of everyone. He wants my father to suffer, and he wants the entire world to know who’s causing the suffering. That’s what you get for betraying the *Pakhan*’s trust.

Slowly, so painfully slow, my father lowers himself to his knees, never leaving Wolfgang’s stare. I can’t believe he’s doing it.

“Please, I am begging you—”

Wolfgang lifts a finger into the air, reducing Dad to silence in the awkward position. Then, taking his phone out of the pocket of his slacks, he seamlessly dials a number that almost immediately picks up.

“You were right,” he says into the microphone. “He’s on his knees right now.”

I’m standing so close to him I can hear the other person on the other line.

“Of course he is. You owe me ten bucks.”

Ten bucks. He did this for ten bucks, when he’s a goddamn billionaire.

My hands clench into fists, nostrils flared at the humiliation he inflicts on my entire family. Making a mockery of us in front of everyone we know. In front of people who will laugh about this later, when this shitshow is over. Fire licks at my veins as I imagine the things they’re going to say.

The call ends as abruptly as it started. Wolfgang pockets his phone, then crosses his arms at his chest before bringing a hand to his chin. To those lush, sculpted lips, as if he’s considering what to do next. It’s all a pretense, by the looks of it.

He already knows exactly what he wants, and the shadows swimming in those cognac-colored irises prove it. I want to pry my eyes away from him, but he drags my gaze back when he speaks again.

“Very well, then. Anya stays.”

The entire room seems to sigh with relief. But not me. It can’t be that easy—whatever else he’s about to ask for in return will be much worse.

And when he turns to me, the look on his face confirms it.

“Say goodbye to your family, Victoria. We’re leaving.”

I can physically feel the blood draining from my face.

The room spins, a white haze webbing my vision, turning everyone around me into eerie ghosts. Into silhouettes I no longer recognize. I step back, and as if on cue, Wolfgang takes my hand.

The scars and calluses of his skin feel foreign to my body, and like an anchor, it’s enough to stop my mind from drifting. His touch sizzles, *burns*, takes control of me like a malevolent spell I can’t revoke.

This can’t be happening. It can’t. It *can’t.*

“My apologies for the short notice, love,” he murmurs. “But you’re coming home with me tonight.”

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4

WOLFGANG

She should give in to me. It would be easier for her. But the way she braces herself, trying to pull her hand from mine, clearly shows it's not what she has in mind.

I almost smile at her useless attempt, but I keep my reactions to myself for now. There will be plenty of opportunities to show her there's nothing she can do or say to make me free her from my possession.

Victoria is the cost of her father's treason, a debt that couldn't be paid in any other way than flesh.

I could've killed her and her entire family for what he's done, and it would've made my father's wish come true—a lackluster plan, in my opinion, since the men working for us are accustomed to the thought of their impending death.

Besides, everyone can kill… but not everyone can make their enemy *want* to die.

Not everyone can dangle death in front of hopeless men like a prize when they've taken everything they own and turned them into pariahs for the

world to see.

It's our specialty and exactly what makes the *Pakhan* as powerful as he is. In fact, as his *sovetnik*—his advisor—it's how *I* make him powerful, and I intend to keep doing it with sweet Victoria by my side.

"Don't act so surprised, love," I say, tightening my grip on her trembling hand. "It was always going to be you. You know that."

She shakes her head, the fear in her glossy baby-blue eyes undeniable.

I bring my thumb to her quivering lips, their rosy color and plumpness foreign to my scarred skin. My cock twitches, but it doesn't surprise me. She's a beautiful woman, and even if our marriage is just a means to an end, that won't stop me from consummating it.

Stepping back, she puts some distance between us as her head and eyes shift to her parents.

None of them makes another sound because… what else can they say? They're lucky I don't put a fucking bullet through their heads on my way out. And honestly, the fact that Nikolai tried to spare Anya but isn't doing shit for my soon-to-be-wife makes me want to do it anyway. Looks like Victoria and I have a lot more in common than I thought.

I clench my jaw, suddenly overwhelmed with the need to pull her away, to protect her from the pain of abandonment I know too well. But I don't. It's better that she sees it for what it is, just like I had to do all my life.

"Say goodbye, or don't, but we're leaving. Now, Victoria."

I don't have to look at Ivan—my right hand man—to know he's drawing his gun. I told him I wanted Victoria to feel like she had a choice, to either come with me and save her family, or watch her pretty hands stain with their blood.

In reality, I was always going to leave this house with her on my arm, collared and willing like the good little wife she's about to become.

Right now, she thinks this is all about revenge. About the cost of her father's betrayal, about getting my leverage over him. It isn't. Not fully. But she'll learn my true intentions soon enough.

Her eyes follow Ivan's gun, shifting back and forth… thinking. Deciding.

I give her a moment, and when she faces me again, it's like I'm looking at a completely different person. Her pretty face relaxes, her chest rising with a breath, her shoulders slackening on the exhale. Even the pull of her hand loosens in my grip.

Good girl.

I see it for what it is—submission. The kind that tells me I've already won.

"Victoria…" her sister says as an afterthought.

Ignoring her, Victoria tilts her head back to meet my eyes. "I need to pack."

As if. "Everything you need is already waiting for you at home."

"My phone is—"

"Not needed. Let's go."

I release her hand, only to wrap mine around the back of her neck, guiding her toward the doors.

Her body stiffens under my touch, pulse pounding like she's in flight mode, but her heels clack against the floor. The fight in her is gone.

I knew she was submissive the moment I met her, even through the facade she tried to put up when we talked.

She scoffed and crossed her arms, thinking she was defying me. But I knew—even then, I knew she was going to be my good girl and do her very best to please me while I execute her traitorous family.

We've got some work to do, of course, because right now she resents me. But in time, she'll crave me. I'll make it so that all she ever needs is me. And then, when I've taken everything there is to take from her, I'll bring her right back where she belongs before I kill them all.

I walk close behind her, her scent seeping into my pores with every step she takes through the gaping crowd.

She smells sweet and floral, like lilies in the valley—pure and untouched, and completely oblivious to the kind of life I have in store for her. A life of crawling on her hands and knees with gags in her pretty mouth while her eyes beg me to fill her holes.

She'll learn to bask in the darkness of her new cage, and I can't wait to see how long before she breaks.

The soft fabric of her metallic-red dress pours along her sides and over her ass until it touches the floor. But her back is completely naked, only obscured by the collar I secured around her neck. My pretty jewel.

I've only been here for ten minutes and she's already reinforcing my decision to marry her.

We make our way to the entrance, and no one says anything to interfere with my plans. If anything, they're still holding their breath, waiting for me to leave, waiting to make sure they're not being targeted as well.

Outside, a gentle rain splatters over the flowers' petals in the garden, prickling the driveway with dark spots. The small but crisp breeze that

comes with it causes goosebumps to erupt on Victoria's back and arms. I let my arm fall to the small of her back, shielding her from the cold with my body.

I don't want anything bad to happen to her until she officially becomes my wife.

I open the backseat door to the Rolls-Royce parked right up front, and she hauls her dress up a few inches before stooping to get in without a fuss. Ilia, my driver, steps in to open the door for me on the other side. But I raise my hand, rounding the car to do it myself and sit next to Victoria.

Hands in her lap, she stays silent with her gaze turned toward the stables. She hasn't cried yet, and I can tell she's holding it together as best she can, her eyes glossy and faraway.

I lean back in my seat, relaxing my head on the headrest as satisfaction settles within me. No point forcing her to talk now if she doesn't want to. The worst is yet to come.

So I close my eyes, feeling the slight tremor of the car as Ilia drives us away.

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5

VICTORIA

The car stops in the parking lot of a glass-covered building. What is this place? I thought he was taking me back to his house. Not knowing what he wants with me is driving me insane.

It was always going to be you. You know that.

He's wrong. I have no idea what he's talking about. Why did he change his mind? Why didn't he want my sister, as per the original agreement?

I thought about the brief conversation we had a few months ago. Analyzed it to the smallest detail, but nothing particularly welcoming was said from either side. If anything, I told him to leave, that he was trespassing, and clearly showed him I didn't want him there at all.

And yet he waited… waited for my birthday to choose me, and no one lifted a finger to save my life. I suck in a breath, swallowing back tears, because I can't let him see through me again. It's obvious the more weakness I show, the more he'll take advantage of it. And I refuse to let him.

He gets out of the car first, opening the door for me on the other side.

“Where are we?” I ask, ignoring the hand he extends toward me.

I get out on my own, and he grabs the back of my neck like he did at my parents’ house. Showing the world he owns me. My pulse quickens, and maybe he feels that, because he swipes his thumb gently across my skin as if he’s trying to pacify me… or tell me I’m right to fear him.

I bite my lip to stop it from quivering and walk with him to the entrance. Once inside, a tall brunette wearing a skin-tight dress welcomes us—him—from behind a receptionist’s desk, a sultry smile plastered on her face. She spares me a quick glance, her lips subtly pursing before turning back up.

“Mr. Rykov, welcome,” she says. “How are you today? Dr. Stamos is ready for you.”

I twist in shock to look at him. “Doctor?”

His eyes lower to my height, acknowledging me, before choosing to ignore me. It makes me want to scream.

“Thank you,” he tells her, then points me to the left corridor, hand still on the back of my neck. We pass a few people sitting in the waiting area, and no one looks at us. They’re either on their phones or lost in thought, preoccupied with their own problems.

Nerves swarm in my belly, making my limbs tingle as if ants are scurrying up my veins. Without knocking, Wolfgang opens another door for me, and I swallow hard when I see what’s waiting on the other side.

“No,” I say, stepping back, only to collide with his hard body. “I’m not going in there.”

A man dressed in white—Dr. Stamos, I assume—gets up from his desk and walks toward us.

“Wolfgang. Right on time. Come on in,” he says with a smile. “You must be Victoria.”

I dig my heels into the floor, pushing myself deeper into Wolfgang’s chest, knowing full well I’m probably not getting out of this. Not without doing exactly what I said I wouldn’t—show him how vulnerable I am.

“Don’t make me do this. Please…”

Wolfgang’s chest rumbles as he says, “Keep walking, love. Or we can do this the hard way, if you prefer.”

I don’t know what that means. The doctor keeps staring at us with an expectant smile and when I tilt my head back to look into Wolfgang’s eyes, he’s merely quirking a brow in anticipation.

This or the hard way. This or the hard way.

Cowardly, I swallow hard and take a shy step forward, eyes trained on the gyno chair on the far-left of the room. Dr. Stamos continues to smile, but it does nothing to ease my nerves. Not only have I never had a pelvic exam, but I’m supposed to do it in front of Wolfgang? I stop in the middle of the room, hands wrapped loosely around myself as I hear the door closing behind me.

“Feel free to have a seat,” the doctor says.

The seat, he means.

“C-Can he leave first?” I ask, not daring to look back at Wolfgang’s reaction.

I jolt slightly when he wraps his hand around my chin, twisting my face to see him.

“Get on the chair, Victoria. I’m not leaving. And do not think for a second I’d let another man see what’s mine, doctor or not.”

Scowling, I jerk away from his touch and straighten, approaching the chair before hauling myself up. When I pin Wolfgang down with my stare, his jaw is clenched, and he looks like he’s about to strangle me. A kernel of pride seeps into my chest. I’ll take any small victory I can get against this man.

I sit with my feet dangling a few inches above the floor, hands in my lap, trying my hardest to pretend like Wolfgang isn’t in the room. By the looks of it, he seems to be doing the same. He’s sitting across the cabinet, texting someone on his phone. Heat curls along my body over this entire situation, and I curse him for making me do this.

I hate him so fucking much.

“Is this your first visit to a gynecologist, Victoria?” the doctor asks, getting my attention.

I breathe out, trying to relax. And failing. “Yes.”

“Okay, well, I can imagine you’re probably a bit nervous.” He leans against his desk. “But you have nothing to worry about. My job is to make sure you’re comfortable. Today, we’ll just go over your health, answer any questions you have, and if there’s a medical reason, my colleague, Sabrina, will perform your pelvic exam. Sound good?”

A silent sigh of relief leaves my body. I really shouldn’t need the exam at this stage—I’ve never even had sex with anyone.

“Yes. T-Thank you.”

He then starts by asking me about my periods—if they’re regular, heavy, painful, and so on. Each question makes my face burn hotter, and it’s always followed by another, prolonging the nightmare.

I can tell Dr. Stamos is doing his best to make me feel comfortable, but it's in vain. Even if he's preoccupied with his phone, I know Wolfgang is listening, and the realization of why he brought me here in the first place finally sets in.

I'll be his *wife*. He'll want us to have sex. Of course he will—why wouldn't he?

The thought that my parents just let him take me without so much as saying a word hits me again, making the backs of my eyes burn with tears.

Wolfgang is a monster with no scruples, one that already proved how much he owns me in just the single hour of being in his presence. He's going to do it again, and again, and again, exactly the way he wants, until whatever twisted plan for revenge he has plays out. And I won't be able to do anything about it.

Maybe I should've run away the first chance I got. I still can. I could excuse myself to the bathroom right now and make a jump through the window… get on a bus and… I don't know. Go somewhere he'll never find me.

But they'll die—even if I manage to get away, my parents will die, Anya will die… *Sasha* might die. Wolfgang made it clear that was his intention.

He's got me trapped, and there's absolutely no one on my side.

By the time Sasha finds out I've been taken, Wolfgang will have already married me and caged me in his house. And all my dreams… my goals… everything will be gone. Shattered in the span of a single moment—when he showed up and claimed me like a goddamn prize.

I blink away tears for the thousandth time, focusing my attention back on this awkward appointment.

"And how many sexual partners have you had?" the doctor asks.

I pinch my thumb hard. “I’ve never… none.”

Cheeks flaming red, I glance at Wolfgang to see if he paid attention, but he continues to be absorbed by whatever conversation he’s having on his phone. *Good*.

When I turn back to Dr. Stamos, he’s holding a needle inches away from my arm.

“This will hurt just a little.”

I shrink back. “W-What is this? What are you doing?”

Wolfgang’s head rises from the phone, throwing me a threatening look.

You will stay, he seems to say.

Before I get to tell him to go fuck himself, the needle pokes through my skin, pinching me as Dr. Stamos pushes whatever serum he’s got in there into my arm. My best bet is some form of birth control.

When he’s done, he puts a small band-aid over the area, telling me we’re done.

“Let’s go,” Wolfgang says, standing up.

I let my feet touch the floor and, without saying thank you or looking back, I exit the office before Wolfgang has a chance to grab the back of my neck again.

But he’s right behind me, and I can feel him—feel his presence looming there with every step, and I know if he wanted to, he’d reach for me with his claws, dragging me to him.

So I don’t stop. I don’t turn. I just keep moving, my pulse hammering as I step outside.

The cool air still lingering after the rain does nothing to cool the heat crawling up my spine. Reaching the car parked out front, I get in, and slam the door behind me. Consequences be damned.

***

The rest of the drive is exactly the same as before—silent.

Through the window, the city lights blur past until they disappear entirely and a lone forest road swallows us. This is what Alemont City does: hides the most notorious criminals of this country in a haven that's close enough to New York for them to operate from here, but far enough to stay under the radar.

Wolfgang's home—a *mansion*—is a three-story behemoth of stone, glass, and shadows, with two outstretched wings that make it look like a true fortress. My parents may be rich, but this… this is on a completely different level.

The long, winding driveway snakes beyond two iron gates that open for us with a mechanical hum—eerie and as inviting as a wraith welcoming me to hell. *My* hell.

The car stops, and the driver gets out, but I take a moment to ground myself before I do the same.

"You've got two options," Wolfgang says, and this time, I turn to face those haunting eyes. "You can stay close to me, do as I say, and no one will hurt you. Or… you can pull that shit again and stray away from me like a wildcat. But I am warning you, Victoria, other people in this house will want to harm you."

I scoff, but a chill curls down my spine. People worse than him? I doubt that.

But then again…. I have no idea who they are or what his family is made of, other than the horrifying rumors I've heard. So he could be telling the truth… or he could be trying to manipulate me.

"Wait here," he commands before leaning into the door and exiting the car. I don't get a chance to protest, but it's not like I'm eager to go into that house anyway. All I want is to be away from him.

Except… he doesn't leave. No.

He just stands there, at a short distance, casually texting someone. Keeping me on edge, letting me wonder about his return or his next command.

I hate it.

Minutes pass, and my restlessness grows. I sit with my hands in my lap, pressing down on each of my fingers as a way to self-soothe.

He laughs at something—a low, muffled chuckle—then picks up a call. I watch him stand there and do nothing, and my blood boils, because his waiting game feels like just another way for him to assert his dominance over me. To show me who's in control.

Nostrils flaring, I open the door and slip outside, slamming it a little too loud behind me. Fear beats through my chest for a second, but so what if he heard? Let him see I won't be subjected to his stupid games.

He doesn't turn to face me. Not immediately. Yet I don't fail to notice the way his eyes lift from the phone's screen.

I cross my arms, and in the next moment, he's mere inches away from my face.

My breath leaves my body the moment his hand wraps around my neck and pulls me closer to him. His warm fingers dig into my skin, squeezing a little until I'm wide-eyed and snaking my own hand around his.

Not because I want it to stop, I realize in horror. But because something passes through me, like a shockwave, like a thrill of sorts. And when he hums in agreement with that vibrating voice of his—as if he knows exactly what he's doing to me—another, more shameful part of me responds. And it wants… it wants… I don't know what it is, but it's all I can feel right now.

What the hell is this?

"Oh, love…" He flashes a cunning, knowing smile as I pulse beneath his grip, in terror or in need—or maybe both.

He watches the reaction my body displays for him and I wonder what it looks like from his point of view. I hate showing him I'm this weak.

"I told you to wait, didn't I? Actions have consequences. And your little outbursts so far aren't helping you."

"My *outbursts*?" I raise my eyebrows, anger flaring through me. "Oh, I'm sorry. Did you think I'd make this easy for you after what you've done? Am I supposed to pretend I like being around you because you can't stomach the truth, *Wolfgang*? And what the hell kind of name is that, anyway? Aren't you supposed to be Russian, like the rest of your—"

"There you are," he says, squeezing a little tighter. "I was wondering when you'd bite back. Let me tell you how this is going to go between us. And for your own sake, I hope you're paying attention, because I will not repeat myself. Do you understand?"

I nod as best I can, my pulse hammering.

"The only reason you're still alive right now is because I allow it. Everything you are, and everything you hoped you'd be one day… all of it is mine. I don't need you to pretend you like being here because, frankly, I don't give a fuck. You will stay, and you will obey me, and that will be your life until the day I die."

His grip relaxes, and it's enough to grant me a short inhale before he squeezes again. That same thrill flutters through my body. "Do not anger me, Victoria, because I promise you, you're not prepared to see me like that. Against me, you will lose. Every. Single. Time. That clear?"

I mumble the words I want to say, but they barely come out. He retracts his hand, making me choke as I draw more air into my lungs.

"What's that, love?"

"I said…" I cough again. "Fuck. You."

A low chuckle comes with a smirk as he dusts himself off and turns toward the house, sparing me one more glance.

"Breaking you is going to be fun."

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6

WOLFGANG

Victoria’s sobbing reaches my ears even through the thick wooden door of the new room I locked her in. I expected this to happen and, in fact, I thought she'd break much sooner than this. But she waited until she thought she was alone to finally feel the weight of what happened.

Her cry is deep, sorrowful, *pained*. The kind of cry a good man would do anything in his power to stop by barging in there and cradling her in his arms.

But I’m no good man, and I won’t let it get to me.

I worked too hard to secure my position in this family. And even now, when I carry the responsibility of our legacy on my shoulders, I still sleep with one eye open. I will for the rest of my life. Because I wasn’t lying when I told Victoria we were surrounded by monsters in this house.

They all want something from me, and now that she’s mine, I know for a fact they will try to mess with my plans.

My half-brother wants my crown.

His mother—the woman my father married after my own mother died—has made it her life's goal to make that happen. It started when I was five, and it granted me more trauma than any kid could handle.

To this day, there are times when I wake up wanting to tear my clothes off because they remind me of the snakes, of the rats crawling around the basement she used to lock me in.

No one knew about it. Not my father, who was away or unavailable, especially after Mother's death, nor the old housekeepers, before Corinne was employed. The cunt made sure to ambush me when no one was around.

Still, one day, shaken by a snake bite that left a mark, I told my father. Because I didn't know much back then, but I knew what was happening to me wasn't normal.

He, on the other hand, had other thoughts about the situation.

He said the discipline Ekaterina was teaching me was good for a boy my age. That the darkness would make me stronger. That harder things were coming in my future, and I needed to be prepared.

I'll never forget the sound of my pulse in my eardrums when he said all that. From that moment on, rage made a home in my body. It became my fuel, my companion. My only friend.

It got me to where I am now.

Victoria's cries grow quieter as I walk down the long hallway to the stairwell.

I put her in my wing, where no one can bother her, her room just opposite from mine. The house is large enough that she won't have to meet anyone if she doesn't wander off on her own. But knowing her, it's inevitable. And if I'm being completely honest, I wouldn't mind showing her all the ways in which I could discipline her until she understands she's mine.

A reddish glow stretches across the mahogany floors, following my trail. The sunset has the tree branches bringing their shadows into the house, crawling across the walls that hide memories I hate thinking about.

I was four when a bullet took my mother's life, and all my good memories—the ones where she was here—are starting to fade to black.

Only my name will stay with me forever. Wolfgang. Like her German grandfather, the man who raised her back in Mittenwald before my father found her beauty and dragged her to the States. I should hate this name—it's yet another burden that stands against my throne.

But how could I, when it's the only thing I have left of her?

As I descend the stairs to the ground floor, Corinne smiles at me with a mop in her hands. She stops wiping, mouth opening to say something before it closes again. She wants to ask about Victoria, I can tell.

Despite not being here to see when I brought her home, Corinne has eyes and ears everywhere.

It wasn't part of her job description as head maid and I never asked her to do it, but over the years, she has become my trusted spy in this house.

Even after all her salary increases, I still don't think we're paying her enough to endure all the shit going on around here.

"Should I send some food upstairs?" she asks, framing the question carefully.

"No need. I'll be back in a few hours. Just make sure you save something for her."

"For…"

“Victoria.” I nod. “Her name is Victoria. Don’t let anyone wander too close to her room for now.”

“Of course,” she says, and I know she’ll do exactly that. “Mr. Rykov is in his study, in case you wanted to speak with him.”

“I do. Thank you, Corinne.”

Giving me a final smile, she resumes her work and I cross another hallway to find my father’s office. As always, the door is wide open, so I walk inside.

He’s hunched over his desk, looking at what seems to be the monthly report of how much we sold and how much we laundered. He hates doing it, but he doesn’t trust our accountant after he made an honest mistake last year that cost us a few hundred thousand in taxes—a small amount, but my father doesn’t trust many people these days. Regardless of whether they’ve wronged him or not.

Only his eyes tilt up from beneath his glasses to see me before shifting back to the documents in front of him.

“Is it done?”

I plop down on the chair opposite him, peering outside the window. “You know it is.”

“Mmm. And Nikolai?”

“He got on his knees. I should’ve sent a picture.”

“Yes,” he says, taking off his glasses and finally looking at me fully. “You should have. But I suspect it won’t be the last time he does it. That fucking rat. Throwing parties with my money…” he slowly waves the hand holding his glasses in the air. “Acting like he’s the shit now.”

“Money does that to people. You know firsthand,” I say, hinting at his wife.

Instead of a scowl, he sighs, his lips pressing into a thin line. “What did Katy do now?”

He calls her that—Katy—short for Ekaterina. To me, it’s less of an endearing nickname and more of a sign he’s gotten too old and too tired with her antics to use the full length of her name. But that’s just my guess.

“Other than being her usual self, nothing much.”

He shakes his head. “She’ll want to meet the girl. And so will Mikhail.”

Of course they will. But what he isn’t saying is… they’ll want to have their chance at killing Victoria and messing with my plans. Anything to give Mikhail a shot at claiming my throne. I won’t allow that.

I pin my father down with my stare. “They will. When I decide.”

My father understands his role has changed over the years, especially since I came into the business.

In many ways, I’m the one who steers the ship now, and I have been doing it since before I was of age. It’s what I got for being born with an IQ of 148—that, along with a missed childhood and enough blood on my hands to damn me to hell the moment I take my final breath.

Now, my role is more public since Father appointed me as his *sovetnik*. Which is exactly what pisses Mikhail and Ekaterina off.

“In other news,” I say, “the Irish head is dead. I just got a call.”

Father drums a finger on the table. “Good. We can get the East territories back.”

Good—no sending prayers or anything like that.

The Rykov Bratva is all about seizing power when the opportunity presents itself, and this time is no different. Which is why I already have a plan for making sure the area he's talking about ends up in our books.

"Take Mikhail with you," Father adds, anticipating where I'm going next—to The Hive. The place for making deals and bringing people to your side. The place where many wars have started and ended in a bloodbath. "Give him something to do. You know what he's like when he gets bored."

I snort. "Because giving a viper a seat at the table has never backfired before."

"That was a long time ago, and he was too young to understand his role. Take him. I don't want to see you two fighting anymore."

Yeah, right, as if it's that easy.

His mother made sure to poison him against me when we were kids.

He's never liked me and taking him with me now isn't going to change that. I'm surprised he hasn't tried to kill me yet.

Still, there's one reason why I'm tempted to do what Father says.

I'd rather Mikhail come with me than remain under the same roof with my soon-to-be wife. And if all I have to do is pretend I care about his involvement in the alliance I plan on making tonight, then fine.

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7

VICTORIA

Mountains pierce the forest around the estate, standing tall, guarding in the quiet of the night. Eyes swollen from the hours of incessant ugly crying, I stand perched on the window frame, watching the nothingness that is now my life.

How did I end up here? One moment I was preparing to buy plane tickets for Europe, the next I'm taken like a sack of gold. Not even gold, actually, since no one tried to keep me.

I should've let him kill all of us. I can only imagine what his revenge is going to look like from now on. And he's just getting started.

I know I should be better—Sasha taught me better than to mop in my misery. *There's always a solution to every problem*, he used to say, and I used to believe it. God, I used to think I was on top of everything… that I was going to leave this city, this country, and show everyone I can do whatever I set my mind to.

But right now, heartbroken over my family's betrayal and utterly alone in this monstrous new world, I'm starting to realize just how human Sasha is,

like the rest of us. He doesn't have all the answers… and he still has hope for things that might never come true.

Hope… what a dangerous thing to hold on to.

Pressing the heels of my palms against my closed eyes, I exhale the rest of my energy for tonight. I haven't even turned on the light since Wolfgang locked me in here. I needed to let the night swallow me, to make it feel like everything was just a bad dream.

But after hours of being alone, my stomach is grumbling, and my fear is returning to replace the sadness. Because that's all I've felt today—fear and sadness—and it's a far cry from what I was hoping to experience on my birthday.

Pushing into the window frame, I turn to face my new prison for the first time.

A king-sized bed against the wall fills most of the room. Around it, a walk-in closet holds silhouettes of clothes, and there's also a vanity desk with drawers and a chair. Attached to the space is an en-suite bathroom I haven't entered.

Crossing my arms loosely around myself, I take a few aimless steps around the room, not knowing what to do with myself. There's nothing here other than bare necessities.

Just for good measure, I approach the door and twist the knob to see if it's still locked. A jolt of anxiety traverses my chest at seeing that it is, and I hit the light switch on the nearest wall, suddenly afraid of the dark. But it doesn't help—in fact, it only makes things worse because seeing glimpses of my cage in the light makes this whole thing real.

And it makes me want to scream.

I flip the switch back off and trudge to the vanity desk, opening up the drawer. I've never done this before, but if I could find a hairpin, maybe I can open the door.

And go where? What will you do?

"Shut the hell up," I tell myself between clenched teeth.

My hands fumble through the makeup inside, touching glass containers, brushes, and tubes of probably mascara or lipstick. I toss them to the side, digging, hoping this isn't everything there is, until a low, prolonged whistle makes me halt.

Slowly, I straighten up, eyes wide and as silent as I can be.

It's that feeling again—the one of being hunted, of being looked at by a predator in the shadows—that seizes my survival instinct.

"H-Hello?" I say, my voice dry and exhausted from all the crying. "Who's there?"

Again, the two-note whistle spears the silence of my confinement, making the hairs on the back of my neck stand up.

Somehow, it sounds like it's coming from all around me and nowhere simultaneously. I step back, hearing it again through the wall behind me.

There are others who will want to harm you.

Maybe Wolfgang wasn't lying. Maybe he did me a kindness by locking my door tonight.

Another whistle, long and ghostly, sends my heartbeat into overdrive.

I walk backward until my thighs touch the bed frame and I haul myself up as I pull the covers from beneath me. I don't tear my eyes away from the

emptiness of the room for a single moment.

The door is locked. The door is locked, and you're on the second floor, I remind myself over and over as I sit on the mattress and curl up, taking the silky sheets over my head. They smell rich, clean, and I inhale voraciously, using the scent to ground me through the moment. It doesn't work. The whistles continue to flow seamlessly with what sounds like a slightly amused lilt.

I lie in the dark for what feels like hours, listening and not reacting, hoping once again that this is all just a nightmare I'll wake up from in the morning.

WOLFGANG

When I get back home, it's well after midnight.

The house looks dark and quiet from the outside and my eyes go straight to the second floor, where Victoria is waiting. Ruminating, maybe.

Her light is off, but the curtains are drawn, telling me she inspected her surroundings. Where is she now? Is she sleeping peacefully, trying to escape her new reality until dawn? Or is she still up, banging her fists against the door of her enclosure?

She was all I could think about on the way back and during the meetings at The Hive. Ever since we met, the image of her has been spreading through my mind like wildfire, leaving no corner untouched. I expected it. She's my new toy, after all. Anyone else in my position would obsess over her.

I head inside, making a beeline for her room and unlocking the door.

Upon entering, I'm hit with the faint scent of lilies, of something sweet and feminine that's inherently hers. I inhale, laughing to myself. She's only been here for a couple of hours, and this cursed house is already affected by her presence. If the circumstances had been different, I wonder what she'd have done with the rest of us.

I also wonder what she'd do if I fucked her pussy raw tonight.

My cock twitches, hardening at the thought. There she is, partially hidden under the covers, her body a small bump in the middle of the bed. As I approach her sleeping figure, more parts come into view: her hunched shoulders, as if she's afraid of something even in her dreams, the small crease between her brows, the pouty, parted lips… I could have her wake up with my cock between them. I could spread my cum across their rosy color like a fucking lip balm.

The thought is intoxicating.

She's shackled to my bed, to my will, my strength. It would be easy to ruin her now, if easy was what I wanted. But it's not.

I want the moment she begs me to take her. I want her to hate herself for wanting me. And I want the world to see that reflected in her behavior—how much she needs the man who ruined her father, how much she craves him like a good, obedient girl.

That's when I'll take her.

Consummating my marriage was never in my plan. In fact, *Victoria* was never in my plan. I was supposed to take her sister, Nikolai's golden progeny. And I was going to drag her with me everywhere I went, flaunt her as my possession, maybe wrap a pretty collar around her neck. But that was all.

Then I met Victoria. And something about her—maybe her raw, unfiltered honesty, maybe the wound we both seem to share, maybe her feisty yet

sweet demeanor—drew me to her. A rare event, since nothing ever gets to me these days.

I've experienced more than the average person could experience in a hundred lifetimes. I also fucked as much as I wanted, had everything I needed in the palm of my hand. But the way this woman responded to my touch at her birthday party—afraid, yet daring, challenging… The way she stands up to me with her little acts of defiance… It woke me up from a slumber so deep, there's no going back.

So I changed the fucking plan.

I don't just want Victoria to be my puppet. I'm making it my mission to bend that feistiness until it bows to me. Until she recognizes me as her new master, willing and pleading for all that I could give her. I can't fucking wait.

I crack the muscles in my neck, releasing some of the tension, then take a seat next to her limp body. She whimpers, trapped in some dream, and it's the sweetest fucking sound I've ever heard.

I brush a strand of hair away from her face. She stirs, and while I focus on how soft she feels under my hands, her eyelashes flutter. Confusion etches on her pretty face as she looks around, probably trying to figure out where she is. When the realization dawns on her, she sucks in a breath, catches my gaze, and jolts upright, supporting her body on her arms as she tries to get away.

"I didn't take you just to kill you," I say. "You're safe."

For now.

She shakes her head, tears pooling in her baby-blue eyes before she blinks them away. One of them still escapes to her cheek. It makes my cock harden further, and my hand instinctively reaches out to wipe it away. Not because I want to soothe her, but because I need to taste it on my tongue, even if I

don’t end up doing it. I don’t yet want her to know how much I want to take from her.

Let her wonder, let her try to anticipate my needs, my moods. Let her come to her own conclusions slowly, in time.

“It was y-you. Wasn’t it?” she asks, her voice mellow, timid, still laced with sleep.

I frown. “I don’t follow.”

“The whistling. You were trying to scare me.” She tears her gaze away from me, bringing her knees to her chest. Her camisole strap falls to her shoulder—one of the many I filled her dresser with prior to her arrival—revealing the top of her breast. My fucking mouth waters.

“If I wanted to scare you, I’d employ much more enjoyable methods. Besides, I was out all evening.”

“All evening? Then who… who was it? What the *hell* is this place?!”

“What happened, Victoria? I can’t help you if I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

She scoffs, as if she doesn’t believe I actually want to help her. But in this case, I do. She’s my possession now. Mine. No one else gets to torment her but me.

“All night, someone was out there, whistling. It was creepy, and loud, and it wouldn’t stop. And I thought… I thought you were trying to mess with me.”

Of course. *Fucking Mikhail.*

That’s why I couldn’t find him anywhere to take him with me to The Hive. He pretended to be out already, when in fact, he was here, waiting to prey on my soon-to-be-wife. Knowing him and his motives, I knew this would

happen eventually. But this was the first goddamn night. I didn't think I'd have to impose myself so quickly.

"It wasn't me. Sorry it bothered you."

Her head shakes in what looks like disbelief.

"I warned you, didn't I? About the others."

"Don't paint yourself into a savior when *you're* the one who brought me here in the first place—"

I wrap my hand around the back of her head, grabbing her hair and pulling a little so she tilts. So she looks at me.

Her breath hitches. And that same flicker of thrill goes through her like it did earlier, when she got out of the car against my explicit order. I can see it in the way her body slackens, in the way her breathing pattern changes. If she were afraid, she'd try to get away. She's not. No… she just doesn't understand how this action makes her feel. I have so many delicious things to teach her.

"I'm the only one you can rely on here. So if you were smart, you'd choose your battles carefully. And you *are* smart, aren't you, Victoria?"

She keeps silent, but I can see the anger, the defiance swimming in her eyes.

The corner of my mouth lifts. "That's what I thought."

I release her, forcing myself to get up. As much as I'd love to keep taunting her for the rest of the night, I need to focus on the rest of the plan. It started with her, and it will end with her, but everything in between, I need a clear mind to take care of that.

"I'll have Corinne bring you something to eat."

“I don’t need your food. Or anything else you have.”

I quirk a brow. “Isn’t that one of the camisoles I bought you?”

“I had no choice.”

“Sleeping naked was a choice. You chose not to do that.”

“So you could pry on me all night? No, thanks.”

“I could get you naked and on your knees right now if I wanted to, love. That sheer layer of clothing means nothing. I’m sure you already know that.”

She snorts an incredulous laugh that I don’t buy. Our dynamic is clear, even if she refuses to accept it. I call the shots. She does what I want.

“You’ll get your food, and you’ll eat it. Be ready in the morning. I’ll be here to get you.”

Her brows furrow. “What? Where are you taking me?” A pause. “Wherever it is, I don’t want to come.”

I don’t bother to reply to that. What she wants is irrelevant. Besides, there will never be a good time for her to meet the others, so we might as well do it tomorrow and get it over with. I leave her room, locking the door behind me. Enjoying the feeling of having her trapped again. Of knowing she’ll depend on me from now on.

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8

WOLFGANG

W: Hiding from me after what you did, huh?

I text Mikhail as I look for him throughout the house. He's not in the other wing, not in his room, and no one seems to have seen him.

It's what he does.

He likes to lurk in the shadows, to make you chase him. He disappears, sometimes for weeks, hanging out with his group of misfits and causing chaos wherever they go.

Only when he gets bored does he ever come out. And when he does, he's twice as destructive, twice as difficult to keep in line. Nothing seems to touch a nerve with him, no matter how many things I threw in his face over the years or how many fights we've had. Instead, he smirks, amuses himself at the world around him, like we're all puppets in whatever world he conjured for himself in his head.

He's a dangerous man. And I'm not going to let his behavior with Victoria slide by.

My phone buzzes in my hand, getting my attention.

M: How could I be hiding if I'm right behind you?

I turn, anger flaring through me at the sight of him. He's smirking, leaning against the door frame with his arms crossed.

I stalk toward him, his brows rising in pure delight. I don't think about it. I simply pull my arm back and punch his jaw, a chuckle escaping him after the impact.

"Stay the fuck away from her. Let her be, or next time I hear she's upset over your stupid games, it won't end with one punch."

He straightens himself up, touching his jaw. "It's so fun to see you pussy-whipped."

"You think I got her just to fuck her?"

"Nah. We both know why she's really here. But you want this woman for more than that, don't you? She's pretty, got that fire in her veins. Who knows, maybe she'll be the one to ruin you, and I won't have to."

I step forward, and he doesn't retreat. He looks like he could take another punch, and my fingers itch to make his wish come true.

"You want to ruin me, Mikhail? Then get in line. Or, better yet…" I shrug. "Do something about it. Because the way it's looking out right now, I'm winning. You're lost in the fucking crowd."

I pin him down with my gaze a moment longer, then walk away, his voice carrying over to me one last time.

"Careful, brother. Danger hits harder when it's hiding in plain sight."

Back in my wing, I pass by Victoria's bedroom door, dragging a hand down my face.

My sweet little captive comes back to the front of my mind. And suddenly, my cock starts throbbing against my pants, hard and fucking angry at the denial I've enforced on it.

The image of her crying, the camisole strap fallen off her shoulder… *Christ*. I expected her to be beautiful, but not like this. She looked so soft, so serene under the pale moonlight, giving me a glimpse of her breast.

She's ravishingly perfect, and the fact that no other man has touched her makes me even more restless. She's mine, and I get to be the first one—the *only* one—who taints her innocence.

She thinks I'm too much now? Well, she won't be thinking that when she's bouncing on my cock, riding me like the good little equestrian she is.

One day soon, I'll be her undoing, and she'll be stretching her holes for me in offering before I even have to ask.

I barge into my room across the hallway, shutting the door behind me with a loud bang.

My palm slaps against the nearest wall, and I rush to take my cock out with the hand I used to swipe the tear off her cheek. I wish I'd tasted her then, but I didn't, so I could prove a point. She means nothing to me, and her only purpose in all of this is to secure my position against my—

Fuck!

I grunt, stroking my length with harsh, sudden movements, feeling the tendrils of pleasure crawl down my spine and shoot to my cock. I think of her tongue wrapped around me, of her virgin pussy squeezing me tight as I fill her up with all the cum she can take.

Such a good girl—she can be such a good girl for me. And she can be feisty, and I like them both.

“Fucking hell, Victoria,” I mutter, gripping my cock tighter, increasing my pace. “Look what you’re making me do.”

Embarrassingly enough, a few more strokes are all it takes before cum spurts into my fist, coating my hand, smearing the crotch of my slacks. My chest rises and lowers with exhausted breaths as I rush to rid my mind of her image again.

What a nuisance.

I unbutton my shirt, taking off my clothes on the way to the en-suite bathroom. The water is ice cold when I turn on the shower, and I don’t wait until it warms up to walk under the stream. My chest expands further, the coolness pouring down my hot skin doing nothing to regulate my breathing.

At least I can think again.

Minutes pass, and my skin begins to tingle from the severity of the temperature, keeping me grounded to the present. Eventually, I step out, using a towel to shake the excess water from my hair.

The sight of the wall I leaned against minutes ago brings back a flood of blood to my groin, making my cock swell. I clench my jaw, turning to the bed instead, shoving myself under the covers. I can only hope the memory of my soon-to-be wife doesn’t follow me into my dreams.

***

The next morning, I unlock Victoria’s room, expecting to see her either in bed or getting ready for the day. But the bed is empty, the sheets barely rumpled, as if she woke up in the middle of the night and fled.

Impossible, of course, since I locked her up myself. I leave the door open and peer into the attached bathroom, but there's no sign of her.

What the fuck?

The windows are closed, and there's no way she could've made the jump. And if she *did* jump, she'd have a broken spine, leg, or arm, at the very least.

There's no way she'd make it out of the property without one of my men seeing her and alerting me during the night. The only possible conclusions are, either somebody let her out… or she's hiding right here, in plain sight.

I smile, pretty confident with the latter.

"Good morning, love. You can come out now."

Still, nothing.

I move around the room, looking for places she'd be able to hide—under the bed, behind her vanity desk, the walk-in closet, and so on.

"Aren't you a little old to be playing these kinds of games? Come out, Victoria. You're not a child." I sigh, pulling the curtains to the side, letting the sunshine in.

Annoyance making its way to my clenching jaw, I walk over to the bathroom to check behind the cupboard there. But maybe she really isn't here. Maybe Mikhail played me and somehow got the key from Corinne, then let her out. Maybe—

A sharp, almost blinding pain pokes through the side of my abdomen, twisting with obvious hate. Tendrils of blood seep out, making a warm spot on my shirt. Flinching, I look down to see a small but polished glass shard lodged in my skin. Around it, a slender, manicured hand comes into view before it retracts almost as quickly as it struck me.

“I belong to no one,” Victoria says, seething, from her hideaway behind the bathroom door. “And I will win—against you, or anyone. My fucking *name* proves it, dickhead.”

Before I get any time to react, she whooshes past me, her rushed steps traversing the bedroom and exiting through the door I left open.

Alone and bewildered, I continue to look at the shard, and a laugh erupts from somewhere deep in my chest as I register what just happened.

She stabbed me. She fucking stabbed me.

The pain grows and sharpens with each shake of my shoulders. I pull the glass out of my side with one swift movement and toss it to the white bathroom tiles, sprinkling some of my blood around its perimeter.

“Someone woke up in a bad mood,” I muse.

Shaking my head, I walk out into the hallway, trying to figure out which way she ran. The house is so massive it’s practically a maze, and it would literally take me hours to find her… if I hadn’t already noticed a faded, bloodied print on the right wall beside me. In her frenzy, it’s very unlikely she realized her mistake. So I take in her direction, patient but steady because I know she’s headed toward a dead end.

I push open every door in my path, and for the most part, they’re empty bedrooms. Two of them, however, lead to Corinne’s suite. It’s breakfast time, so she’s probably downstairs, setting the table and directing the other staff like she does every morning. Which means Victoria could’ve easily snuck in there and not get busted by her.

And sure enough, when I open the door and peer inside, my pretty little war prize is on the floor with a phone at her ear, turning in horror to realize she’s been caught.

“So I get stabbed in the back, and someone else gets a sweet phone call? You’re hurting my feelings, Victoria,” I say with false sympathy as I rush to

her side, snatching the phone from her.

“Fuck. *You*!” she yells, standing up, scratching at me with her nails.

I back away, putting the phone to my ear, but hearing no one from the other end. “Who did you speak to?”

“Wouldn’t you like to know!”

I snort, looking at her petite figure, at the way her pretty blue eyes shine with hate and anger. I’ll find out anyway. And when I do, I’ll make sure they’re fucking dead.

Victoria leaps past me, but I wrap my arm around her just in time to catch her midway. I pull her to me, my wound contracting, sending pain everywhere in my body. She gouges at my arm with her nails, puncturing skin, drawing more blood. Smirking through her small victories.

I take a few steps forward with her still thrashing in my arms, then throw her on the bed.

“Enough.”

I tower over her, gripping both wrists above her head. With my other hand, I circle her throat, forcing her to stay still and look at me. Jaw clenched, she bares her teeth, pushing her hips up abruptly, trying to sway me off her. But I’m not going anywhere.

Her body rubs against mine, dragging a deep groan from me when I feel her plump pussy through the thin material of her panties. She’s wearing her birthday dress from yesterday, but it’s ridden up, exposing her to me.

Without thinking, I start rocking into her, gliding my hard-on against her spread-out slit. A soft moan whispers in my ear, and I swear to fucking God she’s arching into me. It’s shy, and barely noticeable, but my cock feels every stroke of her sweet pussy against it.

“Giving up already? I thought winning was in your name.” I lower my head to lick the side of her neck, feeling her pulse pound against my tongue. So fragile.

I bring my lips closer, leaving a soft bite that I know will leave a bruise. My cock grows harder, and she whimpers, resuming her thrashing under my weight. The movement makes her chest expand and her breasts brush against me. She sags again, eyes fluttering closed, her knees parting wider, giving me more access.

“It would be so easy to pull your panties to the side and fuck you raw. Is your pussy nice and wet? Hmm?”

“Oh—” She pants, her hands no longer pushing against mine.

I squeeze her throat, enough for her to open her eyes and acknowledge who’s rubbing her pretty cunt. I want her to know it’s me. Want her to realize she’s letting me take whatever I want from her, even if I choose not to.

“Wolfg—”

“Yes, it’s me, Victoria. And I’m going to make you come.”

I rock into her deeper, longer, ignoring the pull of my own pleasure—of my impending release—as I loosen my grip on her throat and let her sweet little moans fill the air. I laugh to myself realizing there’s another thing she and I have in common.

Because here I am, stabbed and bleeding with my cock pressed against her, and here she is, breathless with her neck bearing the marks of my possession. Pain brings people closer, and it seems ours keeps twisting like two lovers’ fingers lacing together for the first time.

Then her legs twitch around my body, and her sensitive pussy remains still, taking my strokes like a good little plaything. Her face scrunches, eyes fluttering closed, a throttled cry echoing in my ear as she arches her back away from the mattress beneath her. I release my grip on her wrists, bringing

my hand between us, pulling her panties to the side and touching the proof of her arousal. She moans louder, head twisting to the side, hair spread out in all directions. She's so fucking erotic right now, coming undone by my hand. I can't help but praise her.

"You are exquisite. And this pussy—" I push my finger against her entrance, "*Christ.* Look at the mess you made all over my hand."

My last words seem to wake her up from her trance. She pushes her hands into my chest with a puff, and I let her, rolling to the side so she can get up. And when she does, her baby-blue eyes are thunderous—no longer hooded, no longer hiding beneath the veil of pleasure she was so desperate to lose herself into just moments ago. She's all flushed, pink cheeks, swollen lips, and all.

"This changes *nothing.*" She huffs, pulling a fallen strap back up on her shoulder.

I stand up, dusting myself off as I face her and smile. "You're right. It doesn't. You'll still be my wife, and you'll continue to drip on my fingers like a needy little slut."

She throws me a cold smile in return.

"You forgot the part where I'll never love you."

"I've been hated all my life, Victoria. It's what I know. In fact, the only way you might be able to get my guard down is if you did, somehow, end up loving me."

She scoffs, and it's all the confirmation I need.

"That's what I thought. Now, tell me, love… who the *fuck* did you call?"

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9

VICTORIA

I promised myself I'd kill this man. Maybe not today, maybe not tomorrow, but one day, when his guard is down, I'll stab him somewhere else—somewhere he can curse me for even in death.

I glance down at his wound, but no more blood is coming out. I guess I wasn't strong enough to push it deeper inside.

My eyes snap back to his. To the feral look on his face that was just inches away from mine a minute ago. My cheeks heat instantly, remembering what he did to me… what I *let* him do to me.

I gulp. "No one. You got here before I managed to call."

"No one," he echoes, smiling with that usual collected smile of his that sends a shiver down my spine. I take a step back as he says, "I'll give you one more chance to tell me the truth. Because if I ask Corinne to unlock her phone and tell me the last number that was dialed, I promise you, Victoria, whoever was on the other line is not living to see another fucking day."

"You'd kill them anyway! Even if I told you."

“That depends.”

“On what…?”

“On how sweetly you beg me not to.”

I exhale, looking to the side as I retreat to the safety of my mind. It was stupid to call Sasha, I know that now. I put his life in danger, not thinking Wolfgang would threaten with something like this. I thought… I thought he’d take it out on me, which I would’ve been fine with.

Dread envelops me, making me wrap my arms loosely around my waist. “Don’t touch him,” I say, my voice reduced to almost a whisper. “Please.”

He quirks a brow. “Him?”

“My riding instructor…”

“You got access to a phone, and you could’ve called anyone else, but picked Sasha Kasparov? Why is that, love?”

I shake my head. “It doesn’t matter. I told you the truth. Now give me your word you won’t hurt him.”

“My word—is that something you’d trust?”

No. But what other option do I have?

“Well… can I? Or is that notion completely foreign to men like you?”

He steps forward, gripping my chin between his thumb and index finger. I can smell my arousal on his skin. And the way he looks at me—with amusement dancing in his eyes—tells me he knows.

“Yes, Victoria. When I make a promise to you, you can trust that I won’t go back on it. I told you, I’m your only ally now. The sooner you start believing it, the better it will be for you.”

I nod once, trying to ignore the burn of his touch on my skin. “So promise me, then. Promise me you won’t hurt or kill him.”

“That’s a demand, not a plea.”

“I asked nicely.”

“And I said I’d do it if you begged.”

“Go to hell.”

He waits in silence, tilting his head slightly. He’s not going to let this go, but I won’t let Sasha get hurt over my pride, no matter how much I hate asking this man for anything.

“Please,” I say, closing my eyes. “Please promise me.”

Another moment of silence, of my cortisol going through the roof as he considers it. I open my eyes as he lets go of my chin, watching me. “No, Victoria. I’m afraid that’s not enough. You’ll have to get on your knees.”

My lips part. “You… you really are an asshole.”

“Lose the dress,” he orders.

More heat floods my cheeks. “What?”

“I said… strip. Get on your knees. You want Sasha to live? I want to see what’s mine. Do it, or don’t, but I won’t repeat myself.”

I stand, bewildered, struggling to find a way out of this. In his fucked-up way, this is Wolfgang offering me a choice. My dignity… or Sasha's life. Only because I was stupid enough to call him. And maybe because I'm desperate to take some of my power back, or because he really is playing me like a violin, I square off my shoulders and forcefully pull the straps of my dress down, one by one. I watch him with a scowl as I do it, wanting him to know it's me who called this shot, as pathetic as it is. The material slips down my body, and I let it, let it pool around my feet.

Here I am again, facing him with my arms crossed, reminiscent of the day I met him—only now we're alone, I'm almost naked, and there really isn't anyone to save me. *There never was.* He's still so much taller, and I'm highly aware of the way he's analyzing me.

"Happy?" I ask.

He shakes his head slowly, extending a hand out to me.

Nostrils flaring, I give him mine in return, because the sooner he leaves me alone, the better. His touch burns, and for a beat, it makes me forget who I am and who he is, as if some sort of spell envelops the moment. And it makes me feel things… things I should be negating, but for some reason I don't. Shame laps at me.

I don't realize he's lifting my arm in the air until I'm suddenly spinning in place, like we're in the middle of a slow dance with only my loud heartbeat as music.

"Good girl," he whispers, every syllable drawn out, dripping with satisfaction.

A throb begins somewhere between my legs, mimicking my pulse. It's wanting. Wanting… I don't know what, but I know it has everything to do with the man in front of me. When I turn my back to him, he releases my hand, and it falls to my side. I don't know what to do with it.

“Who do you belong to?” he asks from behind me.

“No one,” I murmur. “I’m not an object or a pet you can own.”

“A pet. Hmm, I like that.”

He hooks his fingers behind the lace of my panties, and I suck in a breath.

“F-Fuck you, Wolfgang.”

“We’ll get to that.”

He pulls at the material with cruel delicacy.

I shudder.

Then his hands are on me, on my hips, roaming but touching nothing other than my thighs, then my calves, as he drags down those panties.

Everywhere his fingers brush creates goosebumps in their wake. My panties follow his motion until they, too, pool at my feet.

Cruel, so cruel and so inviting that touch is. It awakens something inside me, something I recognize even though I’ve never felt it before. What a primal thing. What a primal, wicked thing.

I feel him stand back up.

“So pretty,” he muses, his voice rumbling above me, grave and laced with the kind of confidence only owning something could give you. “Who do you belong to?”

His index finger slides up my naked thigh, and I close my eyes, realizing I’m wet again. And it’s that spot right there, at my most sensitive part, that begs me quietly for friction.

“N-No one.”

A low, patient growl tickles my ears. “So unbelievably stubborn,” he drawls. “Even so, I picked you. I wanted you.”

I conjure the question in my mind—the question of why—because I don’t understand his motives. But I can’t make up words or think straight.

All I can do is stand here and feel the way he feels me with his scarred hands, as if I’m in some sort of trance. Another slow, deliberate caress across my thigh has my body melting, and I instinctively lean into him. *Fuck*.

“Get on your knees, Victoria.”

“Isn’t this enough already…?”

His body collides with mine—his… dressed, and mine… fully naked—and I feel the hard bulge in his pants pressing against my ass cheeks.

What would it feel like? I wonder for just a second, heat traveling down to my pussy. I’m… wet. Wet for this man—this stranger—and I have absolutely no ammo to defend myself with.

But I’m thrown right out of that thought when his knee pushes against the back of mine until it bends and I’m dropping to the floor. Wolfgang steps in front of me, and I have to crane my neck fully to see him for all he is: a monster, even if he never looks like one.

I cover my breasts with my arm, exhaling when his hand brushes my hair, caressing it in slow, deliberate movements. The other one comes under my chin, holding me in place as he looms above me.

“If you make me suck you, I’ll bite off your cock,” I find myself saying.

His eyebrows rise. “Haven’t we decided you were smart? Don’t worry, though. When you wrap those pretty lips around my cock, you’ll be begging me for it with your tongue out.”

“You’re disgusting. And completely out of your mind if you think I’ll ever __”

Without warning, he shoves two fingers into my mouth, and I’m suddenly full of him. I fumble to stand, but he keeps me in place, pushing down into my shoulder. His fingers slide deeper inside, almost to the back of my throat, making me want to gag. When I’m on the verge of actually doing it, he retracts them, then repeats the motion.

“Have you ever even had a cock in your mouth?” he asks, sounding bored. “Look at you, drooling all over yourself.”

A high-pitched whimper escapes my throat, and my thighs press closer together, seeking friction. What is he doing to me? And why do I want him to keep doing it? I stare up at him, noticing the way his eyes have hooded, contradicting his disinterested tone.

“Such a good girl for me,” he says, stretching his fingers across the entirety of my tongue until I’m forced to open my mouth. Drool slides past my lips and onto my chin, mimicking the arousal leaking out of my pussy.

His fingers leave my mouth completely, and I inch forward out of pure inertia. What the hell just happened between us?

“You have my word,” he says, the spell now broken. “I won’t harm Sasha.”

I’m stunned at the ease of his promise, at the willingness of it. But of course, I take it. I rush to say, “N-neither you, nor your family or *anyone* working for you.”

His mouth twitches upward. “I promise.”

Relief whooshes past my parted lips, giving me the courage to push for more.

“Why did you take me? What will happen to me here?”

“Ah,” he drawls. “A little greedy, aren’t we? When I ask you questions, you don’t answer. And yet you expect me to be open with you.”

That’s fair, I guess. Still, I don’t want him to know anything about me. He’s already seen me naked and made me… come… but at least I still have agency over who I am. Over what I choose to reveal to him about myself. And maybe I could use it to my advantage somehow.

His gaze drops to his wound and I take the opportunity to take my dress off the floor and slip into it again. When I’m done, I follow him with my eyes, noticing the patch of blood gleaming at the side of his abdomen.

“You should get that checked out,” I say.

The curiosity with which he’s watching me morphs into something like disappointment or frustration over not getting any information out of me, like he probably hoped. Igniting this feeling in him makes my chest flutter with pride.

His expression changes once more, hitting me with that casual, carefree look he usually has plastered on his face.

“So thoughtful of you. And here I was, thinking you wanted to murder me.”

I scoff, and he grabs the back of my neck, gentle but dominant, like a master walking his pet out of the room. Tendrils of heat flood my most intimate parts, and I swallow, careful not to let him see how much it affects me.

“W-Where are we going?”

“*We* aren’t going anywhere. I’m taking you back to your room, and then I have business to take care of.”

I twist my neck to see him as we walk down the hallway. “Last night, you said we were going somewhere this morning. I don’t want to be stuck in that room anymore.”

“Well, that’s too bad, love. If you’re going to act like a wildcat, you’ll be locked in a cage until you learn to purr.”

“You’re delusional if you think I’ll ever play your stupid fucking game.”

He brings me past the doorsill of my room, then releases the hold on my neck.

“You’re already in my game, Victoria. And unless you haven’t noticed, all you do is lose.”

***

Wolfgang doesn’t come back for the next week and a half, keeping me on edge about his return.

I wonder if he stitched up the wound. I wonder if it left him a scar to remember. I hope it did. Almost every night, the whistling continues, keeping me up when my eyes are closing from exhaustion. I wake up groggy and sad, my new reality settling in brick by brick. And I have absolutely nothing to do all day—bastard hasn’t even left me a book to read or a TV to watch.

I’m stuck in this room, watching the mountains stretch in the distance. The trees are getting greener, the grass taller, and the birds louder.

Summer is almost here, and I’m stuck in this room instead of being out there, riding a horse through the meadows until my aching thighs force me

to stop. I've avoided thinking about it much because I refused to think I'd never get the chance to ride again. But after these past few days, I'm starting to believe that might actually be the case. And I'd be lying if I said it wasn't crushing me.

The key twists in my door, and I perk my head up from my camel yoga pose on the floor, seeing a tray of food come in first.

"Good morning," I rush to say, embarrassed at how excited I get over the smallest things now—like seeing anyone other than my own reflection in the mirror. "How are you today?"

Corinne barely looks my way before placing the covered tray on my vanity desk.

Taking off the lid is another one of the few things I look forward to. It's the thrill of finding out what I'm eating for breakfast—will I get a dessert or just my macros today? She never answers. In fact, she hasn't uttered a single word to me over the past few days other than telling me her name.

She looks like a kind person, so I'm tempted to think she's just following orders. Which would make sense… if Wolfgang wanted to punish me for lashing out at him.

In a way, the situation reminds me of the maids we had at home, of the food they used to prepare to please my sister. She was the picky eater, I was not. I took whatever they gave us and never complained. It made me invisible. So much so that when I did ask for something different—strawberry, instead of blueberry jam for my pancakes—they threw accusations in my face for making their lives hard.

I cried that night, under my covers, because I couldn't understand what I'd done wrong. I was a child.

I sigh, a flicker of the same familiar sadness I carry with me pulsing through my chest.

“I’m sorry,” I say, noticing the way she quickly glances at me. “I’ve been trying to get to know you since, you know, we kind of see each other every day. But it’s clear something is preventing you from speaking to me. I’m just feeling really lonely, and… anyway, yeah, I’m sorry, and it won’t happen again. Thanks for the food.”

For a short moment, her face relaxes with a timid smile, but she remains silent as she pours milk into my coffee.

Tears form at the backs of my eyes, so I get up from the floor and walk to the bathroom. Closing the door behind me, I slide down to the floor again, covering my eyes with my palms as my shoulders shake with quiet sobs.

I’m so alone right now. So unbelievably alone.

I haven’t heard from anyone back home, including Sasha, even though I briefly explained things over the phone.

Turns out my parents hadn’t even told him, and since he was traveling for the riding tournaments, he hadn’t heard from anyone else either. But what can he do about it? On his own, he’s no match for the Rykov Bratva. And like me, Sasha is almost always by himself.

I cry into my palms, my throat swelling with pain, eyes burning from the salt in my tears. Corinne must be long gone by now, so I don’t bother muffling my voice anymore.

Sitting there, on the cold bathroom floor, for what feels like forever, I break until my eyes dry out and my body resumes its normal breathing pattern.

When I finally get up, I crawl back into bed, even though I just recently woke up.

What’s the point of staying awake, anyway?

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10

WOLFGANG

The tattooed man in front of me drums his fingers on his whiskey glass. “Ten percent,” he says, the Albanian accent sharp on his tongue.

I nod slowly, absently, looking to the side, then back at him. “Like I said, it’s five percent or none. We’ve already secured enough deals to move forward without you.”

“What’s there to say I can’t get more from the Italians?”

“You can try. But by the time you meet with them, we’ll already own the territory. Do with this information what you will.”

As the Albanian Mafia head ponders with his decision, I look behind his shoulder at the two men coming in. Politicians.

Senator Maddox Thorne, campaigning for president, stands next to Rowan King. High up in the military, he’s the man you call when everything goes wrong. He doesn’t seem bothered by the scrutiny he’s received lately over his involvement in the government. To me, he looks like someone who owns his decisions. And I can respect that.

The Hive is the only place where someone like me and the Albanian can be under the same roof with people like them.

It's an exclusive gentlemen's club in New York City, where our positions don't matter other than to grant us an invitation to join. Once you're in, you're here to do business, so all your disdain remains outside.

My phone vibrates in my pocket, and I take it out, seeing a message from Corinne.

I told her to text me if Victoria was giving her a hard time, but I haven't heard from her till now. Keeping my phone under the table, I peer down to read what she sent.

C: sorry to bother you

C: she hasn't eaten anything today

C: thought you might wanna know

I frown, my attention completely on this conversation now.

W: Why? Is she sick?

The bubble letting me know she's typing keeps staring back at me, and I feel myself getting restless.

C: seemed okay this morning but don't think she left her bed since

Now why would feisty Victoria do something like that? The thought of her being sick or hurt sends a strange sensation through me.

I don't care about her—no, that's not it.

But she's mine, and I take care of what belongs to me. If something's wrong with her, it's my job to fix it.

W: See what's wrong with her. And text me back immediately.

I look up from my phone at the fuming Albanian in front of me.

"Time's up," I say, standing. Ivan follows my lead.

The Albanian downs the rest of his whiskey. "Seven percent. And we'll do it."

"Six," I counter, knowing full well all our other allies are getting six percent each.

Securing this new territory isn't about the money. It's more about expanding the *Pakhan*'s influence. Especially when the Italians are looking to do the same. And *especially* after Victoria's father conspired with them to seize some of our assets.

"Fine," he says, visibly satisfied that he got more than what was initially offered.

My phone vibrates in my hand.

"Ivan will give you the details of when and where to meet next. Have a good evening, gentlemen."

I peer down at the message as I exit the club, and a strange feeling squeezes my chest at what I read.

C: she says she's fine but wants to be left alone

C: she was crying

She can cry all she wants. It won't change my plans for her.

But as I read the message over and over again, I recognize the feeling, the *guilt* that makes its way to my reasoning, twisting it until it loses some of its sense.

I find myself wanting to call Victoria and tell her to get the hell up, but I haven't given her a phone. I have no way of reaching out to her. And I don't understand why it gets me so fucking fired up.

Why is she crying? I left her alone to prove a point, to give her a punishment—yes. But also to give her some peace of mind. Didn't she say she hates me? That she hates having me around?

"Get the car. We're going home," I tell Ivan.

"Should I call the Serbian? Tell him we're no longer meeting tonight?"

"Yes. And I won't be meeting anyone tomorrow either. We're postponing the whole thing for a few days."

Ivan frowns. "You heard the Albanian. He might go crawling to the Cosa Nostra for a better deal if they hear they have more time."

"I'll come up with something in the meantime. Right now, I need to get home."

***

By the time I'm back, it's already morning. I unlock and enter Victoria's room silently, not wanting to wake her up if she's sleeping.

The thick curtains cover the windows, keeping the sun from passing through, which makes it look as if it's still nighttime. The air is tight, heavy. I know Corinne ventilates the room every morning and tidies up, but it feels as if she hasn't done it in days.

Victoria’s frail body lies under the rumpled sheets, the side of her face buried in her pillow, arms bent at the elbows on either side of it.

She’s barely covered with the sheet, giving me a perfect view of her round ass in a short, cream-colored nightgown.

Tearing my gaze from her, I open the curtains and the window, letting fresh air and sunlight in. She groans softly, burying her face deeper into her pillow.

“Not hungry,” she murmurs.

I approach the bedside, looming above her. “Good morning, love. Miss me?”

Her eyes flutter open, but she doesn’t wake up fully, doesn’t move much like she usually does when I startle her. Instead, she turns to the other side, giving me the cold shoulder.

“I heard you haven’t been eating. Care to tell me why you’re being a brat?”

When she keeps silent, it makes my blood boil.

This isn’t like her at all.

“I asked you a question. Two, in fact. Answer me or see what happens.”

“Fuck you,” she says, pulling the covers up to her neck so I can no longer see her.

Fine, then. I wrap my arms around her—one under her knees, and the other around her back—and drag her into me as she yelps. I lift her up, cradling her at my chest, sheets and all. She tries to get away, pushing into my chest, but my hold is firm, and I’m not letting her go.

“What the hell are you doing?!” she shouts when I put her down in the shower. “Leave me alone!”

I flick the tap, knowing full well the water will be ice cold.

“Fuck! Wolfgang, what the *fuck*!”

The water pours down on her, making the sheets stick to her body, soaking her.

“Oh, good, you’re awake,” I say, peering down at her. The look on her face is murderous. It makes me want to laugh. She’s so fucking beautiful when she’s mad at me. “Be a good girl and get ready for the day. We have things to do.”

“I’m not doing anything with you!” she seethes, standing. “You can go crawl right back where you came from.”

“I’m not asking, Victoria. If you’re not going to do it, I’ll clean you up myself.”

She scowls, and I stare back, my brows raised in anticipation.

“Get out.”

“You have ten minutes.”

I walk back into her room, suddenly remembering the glass shard she stabbed me with. Where did she get that? No mirrors are broken, so I open the drawer to her vanity desk, looking for answers. And sure enough, a makeup palette of sorts has a shattered mirror attached to it. Clever girl.

I make a mental note to take anything like that away from her and wait until she comes out of the shower with a towel wrapped tightly around her body, wet and rosy from the hot water.

She doesn’t spare me a glance before disappearing into the walk-in closet, slamming the doors behind her.

Minutes later, she comes back out, wearing a yellow mini dress with spaghetti straps that molds to her torso and flows along her waist. Flat sandals cover her feet, which she's keeping hip-distance apart as she stares at me with her arms crossed.

"Beautiful," I say, and I mean it. "Your hair?"

"I don't care. It will dry," she answers with a bite in her tone.

I nod once, and extend my hand out toward the door, signaling for her to step outside. Hesitantly, she uncrosses her arms and goes out into the hallway. I'm right behind her, and I take her hand to guide her. She doesn't expect it.

I've been holding her by her neck up to this moment, wanting to show her I own her. But today, I want her to feel comfortable. A bit of light in the dark tunnel she's been trapped in since I brought her home.

I don't know where the fuck that thought is coming from. It makes me angry, but so does not going through with it.

"Where are we going?" she asks, her tone mellower this time, curious.

"I have a surprise for you."

She halts in the middle of the stairs. "No. I don't want it. Let me go back to my room."

Poor thing. She thinks I'm taking her to the slaughterhouse. Maybe I scared her too much.

"You're with me. No one will hurt you. In fact, it's something you'll enjoy. I promise."

She looks up at me, and her expression softens—just slightly, but noticeable enough. My chest expands at the sight of it because it means that somehow, she trusts me, even if just a little. Good.

I take her downstairs and out through the back door, into the garden. We follow a narrow, stone-beaded trail between trimmed bushes and beds of flowers, until finally, she sees it. Her eyes shift to me, only this time they're glassy, like she's about to cry in front of me.

"What is this?"

"I had to punish you for what you did, for making an unauthorized call and running from me. But you stayed put through your punishment and didn't give Corinne a hard time. For that, I want to reward you. And show you that I can be good to you if you do what I say."

She takes a sharp breath, nodding.

"Go on," I tell her, jerking my head to Sasha, who is waiting for her on the patio. "Talk to him, then we'll have breakfast out here. You need to eat."

I caress her head once, her soft hair a reminder of how fragile she is despite her feisty nature.

She doesn't say anything back to me, but she doesn't have to. I can tell what this means to her. And hopefully, it will teach her only I hold the keys to moments like this.

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11

VICTORIA

Letting go of me, Wolfgang brings his hand to the small of my back, encouraging me to walk. He doesn't need to ask twice.

Sasha's tired eyes watch me with a smile glistening in them. I can't believe he's here… and that Wolfgang didn't hurt him—like he promised.

I keep my composure as I take the steps toward him, but it shatters completely when I get close. I practically jump at the man I consider my father, wrapping my arms around his torso, burying my head in his chest.

"Don't cry," he murmurs, hugging me back. "Don't let him see you weak."

I nod, blinking back tears as I push from his chest to see his face.

"Good. Let's have a chat, then. I've missed you."

"I've missed you, too," I say, smiling. "How are you here?"

"Let's just say when the Rykov Bratva bangs on your door and puts a gun to your head, there's not much you can do about it. I thought they were taking

me to my grave.”

I shiver at the thought.

When I look behind me, Wolfgang’s watchful eye is still there, but he’s back in front of the house, at a reasonable distance, lighting a cigarette. Letting me know he’s around, but not prying, which is more than I could’ve asked for.

Sasha and I sit down on the patio chairs. He looks exactly the same as the last time I saw him. His beard is still white, and his eyes are still droopy, but his warmth and smile are the same. He feels like home, even in this strange, lonely place.

“Has he hurt you?” he asks. Not *how are you doing?* He probably knows the answer is *not well*.

“No. He’s not violent.”

Sasha hums in understanding. “Touched you?”

Touched me? Yeah, but not in the way he’s asking. The truth is, I was touched… everywhere, and I allowed it—*enjoyed* it, even. But I can’t tell him that. What would he think of me?

“No. Nothing like that.”

Relief crosses his face. “Good. I was surprised to see him last night. Especially after our conversation a few days ago. I thought he’d hurt you or…”

I shake my head, surprising myself when I say, “No, no, he’s not like that.” Why am I trying to defend him? To show Sasha he’s not so bad? Because he is. He’s horrible, and I hate him.

“I don’t know what he wants with me, Sasha. Do you know anything? Have you tried to find out?”

“I have. But didn’t find much. I don’t think he’s told anyone about the extent of his plans. What I *do* know is that he’s planning a wedding for you. Any day now.”

Makes sense. “He wants to make it public. To humiliate us even more.”

“Yes. And I don’t know what comes after that. But Victoria…” he stops mid-sentence, and my brows draw together in worry. “Your father reached out to me the other day, and I didn’t like what he told me.”

“You should’ve seen it, Sasha… he got on his knees for her…”

“For Anya?”

I nod, pursing my lips as I look down and inhale.

“I’m sorry.” He sighs. “But you know better than to expect otherwise from him.”

“It still hurts.”

He places a hand on top of mine, and his warmth settles my nerves. “I know.”

“What did he tell you?” I ask, swiftly wiping my face with my other palm.

“He wants you to interfere with the *Pakhan*’s plans. He still thinks he can come out on top.”

“God, I can’t believe him… Is he trying to get me killed? All of us? Wolfgang will crush him.”

“He still thinks the Italians will have his back if he can do something to show them he can fight against the Rykovs. They’re sworn enemies—always have been.”

“Are you saying I should help him?”

“No, Victoria. I’m saying if he reaches out some other way, I want you to ignore him. Don’t put yourself in danger for his ambitions.”

I listen to what Sasha tells me, the morning sun caressing my skin as it comes down from the sky with the warm breeze. I like it here. In this garden, time seems to have stopped.

It’s just me and my instructor, and it’s reminiscent of the breaks we used to take in between our riding lessons.

I can’t believe Wolfgang allowed me this happiness. But I’m not naïve enough to forget everything he has done. He can’t be trusted.

“What else did you find out?” I ask.

“The *Pakhan*’s wife, Ekaterina, is not Wolfgang’s real mother and his half-brother, Mikhail, wants to be boss. He resents Wolfgang for being so high up in the organization. The three of them are constantly at war.”

It finally makes some sense now.

Wolfgang’s non-Russian name, the monsters he alluded to when he told me to be careful in this house…

“Promise me you’ll be careful. Because once you’re back in there—” he jerks his head to the house “you’re all you’ve got. Do you understand me?”

He removes his hand from mine, running it through his gray hair.

I hold his stare, not ready to see him leave just yet. But Sasha's eyes focus over my shoulder, letting me know Wolfgang is back. I inhale and square my shoulders, my mental shields slowly putting themselves back together.

"I promise."

***

Wolfgang and I have breakfast in silence on the terrace overlooking the forest. The feeling of dread is still with me. Maybe not as prevalent, but it's still here. He doesn't ask me what Sasha and I talked about, and I don't ask him any questions either.

I eat my granola slowly, savoring the little time I'm granted out in nature. I feel pathetic for not standing up to him, but every time I tried, it ended in his favor. And I'm not ready to be taken back upstairs to my prison.

I watch Wolfgang sip his coffee and text someone on his phone.

Out here, between the flowers and the birds chirping above our heads, he looks like the odd one. His hard features, scars, and tattoos attest to that. And when the clouds shift and shadows of the leaf-clad branches stretch across his face, I suck in a breath at how handsome he is. Handsome and cruel. A deadly combination I never imagined I'd come across, especially in someone who is about to become my husband.

His golden eyes slide over to me with the wind, hair swaying softly above them. And when they do, I get that flutter of electricity coursing through me again, like someone shot it down from the sky, aiming it straight at me.

Just for a second, I look away, and when my gaze returns, he's preoccupied with his phone again, but the corner of his mouth is tilted up.

Arrogant prick.

My lips part so I can make him aware of my thought, but he beats me to it.

“Be good,” he says.

“Why would you say that—”

The sound of taut footsteps crushing grass and pebbles registers from behind me. I rotate my neck a few inches to the left. A dark silhouette walks past me before I get the chance to see a face. New cologne tickles my nostril, smoky and sophisticated.

“Enjoying your day?” the man says, stooping to pick up a blueberry from the table with his tattooed fingers.

When he straightens up, he rakes his gaze over me and smiles. Of course, it doesn’t reach his empty eyes. It even looks abhorrent on his face, next to the tattoo that stretches on the side of his neck.

A shiver runs through me, reminding me of the kinds of people I’m dealing with here. Cold-blooded criminals.

Wolfgang places his phone on the table and interlaces his fingers in his lap. “We were, actually. Until about five seconds ago. What can I do for you, brother?”

Brother.

“Hmm, I don’t know. Introduce me to your pretty little girlfriend, for one,” he says, hands now in his pockets. “Then… maybe you can tell me why we’re not already on the way to meet with the others and take what’s ours.”

A few seconds of silence pass between them, the tension settling.

“Victoria, please meet my brother, Mikhail. And Mikhail…” He holds his stare. “Do not mistake her for a pretty girlfriend. She is my wife. And she’s exquisite.”

“Exquisite, yes,” Mikhail echoes, extending a hand in front of me, his palm facing up. Instinctively, my eyes shift to Wolfgang for approval, and he nods. I don’t know why I trust him all of a sudden, but it’s better to be around a monster you know than one you haven’t met yet.

I give Mikhail my hand, and he takes it, stooping to brush his lips to my skin.

“Lovely to meet you, Victoria. But I don’t see a ring on your finger. You know what that makes you…?”

I frown.

“…up for grabs.”

I pull my hand back, and he laughs as he straightens up.

“I’m not a fucking toy,” I seethe.

“How feisty! Is this why you picked her?”

Is it? I turn to Wolfgang for the answer, but it never comes.

“The wedding is this Saturday,” Wolfgang says, taking me completely by surprise. “Now, what do you want, Mikhail? You’re taking away my sun.”

Mikhail’s face darkens. His energy shifts, and I find myself pressing my back to my seat.

“You changed the plan.”

“Yes. And?”

A slow, deliberate nod. “See, that’s the difference between us, Wolfgang. You only think about yourself, about making sure the plans we make fit

your schedule. It's always me who thinks about everyone else."

"How thoughtful of you. And yet here you are, airing our dirty laundry in front of—"

"What? An outsider?" Mikhail's eyebrows rise. "And here I was… thinking she was your wife."

Turning his back to us, he continues his path to the house. Even when he's gone, and Wolfgang resumes using his phone, the tension lingers, confirming everything Sasha said.

Not only do they not like each other… if given the chance, they'd tear each other apart. And whatever Wolfgang is planning to do with me, it must be detrimental to secure his position as the next *Pakhan*.

I smile to myself.

Does he even realize he practically revealed all his cards?

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12

VICTORIA

A wedding dress should be the most beautiful thing a woman wears in her life. But as I stare down at my hands resting in my lap, all I can think of is the anger, the rage I'm feeling inside. And the cage I'm about to walk into willingly, chaining me to the monster I've known for the past two weeks.

White drapes over my opened palms, creasing gently between my fingers.

Cool and smooth, the fabric of my gown stares back at me with as much disbelief as I'm offering it. It's light, as if it holds no weight at all. It molds to my breasts, my torso, and my hips, then flows in thin, delicate waves of silk and lace, filling the space in the backseat of Wolfgang's car.

He hasn't seen me yet, and I don't even know where his men are taking me right now. Are the Rykovs religious? Will he want to marry me in a church?

I snort at the thought. He'd probably burn alive within seconds of setting foot in a holy place.

But to my surprise, the car comes to a stop in front of a large church with a golden dome, passing dozens of other high-end cars.

I swipe my thumb across the silk and lace, and my breath hitches as I do my best to block out the pain threatening to burst out of me through tears.

I promised myself I wouldn't cry. Not today. Not when everyone will be there to witness it. A hard task, given the way this damned ruby necklace constantly reminds me of the day he ripped my dreams from me like they meant nothing. He made me wear it again.

The door opens to my right, and I swallow hard.

"Miss Romanov," Ivan says, extending his hand to me.

Ignoring it, I clutch the sides of my dress and, as graciously as I can, step outside.

Tilting my head back, I take in the building before me, then look back to see if I'm being watched at all. And sure enough, my soon-to-be-husband's men are right there, like an impenetrable wall between me and my freedom, waiting for me to walk. It becomes clear no one will lead me down the aisle.

Not my father. Not Sasha.

I'll offer myself to him like a fucking sacrifice.

"He's waiting for you. Everyone is," Ivan says somewhat gently.

I bite my lip to stop it from quivering. "Just… give me a goddamn minute!"

Nodding, he steps back and lets me have it. All I allow myself is another deep breath before my feet move on their own accord and the church balms and incense welcome me inside.

WOLFGANG

She didn’t run.

Like a porcelain doll, flawless and void of any emotion on her pretty face, Victoria walks down the aisle toward me between the sea of people I’ve invited to witness her family’s humiliation.

My father and the rest of our family sit at the front, watching her like hawks. Taking her in for the first time.

If I tore my eyes away from my bride, I know I’d be able to see Ekaterina’s displeasure all over her face—the loathing in those green, elongated eyes, the permanent grimace on her narrow mouth.

She was the only one who opposed this marriage, like she always opposes everything I do.

But my wife is a sight to behold, and I bet it pisses her off so much she’s practically boiling inside. The thought of my step-mother standing there, with her perfect makeup and her designer clothes clinging to her tense body almost makes me laugh.

All our allies are here, too, filling most of the pews.

And there, alone and cornered by everyone loyal to us, sits Victoria’s traitorous family—Nikolai Romanov, his wife, and their eldest daughter. Both women look miserable, like they’re about to burst into tears at any moment. Good. They didn’t lift a finger to help Victoria when she needed it most—not that it would’ve changed the outcome, obviously. But now, I have no intention of protecting them.

It’s been a long time coming, and the whole thing is even more satisfying than I imagined.

I keep my eyes trained ahead, seeing how my wife's dress molds to her hourglass figure and flows gracefully along her hips. The red diamonds of her necklace gleam under the sunlight seeping in through the windows. A beautiful, perfect collar for her.

When Victoria approaches, I see the tears threatening to spill from her eyes before she blinks, and they’re gone. I extend my hand toward her and pull her in, jerking her a little on purpose. They need to see this wedding for what it is—that I’m only doing it to prove a point.

I turn to face the priest and feel her shifting next to me, doing the same.

“We’re gathered here today to witness the union of this man and this woman in holy matrimony,” he says, followed by drawing the cross sign in the air. He knows better than to prolong this ceremony for longer than it needs to be. Which is why I’m glad when he skips ahead and asks, “Do you, Wolfgang, take Victoria to be your lawfully wedded wife? To love, honor, and protect her, in sickness and in health, for as long as you both shall live?”

“I do.”

“And do you, Victoria, take Wolfgang to be your lawfully wedded husband? To love and obey until you give your last breath?”

She clears her voice but keeps silent. What does she think she’ll accomplish by delaying it? Her submission is inevitable.

“I meant what I said,” she whispers so that only I can hear. “I will never love you, Wolfgang. And the only vow I can make you is that you will regret this day.”

No, I won’t.

“Victoria—”

“I do,” she says, loud and clear. As if she’s proud to announce it to the whole fucking world. Or… as if she thinks she has the upper hand. Wouldn’t surprise me.

I knew letting Sasha come and talk to her would lead to this. But if she thinks she has any chance of ever winning against me, she’s greatly mistaken.

Ivan approaches with the rings, and we put them on. Despite all her defiance, her slender hand still trembles, and I tighten my hold on it to calm her down.

She should know by now I wouldn’t hurt her. She’s just a pawn in this game, and now that she has my name, I will protect her with my life. As I would do for anyone else who had it.

“I now pronounce you husband and wife. You may kiss the bride.”

I step into her, closing the distance between us. Bringing my hand to the back of her head, I dig my fingers into her hair and expose her neck, keeping her in place as I look down to see her skin throb under her racing pulse. Then I simply lower myself to her and pry her lips open with mine for everyone to see. She’s mine.

My tongue finds hers—sweet, delicate, and velvety—and I have to actively stop myself from groaning because my cock is already fucking hard.

She pushes into my chest, wanting to break free. But I don’t fail to notice the little whimpers she lets out before she, too, realizes she’s supposed to keep those to herself.

When I pull away, she stays still, showing me she stopped fighting. And I don’t want to, I swear I fucking don’t, but something makes me *need* to

praise her for it. To teach her what I want more of. I keep my fingers in her hair and break the silence of the church.

“Good girl, Victoria. I’ll make sure to reward you some more later, in our bed.”

I grab her hand, and she gasps softly, but keeps her head high as I take us back up the aisle.

Congratulations reach my ears, but they’re not aimed at the marriage itself. Everybody here sees this as a power move, and they all know the worst is yet to come to the traitors sitting in the pews who, by the way, don’t get up to see us off like the rest.

It doesn’t even matter, though this is probably their last chance to see Victoria ever again.

We’re almost out when suddenly, my wife’s hand goes taut, and I feel her tripping behind me. One of our men grips her arm and pulls her up forcefully.

“Get the fuck up, bitch. Keep walking.”

Anger shoots through me like fucking lava. Clenching my jaw, I make brief eye contact with my father. He shakes his head at me, anticipating my thoughts. I’m about to kill a man in a holy place.

The room falls silent.

Victoria snatches her arm free of the man’s grip and steps beside me, avoiding my gaze, looking distressed.

The red marks on her skin will probably form a bruise. So I pull out my gun from beneath my jacket and bring the man into me by his collar before firing at his head.

Blood splatters on my face, the metallic scent instantly filling the air. Women's gasps echo all around, and the priest's dark figure dashes behind the altar.

I push the corpse off me. It falls to the floor with a thud.

"Let this be your only warning," I say, tucking my gun back in. "I don't care who the fuck you are or how important you think you are. If anyone, *ever*, touches my wife, or disrespects her, I will kill you. You will die at my hand. Do. You. Understand?"

I pin them all with my gaze, looking for any sign of disagreement on their faces. There's none.

"What my son means to say," Father's voice rings from the other side of the church. "Is that an attack on *any* Rykov is an attack on the Bratva. You all know very well how we deal with traitors, and unless I give an explicit order, no one interferes with our ways." He looks at Victoria's family. "I took Nikolai's daughter. And I'm about to take so much more. Now, if you don't want to be next in line, I suggest you keep your mouths shut and enjoy the rest of your fucking day."

I don't react to Father's statement, but I know I'll never hear the end of what I just did. He chimed in to salvage the situation, and he succeeded, but he shouldn't have had to do it in the first place.

My eyes slide over to Ekaterina, all pampered and dressed in black, as if she dressed for a funeral, not a wedding. She's the only figure smirking in the crowd. Of course she's going to take this as a fucking win.

Still, I stand by what I did.

No one touches my wife but me.

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13

VICTORIA

He killed for me. Standing here, in the middle of his room, with the wedding dress still on, it's all I can think about. The blood that splattered on his face. The sound of metal cracking bone. The stench, the looks we got from everyone in the church, including my family.

I've never seen it happen in real life, and I admit, it rattled me a little, which is another mistake on my part. Because in a world like Wolfgang's I don't get to feel rattled. If I let it, the ugliness will break me, and I can't allow that.

Still, he… defended me. And I wish he hadn't, because now I'm confused.

Why did he do it?

I follow my husband with my eyes as he comes out of the en-suite bathroom with a clean face and new clothes. Business casual, the kind you'd wear if you were going out instead of staying in with your wife.

Except… it's our wedding night, and I expected him to…

I suck in a breath, killing the thought, as I take in the room.

It's larger than the one I've been locked in, and the styling gives it a masculine vibe. A four-poster king-sized bed sits in the middle against a black wall, with silk sheets of a dark charcoal color. The ceiling holds a crystal chandelier above it, catching lights from the sunset through the tall windows.

"What am I doing here?" I ask, exhaustion dripping from my every word.

He picks up the phone, texting someone as he answers. "This is where you'll be sleeping from now."

"If you're *also* sleeping here, the answer is no."

"I'm not asking, Victoria. I'm telling you."

I snort and turn away from him, facing the windows overlooking the garden.

"How is your arm?"

I shake my head, turning to face him again.

"You killed that man."

"I'm sorry you had to see it."

"But not that you did it."

"Do you expect me to be? Because if you do, you will be very disappointed with your new life, love."

Butterflies spring to life in my stomach, and I frown as my pulse hikes. "Don't call me that."

His lips lift with that barely noticeable smile of his that makes me feel exposed. My cheeks warm up. He's so close, and we're alone, and now I'm his wife. Officially.

And that kiss… that long, possessive kiss in the church made me feel things I'm not ready to accept about myself.

His knuckles brush my warm face. "I asked Corinne to bring you dinner. Be good and eat. And get some rest. I know the ceremony wasn't easy for you."

He's right. It wasn't. Seeing my parents there, looking so helpless and humiliated… It hurt more than I'll ever admit to him.

"Since when do you care how I feel?"

"I've always cared about your wellbeing. I told you before, I take care of what belongs to me."

"You took me away!" I explode. "You stole my life away from me. Locked me in a room with no human contact for days on end. Is this how you take care of what belongs to you?"

Compared to mine, his tone is calm, endearing almost. "Actions have consequences, Victoria. I made you aware that you will be punished if you don't obey me. And I also told you I'd reward you if you did. The choices you make are yours. You dictate what happens to you."

I grab his arm and squeeze, looking him dead in the eye. His gaze lowers to where our bodies make contact, and the smile returns to his face.

"*Never* lock me in a room again," I say, lowering my voice. "If you do, the second you open that door, I promise you, Wolfgang… I'll kill you."

He waits, letting the silence stretch between us long enough for my confidence to start to perish. His lips part, and my hand on his arm loosens.

My body fills with unease because I know I just issued my first threat.

“I don’t need to lock you in a room to keep you in check, love. Remember that.”

He turns to walk away, heading for the door.

“You’re… leaving?”

“I have something important to take care of tonight.”

I don’t know why I’m surprised. He seems to come and go without any given notice. This was all just a big transaction for him. Our marriage is a complete sham.

I cross my arms and walk deeper into the room. I don’t want *his* company, anyway. I don’t. I’m just so fucking sick of being treated like an object he wants to dispose of but can’t, so he just stuffs it in the attic and hopes he never has to see it again.

I take a seat and stoop to take off my heels, dropping the first one to the floor.

“You’re upset.”

“Nope. You can go now. I want to be alone.” As soon as I straighten up, he props his arms on either side of the armchair and lowers his head until I can feel the tickle of his breath against my face.

“Were you hoping we’d spend our wedding night together, love? Is that it?”

I suck in a breath, goosebumps pebbling the skin on my back and arms.

“I’m bored. Go pester someone else.”

“No, no, no,” he whispers. “I don’t think bored is what you are. I think you moaned when I kissed you at the altar. I think you liked it when I pulled your hair like I owned you. And I think you wanted me to throw you on this bed and have my way with you until dawn. How far off am I?”

His lips brush mine, not in a kiss, but in a tantalizing touch that never feels like it’s enough.

“Very,” I drawl, my breath trembling between us. “Past the North Pole.”

“Mmm. See, the problem with that is… I know an aroused woman when I see one. But let me assure you, Victoria, that when I get back, I’ll take my sweet time to explore you and your pussy. And you will come for me many, many times, no matter how much you like to lie to yourself that it’s not what you want.”

His baritone voice sears along my nerve endings, forcing me to swallow dryly.

“Keep deluding yourself. Like I said, you’re boring me.”

A lie. A blatant lie. I know it, he knows it, but here we are, still playing the game. The game in which I’m losing, exactly like he said I would.

“Oh, am I, now?” he says with false regret.

Supporting the weight of his body on one arm, he lowers the other one to my feet and drags it up under my dress, stopping once he reaches the apex of my thighs.

“Wolfgang—”

“Ah, but look at you, love, all warm between your legs.” He presses a finger against my panties, rubbing my pussy in a slow circle. My legs part wider on their own accord. “Am I still boring you?”

I’m too focused on the throbbing, on his scent seeping into my pores, on the strong hand drawing out my surrender. My body is betraying me, and I can’t get rid of this feeling. He keeps rubbing me, and it’s soft, and cruel, and oh so delicious. And I can’t, I can’t…

“Victoria?”

“Y-yes.”

“Take off your dress.”

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14

WOLFGANG

When my wife brings her hand to her back and unzips her dress willingly, a hum of satisfaction leaves my throat.

Satisfaction, and no surprise. Because I understood from the moment I laid eyes on her that there was more to Victoria than she let on.

Under her feisty demeanor, her submission keeps trying to come out. It calls out to the darkest parts of me, begging to be taken, used, and stripped of control.

I was never going to leave her alone on our wedding night. All I did was lay the choice in front of her and watch as her body betrayed her. A little disappointment. A little longing. She wanted me to stay, even if she wasn't ready to say it. I wasn't sure, but after this… I know. And I fucking love it.

I help her stand, and with her delicate, trembling hands, she slides the straps off her shoulders, the dress pooling at our feet beneath her half-naked body.

When I look down at her, her round breasts and pink, pointy nipples stare back. I can only imagine how her shaved pussy throbs behind the soaked layer of her panties. My cock hardens at the sight of my wife, at the breathy

sound of her nervousness. It's practically painful at this point, and there's no way in hell I'm not spending the night hearing her moan in my ear while I fuck her raw.

"I don't… I don't know what to do," she confesses.

I trail my knuckles down her abdomen, raking my eyes over everything that's mine. Goosebumps pebble her skin in the wake of my touch, showing me how much it affects her.

"All you have to do, love, is listen to my voice and do as I say. Can you do that for me?"

She nods softly, and I step in toward her, making her instinctively retreat. Then another step, and another, until the backs of her thighs collide with the edge of the bed.

A subtle frown confirms the small conflict inside her. She wants this, but she's hellbent on hating me at the same time. Fair enough. Though it will be hard to hate me when I'm caressing her sweet little cunt.

Still, she takes a seat, her gaze never leaving mine. She's on my sheets now, stretching herself back like a cat as I lean above her. She's the only pale thing in the mass of dark colors, and she looks soft, and warm, and inviting.

More importantly, she looks like she's mine.

"What will you do to me?" Her voice is timid, void of her usual bite.

I fondle her clit through her panties. "Whatever I want."

Her lips part as if to say something, but a breathy moan slips past them instead. Her eyelids fall closed, and a rosy color blooms on her cheeks. I love how easy to read she is—I can see it all over her pretty face.

Hooking my fingers behind the seam of her panties, I pull them to the side, revealing a glistening pussy. *Christ*. She's drenched, and I barely even touched her. My mouth waters.

I press my thumb to her slit, gliding it up and down without applying much pressure. Her back arches, and she mewls, chasing the high I'm denying her. More and more of her arousal coats my skin, making a wet, ticking sound as I smear it all over her soft flesh.

My middle finger slides down to her entrance, entering her easily to the first knuckle. I hold her there, wrapped around me, feeling her pulse and warmth in her tight channel. She writhes, slowly and subtly, but nonetheless, she writhes, rubbing herself on me as best she can. I don't even think she realizes she's doing it.

"Wolf…"

"I know, love, I know…"

I pull my finger out with more of her arousal, dragging her panties down her thighs until she's naked before me. Then I simply pry her pussy open with my palms and stoop to rake my tongue over her engorged clit.

The moan she lets out can only be described as ravenous. It makes me growl between her legs. Her sweet taste spreads like wildfire in my mouth. A mistake. How the fuck am I going to crave anything else from now?

Pain pulls at my scalp when her fingers rush through my hair, tugging as she keeps arching, taking my tongue strokes like the good girl she is. My cock twitches, begging to be freed and buried inside her cunt. So I hurry, licking her faster, until her moaning intensifies, and her body tenses as she comes undone.

Her cum drips on my tongue as she contorts, and I make sure not to waste it. I lick her through it, causing her legs to spasm and her eyes to roll back.

When she comes down from her high, I stand upright and unbuckle my belt from my slacks.

“I’m going to take it easy on you, love. But only because this is your first time.”

She nods, but I’m not sure she realizes I’m about to fuck her.

Not make love to her, like she might be thinking.

But use her. Praise her. Degrade her.

Show her what it means to be owned.

VICTORIA

The sound of his belt hitting the floor makes my pulse hike.

My gaze is fixed on his crotch, on the way his skilled fingers unbutton his slacks, then pull out his hard, veiny cock. *Jesus*. How the hell is that going to fit inside me? But my throbbing pussy answers for me, and she’s telling me to shut up.

Because my God, the thing he did with his tongue? I’ve never realized just how much I missed out on for never having a sex life. And right now, I want more of it.

My eyes flick up to meet his when he leans above me. He’s not going to get undressed. Of course he isn’t.

This is just another way for him to assert his dominance. That I’m his possession, and all he needs to do is take his cock out. But all my thoughts

die when his hand takes mine and guides it to my pussy.

“Use your hands to open up your pussy. This will hurt.”

“You said you’ll be gentle,” I say, feeling my wetness with my fingertips.

“It’s still going to hurt. Your pussy is very tight. Just do it, love.”

Sucking in a breath, I part my legs wider for him and do as instructed, opening my pussy with my palms. The air in the room is cooler than my body temperature, and it caresses my entrance, intensifying the throbbing.

There’s something deeply erotic about being exposed before him. It turns me on, and I know I could have another orgasm just by listening to his voice.

“That’s a good girl,” he says, supporting his weight on the mattress next to me with one arm, the other guiding his cock to my pussy. And then… I feel him.

The smooth skin on his crown. The pre-cum mixing with my own arousal. He pushes past my entrance, past my open palms, and my body shivers with pleasure. It’s just like what he did with his fingers, but better. Much, much better this time. My pussy tightens around him, and I bring my hands up to rest them on his shoulders.

“Oh…”

“Fuck, Victoria.” He groans, pushing himself deeper into me. “Goddamn.”

Another inch is all it takes for my eyes to snap open and for my entire body to tense. Pain like I’ve never known rips through me as if I’m being pulled apart. Something drips out of me, but I’m not sure it’s my arousal this time. I’m not turned on anymore. It hurts like hell.

I dig my nails into his muscles, yelping under his weight.

Another inch or two spear me.

“That’s it, love. Take my cock like a good, obedient wife. Ah, fuck, you’re so tight…”

And another few.

“W-Wolf—”

My words halt with his last thrust that rips through whatever was left of my innocence. He’s buried inside me to the hilt now, and tears run down my chin. I can’t help it. My lip trembles and I bury my mouth into his shirt, sobbing quietly as my pussy burns.

“I-It hurts…”

“You’re doing so well. Look at you, bleeding all over my cock.”

He pulls out a little, and my body sags, thinking this was it.

Then he slams into me again, and I let out a scream so loud I don’t care who hears it. I push into his hard chest, wanting to stop the pain.

But when he pulls out again, the burning feeling subsidizes, giving me a much needed break. He waits with me, as if he knows I need it. Until I find myself moaning at the new sensation settling deep inside me.

“There you are,” he coos, pressing his lips to my exposed neck. “There’s my good girl.”

I writhe, feeling my pussy tighten around his cock, timidly chasing more friction. And he grants it to me. Our bodies slap together as his hips rock into me in long, fluid motions. His hand cups my breast, squeezing it lightly before bringing his mouth to it, sucking my nipple between his lips.

Fuck.

New tears form at the corners of my eyes. Only this time, they're from pleasure. And all I can do is lie here and take it. Take all he's giving my body like I'm exactly what he said—a good, obedient wife.

All I can think of is him, all I know is him, and it feels right, even though I know it's all a lie.

Pulling away fully this time, his cock—long and hard—stands straight up between us, my blood smeared all over it. He strokes it slowly a few times as his eyes rake over me like I'm some sort of meal.

I'm all splayed out on his sheets, with the proof of his claim on me smearing my thighs. Shame washes through me, but I don't think he cares. Because his eyes darken further, and he's leaning back down to use me some more. I swallow hard, struggling to catch my breath.

My husband's powerful arms round my hips. He flips me over like I weigh nothing, my face buried in his sheets, ass up in the air. His low hum of agreement sounds above me. A hand fists in my hair, pushing my head deeper into the mattress. Then his cock is shoved back between my shaky legs.

I yelp, the sound muffled by the sheets. I'm running out of oxygen. He must know that, because my head is yanked back, and I'm bent like a pretzel for him to fuck from behind.

"Wolf—Oh, God…"

"How does it feel, love? Having my cock in your cunt."

I breathe in and out, trying to block out the pain of the position he has me in.

"Answer me."

"Go-od… it feels good," I mumble. "Please…"

“Begging me already, love? So sweet.” He lowers his head to my ear. “Do it again.”

His cock thrusts inside me, filling me up, a mix of pleasure and pain rocking my body up and down, rumpling the sheets beneath me. He fucks me fast and hard, and moans explode out of me. It hurts, then it doesn’t. It’s an array of feelings I’ve never experienced before.

“Please. *Please*,” I say between shattered breaths, but I’m not sure what I’m begging for. My pussy clenches around him, feeling every stroke, every vein gliding against my walls.

Every spark of pleasure creeping into my core. And when he brings a finger to my untouched hole, my eyes widen in shock at the rush of arousal coursing through me out of nowhere.

“Come for me, Victoria. Let me see this pussy come all over my cock.”

He doesn’t have to say it twice. Because as soon as he pushes that finger against my ass, I shatter right there and then, whimpering, writhing. Spasming while he fucks me through it. My eyes roll back, meeting his hungry stare from upside down. And the orgasm washes out of me in waves so powerful they take my breath away.

“That’s it. So fucking beautiful when you fall apart,” he praises, thrusting.

For a moment, I keep silent, feeling as if I’ve passed out, and this is my spirit looking down on me from above. I only come back to my senses when his thrusts stop, and something warm pulses into my pussy. My husband groans, coming inside me.

He pulls out and flips me over, and I’m forced to meet his gaze in a clearer state now. My scalp hurts from where he pulled my hair. And my pussy feels like it’s on fire. Only his cum soothes the soreness a little bit.

The spell is almost broken.

Almost… because I can’t believe what just happened between us.

“Victoria.”

“Y-yes?”

“I asked if you could walk.”

“I don’t… I don’t know.”

He smiles and drags me into his body.

“Come here, love.” He lifts me up in his arms and takes me into the en-suite bathroom. Placing me down on the shower bench, he turns on the water while I stare at his blood-covered clothes. My blood.

This time, he undresses, peeling each layer off him as he exposes himself to me.

He grips the hem of his shirt with one hand, the slow drag of fabric revealing taut, sculpted abs, each ridge defined, some adorned with veins, especially on his tattooed arms. I don’t know what they mean. They’re just intricate patterns with some foreign words scribbled really small.

When he takes off his slacks and leans a bit to the side, I get a glimpse of the cuts and scars on his back, along with the one where I stabbed him.

“Don’t worry about it,” he says, stepping into the shower with me.

“I wasn’t,” I lie.

He helps me stand, and the stream of hot water flows down on our bodies, washing away the blood and tears. I watch it go down the drain, but he lifts my gaze back up, bringing his knuckle under my chin.

“Remember what you said the last time I made you come? That it changed nothing?”

I nod.

“It changes something now. Because this pussy,” he says, bringing his finger against my slit. “Is mine. And I’m going to use it a lot, Victoria. Your cunt, ass, and throat will know every inch of me. And in time, you’ll learn to beg and crawl for my cock. Because why?”

I swallow hard, trying my best to keep a backbone right now, but the words come out behind a shy gaze. “Because you own me?”

He smiles. “Because I own you, love. And to reward you for taking my cock so well for the first time, I’m going to make you come on my tongue again.” He jerks his head toward the shower bench. “Sit down and spread your legs.”

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15

WOLFGANG

I lie awake next to a sleeping Victoria curled at my side. Her round ass peeks from underneath my sheets, and if tonight hadn't been her first time, I'd be snaking between her legs again just to hear her moan in my ear.

Her pain shouldn't matter to me, not really. But I'm going to want her more when she wakes up tomorrow, and it won't be the same if she's too sore to feel me.

Which makes me wonder… why the fuck am I still in bed with her? I know damn well when I'm up at this hour, I won't be able to fall asleep no matter what. I've been dealing with insomnia for far too long to forget it.

Thankfully, my phone vibrates on my nightstand, and when I pick it up, I stand. It's Ivan. And I bet he's texting to tell me whether the move on the Irish territory worked or failed.

I unlock my phone and read the short string of messages.

I: all clear

I: small problem

I: boss texted me about it

I: what do I tell him?

Fuck. If Father messaged him directly to get an update, he must be fuming right now. And it doesn't take a genius to know it's because of the scene I caused in the church.

Since I didn't meet with him again after the ceremony, I guess this is his indirect way of making sure I know.

I shoot Ivan a text, telling him to stay put, and slip on a t-shirt and pants. Victoria stirs a little from the noise, but otherwise remains asleep. *Good.*

Out into the hallway, I lock the door behind me, just in case someone goes in when I'm not there. I'm not going to take any risks with my wife sleeping naked under my sheets.

When I step into the other wing, the lights are off, but the smoke wafting in the air tells me Father is here. And when the sound of glasses clinking together breaks the silence, it tells me he's already spotted me.

"I don't appreciate you going behind my back to my guy when you know damn well I was going to update you in the morning."

His arm extends out into the moonlight, an empty glass of whiskey in his hand. "Maybe I should fire your guy, then. Seems he forgot who he's really working for."

I step toward him. "Ivan works for me. I'm paying him with my own money, lest you forgot."

"Sit down, Wolfgang."

Whiskey trickles from the bottle into the two glasses, one finger deep.

“Congratulations,” Father says, handing me a glass. I’m tempted to leave him hanging, but I find myself taking it anyway. “Your plan is well on the way. You got the girl.”

“And next, I’ll get the money. What are you getting at?”

“Can’t a father congratulate his son on his wedding night?”

I roll my eyes, and he chuckles.

“You know,” he says, before taking a sip of his drink. “For someone with an IQ of a genius, even you didn’t see this coming. And you’re usually the one who sees things the rest of us don’t.”

“What the fuck are you talking about?”

He points a finger in my direction, his voice taking a serious tone. “You know what you did today, Wolfgang.”

I lean forward in my seat, pinning him down with my gaze. “I killed a man for disrespecting us. It’s what we do. It’s what *you* taught us.”

“No. You killed a man because you let your feelings get in the way.”

“Excuse me?”

“What? You’re going to sit there and pretend you weren’t balls-deep in her cunt just moments ago? Come on, son. Honesty has always been one of your strongest suits.”

Fire licks at my veins, threatening to burst out through my fists. My nostrils flare, pulling in the air forcefully, leaving just the same. Father and I have had our disagreements over the years, but what he’s suggesting now…

“You’re out of fucking line,” I tell him. “What I did or did not do with my wife is none of your business. And it changes nothing about the plan.”

He sighs. “I could’ve shot every single one of the Romanovs in the head the moment I found out about their betrayal. But it was *you* who convinced me not to do it. You said…”

“That this was going to put us in a much better position. Yes, I remember what I fucking said.”

“Then you also remember what’s at stake.”

My throne.

I keep my gaze trained on his.

“You know that if you fail this, Mikhail will jump at the opportunity to get ahead. And Katy will support him. And as much as I want to let you have it, I won’t break this family apart. What would be the point of that?”

What would be the point? What would be the *point*?

This fucking family is already doomed. It has been ever since my mother died, and he knows it. He should’ve divorced Ekaterina the moment he saw her true colors, but instead, he chose to turn a blind eye.

He chose to let her do whatever she wanted, even if that meant breaking me every chance she got. He fucking owes me, and he knows it. But even so, what he’s really saying is he won’t butt heads with his wife and other son for me.

“Look. I know how hard it’s been for you growing up without your mother…”

“Do *not* bring her into this,” I say through clenched teeth.

“I fucking loved her too!” he shouts, his voice bouncing between the walls.

Silence.

Then after a while, he clears his throat.

“What I mean to say is that I know you had to fight a lot of battles. With Mikhail. With Katy. It wasn’t easy, and I am sorry for that. But… if you want your throne, if you want them to see you as part of this family, you’re going to have to come to your senses. And do what needs to be done.”

I nod and get up. Not to agree with him, but with the thought that he’s being an asshole.

“For your information, the Irish territory has been secured. And my plan worked so well I barely had to lift a finger to get it done. So the next time you accuse me of messing things up, I suggest you have a look at the facts instead of consulting your vivid imagination. Because the truth is… I’ve been steering this ship for far longer than you’d like to admit. *Me*. Not you. And if I don’t get what I want, I promise you, you’ll be sinking faster than the fucking Titanic.”

Father gets up and faces me, downing the rest of his whiskey.

Placing his glass next to mine, his eyes rise. “Good. Then we want the same thing. So get. It. Done.”

VICTORIA

The bed is cold and empty beside me, the absence pressing against my skin before I even open my eyes. Still lying down, I glance around the room, letting the morning light brush the sleep from my eyes. I’m really alone.

But when I get up on my elbows and push the sheets aside, a gust of Wolfgang's scent wafts over to me.

And the memory of every touch from last night comes back, sending butterflies to my sore pussy.

"Oh my God," I mumble, sitting upright, rubbing my face with my palms.

After he made me come again in the shower, he carried me back to bed and did it again with his fingers.

I almost asked him to stop because I didn't think I could take another orgasm. But I guess the adrenaline kept me going until, eventually, I fell asleep in his bed. The bed I bled on, now that I look at it.

I stand up and pull the ruined sheets off until they're all crumbled in my arms.

What if someone sees? What if the housekeeper finds it first?

I don't know what the hell to do with them, but I can't let anyone know what he did to me. I'd die of embarrassment. So I trudge into the bathroom, looking for a laundry basket where I can dump them. And finding none.

I do, however, notice all my toiletries in here, on two designated shelves, making my new reality even more real. *Ugh!* How am I supposed to feel about this? I'm married to him now, and we had sex. No, scratch that. We *fucked*.

He fucked me, and I enjoyed it so much I begged, moaned for him. Came all over his cock, just like he wanted.

What the hell is wrong with me? How could I feel that way, knowing what he took away from me?

I want to feel ashamed, but the ugly truth is, I don't. Because every time I see something that belongs to him—his shampoo, the shower cap he pressed to

my pussy last night, and the wedding ring on my finger—it makes my heart flutter as if I'm back in high school, developing my first crush.

It's stupid, and it can't be happening. I know it can't.

So instead of continuing to think about how I wish I'd woken up next to him instead of alone, I brush my teeth, hop in the shower, and get ready for the day after leaving the sheets in a corner on the bathroom floor.

Just like my toiletries, someone brought the clothes from the other bedroom. I fasten the last strap on my sandal when the door swings open and my thoughts vanish.

Corinne's face greets me with a smile.

"Good morning, Mrs. Rykov," she says, walking deeper into the room.

Mrs. Rykov. She means… me.

"It's Victoria."

She opens the windows and the curtains, inviting the day in, then comes back to make the bed.

I hold my breath, thinking she'll ask me about the sheets, but she just takes off the pillow cases as if she doesn't see anything missing.

"Mr. Rykov is already downstairs if you would like to join him for breakfast."

"I… You mean I can go out of the room by myself?"

She chuckles. "Of course you can. This is your home too, now."

As if. Still, the fact that I can wander off on my own brings hope to my chest.

"Okay. But Corinne…" I say, feeling the heat return to my cheeks.

“Yes?”

“The bed sheets…”

She hugs the pillowcases at her chest and throws me a knowing smile.

“Don’t worry about it, Victoria. No one else will see. And… you did what you had to do.”

I did what I *wanted* to do, but of course, I don’t tell her that. Instead, I thank her and head downstairs, eager to explore and find the breakfast table by myself. *And to see him again*, a small voice says from the back of my mind, which I try to silence as best I can.

The house is eerily quiet as I make my way through the halls, my sandals tapping against the polished floors. I walk with caution, not knowing where I’m going or who I might see. I don’t even know everyone who lives here.

A feeling of unease floats around me, almost as if it’s telling me to turn back around. I try to brush it off, because I don’t want to be stuck in a room anymore.

But minutes later, when I see a figure staring back at me at the end of the hallway, I realize that feeling was my intuition. And I should’ve listened to it.

It’s Wolfgang’s father.

He looks like he was going somewhere, but he halted there just to see me.

I stop, too, not knowing how to react. All I know is the hairs on the back of my neck are standing up. I want him gone—his cold eyes fucking terrify me.

They linger on me for what feels like forever, and I stand unmoving, watching him analyze me.

I don’t realize I’m holding my breath until after he disappears, and all the air in my lungs leaves me fully.

By the time I figure out where the dining room is, I’m still a little bit rattled.

A faint murmur of cutlery and movement guides me toward a large open doorway, and when I step inside, the scent of fresh coffee and buttered toast fills the air.

And then I see him.

My husband sits at a large dining table, his broad shoulders relaxed as he looks down at his phone and sips his coffee, his biceps flexing deliciously when he brings the cup to his mouth. The mouth that licked my pussy like it was starved.

Jesus, Victoria. Get a fucking hold of yourself.

But the sight of him sends heat curling through my core—until he finally glances up, and his golden eyes lock onto mine.

“It’s Sunday. Ever heard of sleeping in?” I say.

Approaching the table, I drag a chair out for myself and take a seat. Almost immediately, another housekeeper brings coffee, placing it in front of me.

“Thank you.”

I wait, watching my husband, expecting some kind of sarcastic or arrogant remark, as always.

But Wolfgang says nothing.

The warmth in my chest falters, and nerves swarm in my belly, but I push past the feeling. Maybe he just didn’t hear me. Leaving out a sigh, I pour milk into my coffee and stir.

“I guess you’re not a morning person after all.”

Still, nothing.

I put my teaspoon down and look at him, the realization slowly dawning on me, twisting my insides and making my stomach churn with unease.

He heard me alright. He’s just choosing to ignore me.

“I’m talking to you,” I snap.

“And I’m trying to enjoy the only spare moment of my day in silence. What can I do for you, Victoria?”

What can he… what can he *do* for me?

The question slaps me in the face like a big ‘fuck you,’ showing me just how little he cares about what happened between us.

My throat swells with pain, but I swallow it back down, hellbent on not letting him see through me.

“Ah, I get it,” I say, keeping my tone amused. “You’re one of *those* men—the kind who go all ghost mode the morning after. Not very original.”

“We fucked, Victoria. Did you expect me to fall in love with you?”

“Did you expect me to care if you did?”

He gulps the rest of his coffee. “Oh, believe me, love, when it comes to you, I have no expectations. Now, let’s not make this awkward. Eat your breakfast quietly or find somewhere else to be.”

I blink, truly taken aback by his change of attitude. He used to mock me, tease me, banter with me. But he was never mean to me. Not even when I stabbed him.

Maybe this has been his plan all along. To get my guard down around him… then treat me like shit, just so he can break another thing in me.

And if that's true, I fell right into his trap like a goddamn idiot.

"You're a fucking asshole," I tell him, trying my damnedest to keep from crying.

He stands up, tucking his phone away. "But you knew that already, didn't you?"

Then he turns his back to me and walks away, and when my first tear rolls down my cheek, I let it.

A moment later, the only thing that makes me wipe it away is the sound of heels clicking against the floor.

"Men can be so cruel sometimes, can't they?" a woman's voice approaches. "But my step-son… Well, he's on a completely different level. Hello, Victoria. It's lovely to finally meet you."

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VICTORIA

Ekaterina Rykov is supposed to be a fifty-something-year-old woman. And like any woman her age, at least a few faint lines should carve her face, telling the story of a life well lived. But this isn't the case.

Her features are tight, pulled back as if her skin hasn't matured at all. Or, as if every time it tried to follow the natural progression of collagen loss, Ekaterina found a way to keep it glowing.

That, together with the jewels hanging from her ears and neck, plus the Louis Vuitton pleated dress, makes her look like exactly what she is—the wife of the most powerful criminal in the country.

I saw her briefly at the wedding ceremony, but I was too stressed to take her in fully. Now that she's here, though, smiling at me with her white veneers, there's no way I can ignore her.

"Don't let it get to you. This is what he does when something entirely unrelated bothers him…" She sighs, taking a seat next to me. Fresh coffee is brought for her, and I swear the staff are even faster this time around.

"Who says I am letting it get to me?"

“Oh, darling, you’re not a very good liar. Your face tells me more than your words ever could.”

I nod bitterly, not knowing what else to tell her. I feel sick to my stomach, and I can’t imagine eating anything right now. But I don’t have anywhere else to go.

A warm hand touches mine, and I jolt a little at the strange sensation. No one has touched me with kindness since I got here. Not truthfully, anyway.

“You’re going to be alright.”

I glance at her with glassy eyes, wanting to believe her.

“I know you have no reason to trust me, but I’ve been where you are.”

“You were… forced into marriage?”

Her hand retracts and her lips press into a thin line. “Forced. Used. Manipulated. All the above. And let me tell you, darling, we deserved better.”

“And you’re still here? After all these years, you could’ve…”

“What? Left?” She gives a short, amused laugh. “There’s no leaving a Rykov man. He will hunt you down and drag you right back where you belong, even in death. But…” She smirks. “You can play him like an instrument if you learn his weak spots.”

“I doubt Wolfgang has any. If anything, he’s been the one playing me all along.” I shake my head. “Why are you telling me this, anyway?”

Ekaterina clicks her tongue, raising the cup of coffee to her lips. “Every single man has one. And it’s usually the very thing you’re upset about right now.” She sips, and I snort, amused.

“So you overhead the entire conversation, then.”

“I do apologize. I didn’t mean to.”

I shrug and remain silent, lost in thought as I peer through the large windows overlooking the front yard. Two armed men do their rounds, securing the perimeter. This entire property is so big I rarely see anyone around. But down here, in this wing, seems to be where everything happens.

“Tell you what,” Ekaterina says, getting my attention. “Why don’t you come shopping with me today? You look like you could use some time away from this house.”

“Shopping? Like… to the mall?” My brows rise.

“That’s usually where the clothes are, yes.”

There’s no way in hell Wolfgang would let me leave the house with her. Those goons he has scattered around the property would drag me right back.

“You’re a Rykov now,” Ekaterina says, reading my mind. “And it gives you plenty of rights. Before, you were the daughter of a traitor—and that only granted you a room with a lock on the door.”

That explains why I was left to my own devices this morning. I hate that my change of name is what granted me back my liberties. But at least I have them now.

I nod, and Ekaterina puts down her coffee, calling out for someone over her shoulder. Moments later, a man—another goon—shows up behind her.

“Be a good man and bring the car around. Victoria and I are going out.”

She pushes back her chair, dragging across the floor with a groan as she flashes me an enthusiastic smile. I leave the table to freshen up, dabbing at the probably smudged mascara under my eyes.

And as I take the corner to go back to the staircase, Mikhail is there, blocking my way.

I halt, jolting almost, sensing the shift in energy. Sensing the danger exuding from him, from that scar across his left eye and all the tattoos that suggest a dark, perhaps tragic past.

What is he doing here? Was he spying on me? On what we talked about? As big as this house is, there doesn't seem to be much privacy.

Inhaling, I square off my shoulders and move to walk past him, wanting him to know I'm not afraid. If he can see through me, he doesn't show it. Yet, once again, he shifts and blocks my way.

"Whatever it is, I don't want to talk to you," I say.

"Too bad. Because you're still going to hear it. My mother…" His eyes squint. "Stay away from her. She's not your fucking friend."

"What is this? A warning? Or a threat?"

"Think of it as a suggestion." His shoulders rise on the last word.

"Right. A suggestion… from you. I think I'll pass, but thanks."

I step to the side, and he extends a hand between us, stopping me. I look down at it, then dare to look him in the eye.

"Do what you want. But if you're going to ignore it, the least you could do is watch your back."

WOLFGANG

I should walk away.

Like the night I raked my eyes over Victoria's perfect body when I first brought her here, I should turn my back and fuck my fist to take off the edge.

I'm supposed to keep my eyes on the prize—not because Father warned me a few nights ago, but because I know he wasn't entirely wrong about the reason I shot that asshole at the wedding. I fucking hate it.

Still, the way I left things with my wife doesn't sit right with me.

No matter where I go or what I do, she's in my head. Her presence lingers. My body begs me to sink into her again, to taste her, to remind her she's mine.

Staying away only makes it look like she's the one who owns me, not the other way around. So my coming to her room right now has nothing to do with my "feelings"—it's about setting the record straight again.

Her room, yes. Because over the past few nights, we've been sleeping separately.

She took her stuff out of my bedroom and fled back to her prison willingly. At first, it made my blood boil. It took everything in me to let her go, to resist tying her to my bed and watching her squirm. But she's been distracting me lately, and I shouldn't have let her.

Upon entering, I take in all the clothes and toiletries she brought back from whatever shopping she did with Ekaterina.

My eyes trail up her naked thighs, beneath the oversized t-shirt that covers her hips. It's gotten so hot outside that I'm surprised she's not sleeping naked.

I approach her bedside, seeing her chest rise and lower with quiet breaths. A lock of hair lies across her plump lips, and I bring my hand to her face, gently pushing it away.

She looks so peaceful right now.

It's hard to remember she actually hates my guts. That's alright. I don't plan on changing her mind about me, but she still might when she wakes up with my tongue all the way up her sweet cunt.

Placing what I brought with me on the bed, I take both of her wrists and pin them above her head. She stirs a little, but it doesn't wake her up. Not even when I wrap my belt around them and secure the length of it to the hooks installed on this bed and mine.

I pry her legs open with my knees, making sure she won't be able to close them up. As I pull her panties to the side, I pick up a butt plug. I slide it up and down her pretty slit, stroking her gently until beads of arousal glisten at the entrance of her cunt. Then, I simply push it between her walls and start gliding it in and out.

The metal grows slicker, her pussy swallowing it up. A small whimper leaves my wife's chest, her face scrunching.

I smile, imagining the kind of dream she's having. Wondering if she's bouncing on my cock, demanding that I beg for her forgiveness.

If she asked me, I would.

When the plug is wet enough, I swirl it out of her pussy and take the bullet vibrator, bringing it to her slit. I turn it on at the lowest level, securing it by pulling her panties back over it.

A soft buzzing sound fills the room, and Victoria's head moves to the other side, stirring more this time.

Taking the wet plug back in my hand, I move her panties away, only above her asshole so the vibrator stays in place. I push it inch by inch inside, watching the motion. Her face contorts some more under the new sensation, her hips rocking into the object.

My cock throbs, asking for her. It won't be tonight, but I can't wait to fuck her in the ass.

When I look back up at her, her blue eyes are wide open with a deep frown.

"*You*," she seethes, her voice laced with pure hatred and a hint of the pleasure I'm inflicting on her.

I smile, loving the conflict splayed on her pretty face.

"Yes, love," I say, pushing the plug deeper into her ass. "I hope you weren't expecting someone else."

She sucks in a breath and pulls on her hands, realizing she's tied up.

"Maybe I was. Maybe Mikhail and I were planning on some alone time."

Hearing another man's name coming from her lips makes a muscle tick in my jaw.

Do I deserve it? Maybe. But I won't admit that.

I push the plug all the way, then cover it up with her panties. She stirs beneath me, writhing softly as if she's trying to deny herself the pleasure. I lean above her, bringing my face close to hers.

"Ah, I know. I'm an asshole. And I hurt you."

Whimpering and pulling down on her restraints, she struggles to roll the words off her tongue, “You didn’t hurt me. You annoyed me. There’s a difference.”

“Then let me make it up to you,” I whisper against her lips, aching to touch them with mine.

“You don’t deserve me after what you did.”

“I don’t. But you deserve to feel good right now. Tell me I’m wrong.”

I bring my hand between us, stroking the objects pressed against her cunt and ass. A moan rumbles from her chest, and her body sags, no longer resisting the restraints. *Fuck*. She’s so goddamn perfect when she falls apart.

“What is that…” she breathes out. “What did you do?”

“This? Just a small plug I pushed inside your ass. And this.” I move my hand higher up. “You know what this is. Haven’t you used one before?”

She shakes her head, her whole body warming beneath my fingertips. I love how embarrassed she gets when I tell her how things are. I smile above her lips, satisfied that I get to teach her everything about her own body. That I’m the only one she’ll ever need to make herself come.

“Are you telling me you’ve never touched this pussy with anything other than your hand?”

“So what if I haven’t? I wasn’t interested in”—she moans—“stuff like that.”

My fucking God.

Unable to contain myself anymore, I press my lips to her soft mouth, my tongue darting out to find hers. To my utter surprise, she finds mine first,

and I groan, feeling the same sleek and sweet flavor of hers that I only ever tasted back in the church.

I stroke her gently, in waves, mimicking the motion I'd inflict on her pussy if I were kissing her between her legs. Her back arches, and it doesn't take long until she shatters under me. Her body trembles, legs twitching as her orgasm washes out of her, taking her by surprise.

I bring my hand to the hem of her t-shirt, snaking it underneath, cupping her round breast. Her nipple is hard, and my mouth waters, wanting to pull it between my teeth. I want to taste all of her. I want to feel her until I'm satisfied. But no matter how many parts of her I possess, I'm starting to believe that feeling will never come.

She's fucking mine, and nothing else should matter. It shouldn't, yet it does.

And if I had any sense, I'd stop this now… before I'm too far gone.

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17

VICTORIA

I wake to hard, muscular arms around me—half on my body, half splaying over the sheets. Charcoal sheets. Which means Wolfgang carried me back into his bedroom last night.

Why would he do that? After he made himself clear about not giving a fuck about me, it makes no sense. And yet, his hold is strong, possessive. As if he wanted to make sure I wasn't going anywhere while he was asleep.

I try to shift, to turn around, but his hold tightens, pulling me closer to his body.

A sleepy groan rumbles from his chest. "I think you're onto something, love," he says. "Sleeping in is so much better than waking up when it's still dark."

I haven't forgiven him. I'd like to, but since he hasn't even apologized, he probably meant every word he said after our wedding night. So even though I see the effort he's making to break the ice, I won't accept it.

If you want to break an iceberg, better come prepared with more than a goddamn pickaxe.

“Shouldn’t you be downstairs, enjoying your only spare moment by yourself?”

“Mmm. Normally, I would. But turns out this—with you, in our bed—is a thousand times better,” he says, sliding a warm hand under my t-shirt, splaying it across my abdomen. Butterflies spur to life beneath his touch. I hate it, so I try pushing him away.

“Maybe for you. Move over, Wolfgang. I’m getting up.”

“Victoria…”

“No, no *Victoria*. You were right—last night, I deserved to feel good, and I let you touch me like that. But make no mistake, I’ve never wanted you, and I still don’t. In fact, the only reason I’m with you is because I have no other choice. You’d be wise to remember that.”

For a second, his hold on me loosens, but only enough for him to flip me on my back and tower above me, hand on my throat.

I expect him to squeeze, to make me regret what I said. Part of me wants that. But his eyes shift across mine, his handsome features brightening under the morning light.

“If you want an apology…” His voice is low, laced with sleep. The roughness of it makes me press my thighs together. “I don’t do that.” A muscle ticks in his jaw. “But if you think I left that morning because I regretted it, you’re wrong. I shouldn’t have been an asshole about it.”

I snort, looking to the side and back at him.

“You’re going to have to do better than that. Get off me,” I say, wrapping my hand around the one he has on my neck. “I need coffee.”

He watches me a moment longer, as if there are still words he can’t make himself say. We wait in silence, eyes locked, until, to my surprise and

disappointment, he releases me. And I get up.

***

The library floor creaks as black polished shoes walk inside.

My eyes flick upward, catching Mikhail's silhouette, before I return to *Crime and Punishment* in my hands. I'm curled up on a divan sofa Ekaterina showed me during a house tour.

Other than flipping the page, I don't make any sudden movements. I haven't had much contact with him since the day Wolfgang introduced us, and being alone in the same room makes me feel uneasy.

Turns out he was the one who tried to scare me when I got here with his stupid whistles at night.

His mouth twitches with a subtle smirk. "So you've found the family treasure. I never liked that book."

"Having trouble relating to the guilt-ridden murderer, I suppose." I keep on reading, hoping he'll go away if I appear disinterested.

He walks farther into the room, scanning the titles on a random shelf with his eyes. "Every man has a conscience, sis. Some are just better at ignoring it than others."

"Don't call me that."

Grinning, he picks up a book, handing it to me. "Here. Your husband might enjoy this one. It's about a man who hesitates too much and loses everything."

I peek at the cover—*Hamlet*. What a bastard. I refuse to take it from his hand.

When I leave him hanging, he puts it on the table in front of me and chuckles—a clipped, knowing laugh. “You’d think someone in his position ought to try a little bit harder. But who am I to judge…”

“And what position is that, Mikhail?” I put my book face down in my lap.

Shoving his hands in his pockets, he squares his shoulders, cracking his neck as he takes a dominating stance.

“That of a man fighting for a throne he’ll never sit on. Because while we might be tolerating him…” He shakes his head dismissively, “No one in this family truly wants him here.”

It’s not my fight, not my problem, but his words strike something deep in me anyway.

Heat crawls up my neck and behind my ribs, nostrils flaring above a tight, bitter smile. My fingers itch with nerves, tightening around the edges of my book like claws.

Yeah, I remember this feeling all too well.

Being unwanted. Discarded by your own, like you don’t matter. Maybe my husband and I have more in common than I thought.

“You know what I’m seeing right now, Mikhail?” I stand up. “A jealous, lesser man who wants what his brother has so badly that he doesn’t even realize how pathetic he is. I may have my own issues with Wolfgang, but at least he’s man enough not to speak badly of his family behind their back.”

“A lesser man…” Mikhail echoes, not looking upset in any capacity, but rather amused. “And yet, I took a beating for you. It was interesting to see how much my brother cared about you even before you became his wife…” he trails off. “Maybe, instead of jumping down my throat, you should pay closer attention to what’s really happening. He’s about to lose everything. And it will all be your fault.”

He laughs, and I'm stunned, at a loss for words. He took a beating for me? What does that even mean?

Why would Wolfgang do something like that?

Mikhail's presence unsettles me, so despite my curiosity I don't stick around to grill him for answers. Instead, I storm out, hoping he sees my anger, not my fear. But no sooner do I take a few steps when I bump into a hard chest, stopping me in my tracks.

"Fuck—I'm sorry, I—"

"Why are you running?" Wolfgang asks, looking down at me.

"I just, um…"

"What's wrong, love?"

Behind me, the doors to the library open, and Mikhail comes out. Wolfgang's eyes leave mine, glancing above my head. His jaw clenches, and a protective hand snakes around my waist, pulling me close.

"What did he do?" he asks, his voice thunderous.

I shake my head, sensing a fight I didn't mean to provoke. "Nothing. We were just talking."

"Talking," he echoes, as if he doesn't believe it one bit.

I take his scarred hand in mine, wanting to pull him along with me. But he isn't budging.

"Come on. I want to go for a walk."

"Care to tell me why my wife is upset?" he asks, glaring at Mikhail.

“I guess I recommended a book she didn’t like,” Mikhail says.

I turn, looking between the two of them, the tension so thick adrenaline shoots through me like a spring. I know how Wolfgang handles situations like this—I saw it firsthand in the church. Still, this is his brother, and that should mean something… right?

Time stretches for what seems like forever, neither of them willing to back down. Wolfgang holds me in place with his arm, so I wait, looking up at him with a frown. Hoping he’ll give in.

“Pick a better fucking book next time,” he says at last, then pulls me along.

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18

WOLFGANG

I'm supposed to be working, but I find myself staring at my laptop instead. I tell myself I'm just tired and distracted by all the shit going on in the business—seizing Nikolai's assets, deploying operations in the Irish territory we now own, and overseeing the usual.

But deep down, I know this has nothing to do with work. And everything to do with my wife.

Because she… defended me.

Mikhail ambushed her in the library, when he knew she'd be alone, and tried to poison her against me.

And instead of agreeing with him, like she should've, she bit his head off. She saw exactly what he was showing her. The jealousy. The resentment. The limits he's willing to cross to step over me so he can get what's rightfully mine.

But Victoria is smarter than he gave her credit for. And she stood up for me, even after I said that shit to her after our wedding night.

I pick up my phone and shoot Corinne a text, asking for my wife. After a few minutes, she replies.

C: she says she's busy, and that you do not summon her

C: sorry, not sure what to do

I smile, turned on by the way she still defies me. This woman has been testing me every day since I brought her here, and it's only made me want her more.

I don't fucking understand it, but if that's how she wants to play, I'm more than happy to indulge her.

W: She has two minutes to get here, or I'm sending someone to collect her

Then I switch over to my contacts and dial Ivan's number, instructing him to find my wife when the two minutes are up.

Because I know Victoria. She won't give a damn about my threat.

I get back to the work I'm supposed to be doing. Soon her agitated voice approaches from the hallway. Ivan opens the door to my study for her, pressing his lips into a thin line, as if to say, "good luck with that."

My eyes shift to Victoria, who dusts herself off and steps inside, arms crossed at her chest. Ivan leaves, and I sit at my desk, watching her.

"What part of 'I'm busy' don't you get?" she sneers.

"Come here, Victoria."

She huffs a breath of frustration, but otherwise walks deeper into the room.

"What do you want?"

I tap the top of my desk, loving the way she frowns when she understands where I want her to sit.

“No. I told you already, you won’t be getting anything from me anymore. If you want to fuck, get yourself a hooker.”

“Love… this is the last time I’m asking nicely. Be a good girl and sit on my desk. Now.”

The look she throws me is murderous, but she complies.

With slow, graceful movements, she inches forward, rounding my desk before entering my personal space, hauling herself up on the mahogany between my legs. My gaze lowers to her naked thighs, only covered by the short, thin layer of a pretty sundress. I don’t fail to notice the way she presses them together.

“Let me tell you something,” I say. “If I ask one of my men for an apple, they bring it to me. If I ask for my wife, they bring *you* to me just the same. And if I feel like bending you over this desk with your pretty legs spread and your cunt wet and ready, there’s not a soul in this house who’d dare stop me. Because why?”

Her upper lip curls. “Because you own me?”

“Because I own you, Victoria,” I say, planting both hands on her thighs.

Her mouth parts, a silent gasp pushing past her lips.

“And if I wanted to get a hooker, I would’ve done so already. And you would’ve known.”

“Please… as if you’re not fucking other women when you’re not with me.” She rolls her eyes.

I want to tell her that I don’t, but the fact that she brought it up means it matters to her. So I refrain from answering just to see if this is going to brew

inside her. To see if she confronts me about it at all down the line.

“I heard what you said a few days ago. When you were in the library.”

A crease settles between her brows. “You’re spying on me?”

“I don’t need to. The walls have ears around here. And they all report to me.”

She keeps watching me, probably wondering where this is going. And to be honest, I don’t fucking know. All I know is she defended me, and I didn’t deserve it. Not from her.

“Why did you do it?”

She looks away, knowing exactly what I’m asking. I swipe my hand across her smooth thighs, drawing a deeper breath from her chest.

“Why did you defend me, love? You said it yourself… I don’t deserve you.”

“It doesn’t matter. If I were truly your wife, that’s what I would do. I defend my own like…”

“Like I defended you in the church?”

She’s silent, but I don’t need her to answer more than that. Something tightens in my chest, my breathing mimicking hers. No one has done that for me before. No one has ever taken my side without asking for something in return.

“Why does Mikhail hate you so much, anyway?”

“It’s a long story. What were you doing?”

“What?”

“When you said you were busy. What were you doing?”

She shrugs. “Helping in the kitchen.”

My brows rise at the confession. I didn’t expect her to want to help anyone in this house.

“Find something else to do. I don’t want you there.”

“Afraid I’m going to poison you?” She smirks, but I’m in no mood for jokes.

I pay my staff three times more than what they asked, and make sure they have all the help they need to maintain the house. My wife shouldn’t be working, especially not for free. In fact, it really fucking rubs me the wrong way that she is.

“I said don’t go there anymore. Here.” I pull out my black Amex card and place it on the desk. “Buy whatever you want to keep yourself occupied.”

“Wow. You really think I’m stupid, don’t you?” She throws her head back, laughing a little. And fuck, it’s without a doubt the most beautiful laugh I’ve ever heard in my life—warm, candid, and full of life. “No, thanks. I don’t take money from anyone, let alone my enemy. God knows what I’d be getting myself into to settle the debt.”

I don’t realize I’m smiling until after her laugh is gone. And I’m annoyed at knowing there isn’t anything I can do to make her do it again. Because she hates me.

“You’re right to think that I’m your enemy, I won’t deny that. But I’m also your husband. And like it or not, this is your money too now.” My gaze lingers on her immaculate skin, my fingers digging a little deeper into her thighs. “So you weren’t busy, then. You just didn’t want to come to me.”

“Why should I, Wolfgang? All you’ve done is humiliate me. Threaten me…”

“Is that all I’ve done, love? Was there truly nothing else?”

She looks away, her thighs pressing together more. I wonder if she realizes she's doing it. My cock hardens at the thought of pulling her sundress up just an inch or two, hooking my fingers behind her panties, and revealing her bare cunt to me. To my watering mouth.

"You won't even tell me anything." She sighs.

"What do you want to know?"

"I asked you why you picked me over my sister. I asked you why Mikhail hates you so much. What you're planning to do with me… should I go on?"

"Kiss me," I say, taking both of us by surprise. "Kiss me and I'll tell you whatever you want."

"Wolfgang…"

A wave of heat traverses my body, from the back of my head to my chest, down to my cock. Just looking at my wife heightens all my senses, muting everything else around me. And it's not only because she's beautiful. It's because it's her. It's because she's wearing my ring on her finger and my diamond collar, and looks at me the way she does.

I suck in a breath, groaning on the exhale without meaning to.

"I told you, Victoria, I'll never lie to you. So if you want your answers, do it now, love, because I'm burning inside. I want that pretty mouth of yours on mine."

Her eyes shift across my face, not quite believing me, but wanting to. She inches forward, then a little more, leaning down, planting her hands on my face, until her breath tickles my lips and my heartbeat grows.

"Fine. But don't take this for more than what it is," she whispers.

"I'd never dare."

Then her lips are on mine, so fucking soft, and warm, and perfect. I stick my tongue out, pushing it against the seam of her mouth until she opens, inviting me in like the good girl she is.

Her tongue meets mine, and I grunt at how sweet she tastes. Her hands travel to my hair, her delicate fingers burying themselves in it, tugging and making a complete fucking mess of my breathing pattern. Of all that I am.

I'm about to pull her into my lap and wet my fingers with her arousal when—

"I gave you what you wanted," she whispers, pulling back. "Now tell me what I asked."

Her body leans away, hands leaving my hair as she takes away her lips, keeping them to herself. I sit there, eyes closed, bewildered by the way she just toyed with me. Bewildered, and amused, and needing more of what she just did, like I need air.

But I'm nothing if not a man of my word. So I open my eyes.

"It's not pretty—my story. Are you sure you want to hear it now?"

"Yes. I want to know."

I lean back in my chair, cracking my neck. "My mother died when I was four. Around the time Father was getting started with the business, so he was making enemies fast. But we were happy… and I was so young." I inhale, seeing the patches of my past flash through my mind. "She died on her birthday. A bullet took her life."

"Oh my God," Victoria says.

"Two years later, Father married Ekaterina—Katy, as he calls her—and they had Mikhail. But tradition is…"

"The first son becomes the next *Pakhan*," she says, her lips swollen a little from all the blood swarming there.

I nod once. “I was born with an unusually high IQ. It’s been an asset for the family business, and all the more reasons to take Father’s place. But Mikhail doesn’t see that. To him, I’m an abomination. I don’t even have a Russian name—and that, among other things, makes me ineligible to take Father’s place, even if it’s my birthright.”

A small pause settles between us, and it’s the first time we sit together in silence. As if some sort of mutual understanding passes through both of us.

How strange. And how easy it is to feel this way.

“It’s why I defended you,” she says. “I know what it’s like. I mean, you saw it… at my birthday party when my parents… they simply let me go. They didn’t lift a finger to—” She looks away, her eyes glassy.

I swipe my hand across her face, putting all my attention on her instead of what I just revealed. And I don’t know why, but I feel for Victoria. What happened that day was fucking wrong, and I’ve never been happier to put her family to shame than I am after seeing how they treated her.

“It’s also why I chose you,” I say, echoing her.

She looks back at me. “What do you mean?”

“It would’ve been in my best interest to marry your sister. Because she was wanted and you… were not.” She flinches. “My job was to take whatever your father valued most. But then I saw you, talked to you, and I knew it had to be you. It just made sense. *You* made sense to me.”

She keeps silent, and I delude myself into thinking she feels the same. But I know she doesn’t—she has no reason to. Only in my dreams, perhaps, she’ll kiss me again. Only there she might show me she craves me as much as I’ve come to crave her.

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VICTORIA

I should go, I know I should. But all I can focus on is my husband's hands on my thighs, squeezing, then releasing, as if he's fighting with himself on what to do to me.

And I can't help it—my pussy clenches, wanting him to do whatever he has in mind. His touch sizzles on my sensitive skin, and the way he looks up at me sends tingles all throughout my body.

I wonder if he realizes the effect he has on me.

When he dragged me out of my parents' house, I expected him to be cruel, to do all sorts of terrible things to me. But this? I never anticipated this, and I'd lie if I said I wasn't secretly enjoying it. Enjoying the way he owns me.

If I stay silent, he'll know he's getting me worked up. If I start talking, he'll know I'm deflecting. But if I don't pick something, and pick it fast, he'll pry my legs open, and he'll see just how wet I am for no other reason than being in his presence.

"Thank you for telling me," I say, tucking my hair behind my ear. "Now, if you'll excuse me, I have to…"

Nothing. I have absolutely nothing to do, and by the way he watches me—with faint amusement lining his eyes—he knows it.

He trails his hands up, making my dress ride until it's no longer covering my panties. I suck in a breath, feeling his thumbs tickle me at the apex of my thighs in a gentle caress.

A groan rumbles from his chest, and I breathe out an involuntary whimper. I can feel my arousal being smeared around behind the lace, and if he were to touch his inked fingers to my entrance, he'd pull them back glistening.

"I think your needy pussy is ready for cock, Victoria. Wouldn't you agree?"

My mind becomes a blur from the hormones breaking loose inside me. I close my eyes, breath trembling when he pulls at the edges of my panties until I'm bare for him.

I place my hands on his wrists to center myself. He's so hard there, as if it's where he holds all his strength. His skin is warm—hot, almost—making me think he's burning for me the same way I am for him. Only I know he's not.

All I am to him is a possession, nothing more. He made that clear the day after I lost my virginity. And yet… here I am, wanting more of the scraps he's willing to give. How pathetic. I realize it, and how wrong I am to want him, but I can't help it.

I spread my legs, deluding myself that this is me taking from him, and not the other way around. My husband lies back, knees apart, shaking his head slowly as if he can't believe my gesture either.

He takes my left foot, planting it on the left side of his chair, before doing the same to my right one. Secured in place, he brings his hands back to his lap, and unbuckles his belt.

I watch, mesmerized, completely frozen in place. The world could come to an end right now and I still wouldn't leave this desk. Wouldn't leave his

sight. Wouldn’t bring my knees back together. Not now, when his hard cock is free, and he extends his hand toward me, inviting me to his body, to the pleasure I know he’ll offer.

There’s almost no hesitation when I take it, and he pulls me in, my planted feet helping me down until I’m hovering right above his erection.

“You’re an equestrian,” he says, caressing my hair, murmuring in my ear. “So put my cock right where you need it most… and ride me.”

My pulse is pounding in my ears.

Being so close to him, so intimately, makes me second-guess myself. Hesitantly, I nod and gently lower myself into his lap, supporting myself with my arm around his neck, until his warm cock presses against my entrance. I exhale, looking down between us, then back at him. But when I do, he’s gone. His eyes are hooded, breath flowing in tandem with mine—scattered and uneven—his impatience showing in the sharp edges of his face.

“Don’t toy with me, love.” A low hum rumbles from his chest as he fists a hand in my hair, circling my waist with the other. Holding me close, closer, closer, until I’m all over him, and he’s all over me.

His lubricated head pushes at my entrance and my opening stretches to accommodate him.

“There’s my good girl,” he whispers, “there you are. Look at you, taking me so well.”

Butterflies spring to life in my core. I bite my lip, burying my face in the crook of his neck, his familiar cologne welcoming me. I breathe it in, whimpering as my pussy glides down on my husband’s cock. Down, down, down until I’m seated on his lap, and he’s inside me—not all of him, but enough that I can stop hovering. Taking a second to center myself, I lean back, and I’m met with his open eyes this time. Watching me. His self-

control is swimming there, in the gold of him, and I know it's only a matter of time before he takes charge. So I lift myself up, drawing our pleasure out, then slowly take his cock back inside.

"Ahhh…" I moan, dipping my head back, closing my eyes, his strong body holding me up in more than one place. He chuckles in my ear—a cruel but delightful laugh that's only broken by his groans.

Little by little, I lose myself in the moment, forgetting who we are to each other and what we've done… I let my hips remember the movement as I ride his cock like he asked. I take him in and out of my tight center, gliding over his lap until tingles spread from my pussy to the rest of my body, filling me with pleasure.

Wolfgang pulls me into his chest. Hand still fisted in my hair, he holds me in place.

"Fucking hell, love," he says, pounding into me, his control shattering.

"Oh, God…"

I dig my nails into his shoulders, and he stands up with me, lying me down on his desk. Sturdy as it is, the wood moves with us, screeching against the floor from his powerful thrusts.

A hand wraps around my neck and squeezes, and I swear to God something new awakens inside me. I melt into the desk, feeling everything in my pussy, my mind struggling to understand what is happening to me.

Involuntarily, I bring my hands to his wrist, my survival instinct kicking in. Even if my knees widen simultaneously.

"Tap my arm if you want out."

I do it, and he releases me immediately. I choke on the air I'm pulling in, my head feeling dizzy, empty of any thoughts. So much so that the only

thing grounding me is the way his cock thrusts.

More heat pools at my entrance, and the pleasure builds, builds, and builds, making me squirm under his shadow.

“P-Please,” I whimper, my body slick with a light trickle of sweat underneath my summer dress.

“Please, what, Victoria? Use your words.”

But I can’t use my words. I can’t, because all I’m feeling is him. All I know is him. And what I’m asking for is more of this, even though he’s already everywhere.

“Again,” I say, taking both of us by surprise.

My air is cut off once more, and this time, I come all over his cock, lightheaded. It feels as if I’m falling into the abyss, and there’s nothing I can do to stop it. Darkness takes over. My pussy clenches, squeezing the hard cock still thrusting and filling it up with more cum than it can take. It gushes out on my inner thighs.

Air fills my lungs once more, my vision returning little by little. And when it does, my husband’s face is above me, his scarred hand on my cheek, wiping away my tears.

“You’re okay, love. I’ve got you.”

A well of tears bursts out of me completely out of nowhere. Without thinking, I extend my arms up, reaching for him, and he pulls me up, cradling me to his chest.

His lips press against my forehead as he holds me. And I cling to him, fisting his shirt, crying, unable to grasp the underlying reason. He fucked me so hard I almost passed out, and my body loved it.

“You did so well, love. Let me take care of you,” he whispers, stroking the top of my head.

His tone is mellow, endearing, but strong, and it soothes parts of me I didn’t know existed.

For once, I don’t want to fight him. I don’t want to run away.

So I settle deeper into his arms, basking in the rare and gentle touches as my pussy holds on to his cum and the lingering feel of his cock inside me.

WOLFGANG

Panties down to her ankles, my wife nestles herself into my chest like she belongs. Because fuck, she does. I keep her knees bent with my arm, which lets me see her battered little pussy dripping with my cum.

I bring my hand there, pushing it back inside with a finger. She moans. And I can’t help but pump it in and out of her a few more times.

She’s so fucking wet and soft. My cock lengthens again. She’s everywhere—in my house, on my skin, in my head. And I don’t think I want her to be anywhere else at all.

She’s crying, she needs me, and I can’t make myself push her away again. Not like this. I might be a criminal. A killer. A lowlife. But I take care of what’s mine. And no one’s ever been mine the way she is right now. So raw, so vulnerable… baring herself to me like I’m her savior, not the monster who forced her into this.

In another life, maybe things could’ve been different—*I* could’ve been different. Maybe then I would deserve her… and she’d willingly give

herself over to me like she is right now.

“It’s called sub-drop,” I explain, stroking her hair, satin under my scarred hands. “It’s when a submissive comes down from intense sex.”

Keeping her face hidden, her muffled voice says, “And what is this called?”

“Which part, love?”

“This. What we’re doing right now.” She sniffs, rubbing her eyes with her palms.

A smile tugs at the corner of my lips. “Aftercare.”

She sighs, her breath trembling with the remainder of her tears. “I thought you didn’t care.”

I pull her panties up, and she lifts her hips a little so they can go back in place. Instantly, a wet spot appears from her arousal and my cum. Massaging her pussy through them, I say—

“I think we both know it’s quite the opposite.”

I fucking killed a man in front of everyone for touching her. It’s why I can’t bring myself to take her out of the house yet, even though I want nothing more than to show her off. But after Father’s warning, I’d be lying if I said I wasn’t worried about what else I might do for this woman. Pretty much everything I can think of would end up ruining my plans.

She pushes into my chest, avoiding my stare as she gets herself up.

“Thanks for… whatever,” she says, her cheeks flushing, soft pink.

I want to see more of that, so I don’t let her off the hook so easily.

“What a good girl. Thanking me for fucking her little cunt.”

She licks her lips, showing me a flash of her tongue, and without a single other word, she turns back around and leaves my study.

My cum drips down her thigh as she walks away, my cock hardening as satisfaction surges in me.

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VICTORIA

Before my eyes crack open, I can tell the other side of the bed is empty. Again. One, because I'm no longer leaning on Wolf's hard chest, but on a soft pillow instead. And two, because something—or someone—moves through the room, the sound bringing my body back to life.

For a moment, I think about pretending I'm still asleep. Because the memory of what I did comes to the front of my mind, and I realize I'm not ready to face my husband just yet. I can't.

It's one thing to fuck the way we did… and another to fall apart in his arms. To bare my soul to the one man I'm supposed to always keep my guard up around.

After what happened in his study, I went back into my room. And shortly after, he came to take me back to his bedroom, where he laid me down on his sheets and stroked me with his fingers.

I took it, took all that he was giving me, because I needed it, and I think he knew that. I think it's why he did it, though he hasn't uttered a single word about my breakdown. And neither have I.

My eyelashes flutter carefully, and darkness welcomes me, taking me by surprise. It's not morning yet.

What time is it? And why am I waking up?

Wolf's tall silhouette comes into view as he secures his watch around his wrist, dressed up as if he's about to leave.

I blink a few times, dusting off the sleep from my eyes.

"What time is it?" I whisper so quietly I'm not even sure he heard me.

But when his gaze lifts from his wrist and sees me, I know he did. He saunters over to my side of the bed, where he strokes my face with his knuckles. I shiver at the effect he has on me with just a simple touch.

"Go back to sleep, Victoria. It's late."

I look up at him, confused. Disappointed. "Why are you leaving?"

"Every respectable villain goes to work at this time of night."

A smile tugs at my lips. "Oh, yeah? And what's on the agenda?" I yawn, suddenly feeling a lot more relaxed. "World domination? Robbing Santa?"

"Worse. But you don't need me to tell you that."

No, I don't. I'm already picturing the bloody corpse of the man he killed on our wedding day, and that's about all I need to know. Still, there's one question my mind keeps conjuring. And for whatever reason, I need him to answer it.

"Will you…" *Be safe?* I want to ask, but the words refuse to roll off my tongue. "Is it dangerous?"

His thumb slides over my lower lip, pulling it down, swaying it with a deliberate, circular motion. For a few seconds, he stays silent, just watching me. Stretching out the time. Making my breath hitch.

Then he leans down, pressing his mouth to mine, and my back arches, as if it’s been expecting him. Always expecting him. My eyes flutter, closing as I moan, a silent plea begging him to stay.

His tongue strokes mine, and I’m drowning in his essence, in the taste of him. But it’s short-lived. And before I get to tell him I don’t need a life vest this time, he murmurs—

“*Mne stalo trudno pomnit', zachem ya vse eto nachal… Chto mne s toboy delat', lyubov'*?”

My eyes widen at the sound of his voice in Russian.

More importantly, they widen at recognizing every single word he just uttered. I may not speak much in my grandparents’ language, but I understand it well enough.

With that, Wolf straightens up and saunters to the door, leaving the bedroom, and closing the door behind him. Meanwhile, I’m still here, alone and unmoving, trying to process it all.

It's getting hard to remember why I started all of this… What am I to do with you, love?

WOLFGANG

Tendrils of guilt weave their way into my mind as I exit the house. Darkness welcomes me, and I breathe it in, letting it seep into my pores. I

do this shit every day. There's no reason to feel differently about it now.

My shoes crunch through the gravel. A lonely owl surveys the forest surrounding the estate, flying above the three cars parked out front.

Ivan and a small group of our men see me as I approach, and he uncrosses his arms. "We're still waiting on Kiril. He thought he saw something near the edge of the forest. Went there to have a look."

I raise my brows at that, because no one ever sees anyone lurking around the estate.

"Then he can have a look," I say, "But we're leaving now. I want to get this shit over with by sunrise."

Ivan nods and reaches Kiril through his station. I advance through the group of armed men, rounding my car and opening the door to the backseat. Before I get in, I lift my gaze to the second floor. To where Victoria sleeps peacefully in my bed, completely unaware of what I'm about to do.

And there it is. The tightness in my chest, telling me I'm wrong.

I clench my jaw until my gums hurt and get in the car.

Half an hour later, I step into the shadow of a relic—the Romanovs' estate. All the lights are off, except one, showing me just how desperate Victoria's father has become. Staying up all night, trying to fix the irremediable. It almost makes me laugh.

Shutting the car door, I head to the entrance with Ivan and the others on my trail. The guards see me and move aside, because they, too, are mine now. And when I barge into Nikolai's office a few moments later, he is reminded of that fact as well.

"Funny how you keep on working when you're out of your job."

He springs from his desk, taking in the manpower I brought with me.

“What is this? What do you want? It’s fucking late.”

“I know it is. Which is why it irks me that I had to leave my wife naked in our bed to have to deal with you.”

“You son of a—”

“Uh uh,” I say, walking aimlessly around the room. “I don’t want to have to break your jaw before we have a conversation. Be good.”

“What did you do to my daughter?”

“Please. Let’s not pretend you give a shit about her now. How’s your other one? Enjoying her freedom?”

Face growing red, he points a finger in my direction. “You leave Anya out of this! Your problem is with me.”

The hypocrisy makes my blood boil. Once again, he’ll fight for Anya, but not for my wife.

I approach his desk, looking him in the eye. “My God. You’re such an idiot you don’t even realize you’re leading me straight to her.”

“What the fuck are you talking about?”

I don’t even bother to explain. Before Victoria, a night like this would’ve given me that adrenaline rush I’ve been living on for most of my life. But now? I meant what I said when I told him I’d rather be at home, next to my naked wife. Or rather balls-deep in her pretty cunt.

Muffled, high-pitched voices break through the silence of the house, followed by loud thumps and the sound of broken glass. I look up at the

ceiling, pressing my lips into a thin line. Nikolai looks too, realizing what's happening.

"No," he says, supporting himself with his hands on the desk before rounding it. "No! You leave them the fuck alone!"

I step away, only to grab him by his nape, twisting his arm at his back, shoving his face into the desk.

"This is what's going to happen, Nikolai. Your daughter and your wife are going on the market tonight, because you no longer exist. You're a ghost. A shell of a man. I already took everything that you were away from you. What, you thought I'd let it go, that I've taken enough? No, no, no. You know better. And if you don't, well, you should've."

"H-Hate you," he wheezes. "She'll hate you if you do this."

Pulling his head back, I slam it into the table harder.

"She already hates me. It wouldn't change a damn thing. Catch up."

I release him and he wheezes, still bent over the table. The screaming subsides, a sign that Anya and Nikolai's wife were taken outside. Officially, my job here is done. Our lawyers took care of the hotels being passed on to someone else in our network. His money is gone—we emptied his accounts a while ago, leaving him with nothing to his name. Now everyone he's ever known is gone, too.

And soon, so will this house. Because I'll burn it.

"We're done here," I say to Ivan, loud enough that Nikolai hears there's nothing else I want from him, other than his life. For that, I'll have to wait a bit more, otherwise everything I've just done won't have any real impact. It won't say "don't fuck with us."

I turn to him. “The next time you see me, be prepared to choke on your own fucking blood.”

I leave the room, then the house, and step back outside. Victoria’s sister and mother stand in front of the estate in their nightgowns, faces flushed from the fight, streaked with tears. It’s fucking brutal how I took them out of their beds, but it had to be done this way, otherwise Nikolai would’ve never believed it.

“Get them into the car,” I say to no one in particular. “Ivan?”

“Yeah.”

“Hold off on burning down the house for a few more days. And make sure the word doesn’t get out about this yet. I’m taking my wife out tomorrow, and I don’t want her to be upset.”

More like, I don’t want her to find out. Because what the world will know versus what I’ve actually done will be two very different stories. And if she hears the wrong thing… then Nikolai will be right. My wife will never so much as look me in the eye ever again. I can’t allow that.

I enter the car Anya and her mom were shoved into. Both trembling, watching me with pure terror in their eyes. Part of me feels sorry for them—the women are almost always innocent in our world. Sold to criminals as wives without ever having a say in it. Which is why another part of me is glad they’re feeling what my wife must have felt when I took her.

I take two blankets from the passenger seat and give one to each of them.

“I apologize for taking you out like this, but it was the only way.”

Neither says a word, their hands interlaced. I shift my eyes to their faces, to the many questions in their eyes they don’t dare ask. They must think I’m the fucking devil.

They cover themselves with the blankets, and eventually, Anya asks, “W-Where are you taking us?”

Her face is round, with soft edges, eyes smaller than Victoria’s. She takes after Nikolai.

I sigh. “I’m sorry you got caught in the crossfire, but life as you know it is over. I’ve arranged for you to go back to Russia. There’s an apartment there in my name. And you’ll be cared for in any ways you need for the rest of your lives.”

They look at each other, confused. They can tell this wasn’t part of the plan. And I hate that I have to deviate from it, but my wife would be appalled at knowing her family isn’t safe. I can’t allow that.

“What have you done to my sister? Where is she?”

“Safe. And she will always be safe with me. But if you choose to stay in America, there’s nothing I can do about the two of you.”

Her mother hushes out. “What about him? What about my husband? You can’t leave him here. He has no one. Please—”

“Your husband knew this would happen when he betrayed me. Now he’s simply living with the consequences. The question is, do you want to join him? Or will you take me up on my offer and enjoy your new life?”

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VICTORIA

He called me *love*. In Russian. Like it meant something. Like *I* meant something. But then he walked away.

I'm wearing his shirt now, long enough to brush my thighs. On the balcony of his bedroom, I sip coffee I didn't ask for and look out into the distance.

Trying to forget how I broke in front of him last night.

I don't know where he left or when he'll be back. But leaving like that reminded me he's not a good man. And I knew it already, obviously, but I'm not so sure I believe it anymore.

Are you a bad person if you only kill other criminals?

Are you a bad person if you make your wife smile and make her come?

I shake my head, dismissing my thoughts. Because they're crazy. Of course he's bad. He's bad for me, but God, he's got the most beautiful golden-colored eyes. And he's my husband. Mine.

The gates of the estate click open, groaning softly, a black car gliding into the driveway. Instantly, my heart rate picks up, my body inching forward, craving the sight of him, even though it could be anyone. But then… he steps out. I'm frozen, watching him move like a panther through tall grass.

He doesn't look up right away. But when he does, when our eyes meet, it's like we never left that bed at all. A smile tugs at his lips, and I melt into my seat, breath catching in my lungs.

He shuts the door to his car, and Ivan gets his attention to tell him something I can't hear from here. I take the opportunity to get up and go back into the room, leaving the balcony doors open for fresh air. By the time he comes upstairs, I've already taken a quick shower and brushed my teeth.

Towel wrapped around my torso, I apply a moisturizing cream to my face when I see his reflection in the mirror.

"Sleep well?" he asks, leaning on the door frame.

Heat courses through me at how handsome he is doing that. At the way he dominates the space, even when he's not standing straight up. I nod.

I thought about him last night. In fact, I thought about a lot of things pertaining to him.

"Come here."

I turn to him, gripping the edges of the sink behind me before making the courage to walk. He doesn't take his eyes off me. And usually, it makes me feel uneasy, exposed. But right now, what I feel isn't that. It's hunger. Intrigue. A little danger, too. The good kind.

I stop in front of him, tilting my head back to take him in. His cologne is hushed, musky, and he smells the same way he always does—clean and

masculine, with a hint of musk and spice. It's what I smelled like before I took a shower. And I want it back.

"Is it done?" I ask.

His eyes squint a little, like he wasn't expecting this question. But he nods, and relief washes over me, even though I have no idea what his outing was all about. I guess, for whatever reason, I'm just glad he's not hurt.

"I want to take you out today. Will you come with me?"

"Do I have a choice?"

"I've always given you a choice, Victoria."

It's true. In his twisted ways, he has been doing that. Never forced me to do anything I didn't want to. He could've raped me, hurt me—it's what you would expect from powerful men like him who take what they want. But he never did that. He even waited to have sex until we were married. At least he has some kind of moral code he seems to be guided by, and that's something I can respect.

Respect. A word I never thought I'd use to refer to him.

"What are you thinking?" he asks.

I look away and shrug. "What are *you* thinking?"

He extends his hand between us, untying the loose knot at my chest, making my towel drop. But other than blinking, surprised, I don't hide myself from him anymore. My body knows he's safe. And as much as I don't want to admit it, it *wants* to be seen and devoured. It wants him.

"That I would love to fuck your tight little ass."

My lips part, his knuckles brushing my breast. Goosebumps come out in his wake, sending a tremor throughout my body. He watches the action, seemingly fascinated by it—or by the way my skin reacts. This used to be the part where I had some sort of comeback. But right now, I'm thoughtless. The only words coming out of my mouth are—

"Will it hurt?"

Amusement—or delight—flickers in his eyes for a second. "Yes."

"But you will make it… feel good."

"Yes."

Heat floods my core and I swallow hard, offering a nod.

His hand leaves my breast, my skin empty and wanton in his wake. Taking a step back, he turns and walks into the room. And like a tamed cat, I follow him, chasing his affection for once.

He takes a seat on the armchair in the corner, and I go to him, stopping naked between his parted knees.

"Good girl," he purrs, looking up at me. "I want you to straddle my left thigh. Let me see your pussy wrap around me like that."

I bite my lip. My brows pull together because I'm confused. But I do what he asks. My naked body makes contact with his expensive suit. The pressure to my clit is delicious, and I shift a little, seeking more friction.

"That's it. Well done, love. Make yourself come."

I exhale. "But you said…"

He pulls a butt plug out of his pocket, as if all of this was planned. I follow it with my eyes, noticing its size. Maybe this is a mistake. How will that fit

inside me?

“Wolf…”

“Let me take care of you.” He leans forward, cupping my jaw with his wide palm, pressing a kiss to the other side. “You know I can.”

I do, and that fact is undeniable. I shiver at the touch of his lips, and my head falls back, eyes closed as I start swaying my hips back and forth. The material of his slacks is smooth but rough at the same time. It’s not skin, but it feels so good I start moaning in almost no time.

“So beautiful. You’re making me so proud,” he whispers.

I’m panting. My pussy leaks on his thigh, making the area wet and warm. I should worry about getting him dirty, but I don’t. I’m a little embarrassed, maybe, but the way he praises me wipes the feeling off my mind.

A hand reaches behind me, pulling my ass cheek open. I can feel the air caressing me there, in my tightest spot. A moan shakes my chest. He keeps praising me at the same time. His fingers trail over my hole, probing me, before one of them dips inside.

“Such a tight little ass,” he whispers in my ear while I hump his thigh. I reach for his neck, wrapping my arms around him for stability as he works his finger in and out of my ass. Pleasure floods me, squeezing my walls, drawing his name from my lips. If this is what he can do with his hands, I can’t imagine what he’ll do with his cock.

Wolf groans as he kneads my ass cheek with his other hand. He slaps it once, and the pain sizzles before it turns into pleasure. I rub myself in short, clipped thrusts, finding the tip of my orgasm through the movement. If I keep going like this, I’ll come.

His finger exits, replaced by a cold, wet metal.

“Shhh, relax for me. You’ll take this first before you can take my cock.”

I nod, mouth parted, face scrunching under the stretch of my hole.

“Wolf… it hurts. It hurts,” I whimper, my pussy pulsing against his thigh.

“You’re doing so well, love. Fuck, I wish you could see yourself right now.”

I melt a little when he says that, relaxing my body, and it gives him the opportunity to push the plug deeper inside me. It doesn’t hurt as much this time and I feel so full. The only thing missing is having him in my mouth.

“Oh my God…”

A kiss on my temple makes me shiver in his arms. “Come for me, Victoria.”

My hips thrust forward one last time before pleasure floods me again—stronger, harder. My legs shake, and I’m frozen in an arched position, my head back, feeling every spasm, every throb. Every wave of arousal washing out of me one by one.

Wolf leans back in his chair, watching me as I struggle to take back control of my breathing pattern.

Suddenly, I realize his hands are empty, and my hole feels fuller than before I came.

“Go put on something pretty. We’re going out.”

“What, like *this*?” I say, my face heating up. “What if… what if someone figures it out? I don’t think this is a good idea—”

“The only way someone would know I stuffed my wife with a plug in her ass is if they looked under your skirt. But by the time they do that, they’d already be dead.”

He doesn’t smile when he says it, and I know he means it. Which would scare me, if I wasn’t fucked in the head. My heart flutters. The only thing that makes me agree is that I’m pretty sure no one would be stupid enough to get that close to me in the first place. Not with him around.

“Okay,” I say, taking in a long breath.

I’m still on his thigh, naked and wet, sitting in my own arousal, my pussy pulsing softly. I wonder if he feels me through the material of his pants. His hand cups my face, and he looks me dead in the eye.

“Now be a good girl and lick my clothes clean from the mess you made.”

WOLFGANG

Something is different about my wife. About myself, too. I told her I wanted to fuck her ass, and instead of spitting in my face, she asked me if I’d hurt her. And if I’d make it feel good.

Either I’m coming up with signs that aren’t there or maybe, just maybe, she’s coming around. Maybe she’s not afraid of me anymore. Maybe she sees me. And chooses to be mine.

When she lowers herself between my knees, my cock hardens beyond what I thought was possible. She watches me, her eyes blue and hooded, with whatever innocence still swarming there about to vanish into thin air. Her tongue darts out, pink and soft. And the next thing I know, she licks the wetness she left on my pants.

I’m frozen. Time flows and stretches, dispersing, and all I know is her and the faint feel of her tongue. I groan, my chest heavy. This is the prettiest she’s ever been—right here, tasting herself and the proof of what I do to

her. My cock grows and grows, but I refrain from shoving it down her throat. From doing other filthy things to her. At least, until we get back.

When she’s done, she licks her lips and leans back on her heels, watching me like she wants more. Like she’s not satiated, like she knows I own her, and only I can give her what she wants. My lips tug at the corner.

I bring my hand behind her head and pull her into me, pressing my mouth to hers. So fucking sweet. The taste of her cunt lingers. Maybe now she’ll understand why I love to lick her.

“Good girl. When we get back, we’re fucking that beautiful ass. Yes, love?”

She nods, breathless and mesmerized.

“Go get dressed. Let’s get you out of here.”

She gets up and with quiet grace, she heads into the walk-in closet, giving me a sight of her round ass and the ruby that's peeking out of her hole.

Satisfaction, pride, amusement—they all course through me at the same time. Because finally, after so much going on between us, my wife has become my slut. She falls to her knees, starving, desperate, mine. And I fucking love it.

But something else is growing inside me… a sickness taking root in my mind. I tried denying it, I really tried. And yet, I no longer think what we have is enough.

I want more.

I want every broken shard, every breath, every goddamn thought she ever has.

I want the thing she guards, the thing no one’s ever touched.

Her fucking heart. And I want it now.

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WOLFGANG

I wait outside while Victoria gets ready. Lighting up the only cigarette I'm allowing myself this week, I inhale the nicotine and tilt my head to the sky as I exhale. It's a filthy habit I started for no other reason than to make my mind shut up, especially late at night.

Ever since Victoria came along, I haven't needed it as much. The only reason I'm doing it now is because I can't be thinking about her sweet little ass.

I want to take her out, give her something new to look forward to—she's been locked in here long enough. And if I get a hard-on again while I wait, and she comes outside looking perfect, all I'd do is take her right back. Rip whatever pretty dress she puts on, and lose myself between her legs a few more times.

So I breathe in the deadly substance, trying my damndest to clear my mind when voices get my attention from the garden wrapping around the house.

"…disappear with those lowlifes you call friends, while I'm here, all by myself, trying to salvage your future!" Ekaterina says.

Mikhail chuckles. “There is no future for us lowlifes, Mother. Now, is that all? Or do you want to waste some more of my time?”

The cigarette burns in my hand, reducing itself to ashes.

“You know what, Mikhail? Maybe your father is right to see things this way. Maybe you’ll truly never be as good as Wolfgang. God, it’s like you’re not even fucking trying–”

Movement catches my eye to my right, my wife approaching my side, looking absolutely flawless. Her soft, cream-colored dress, skin-tight, molds perfectly to her beautiful curves and breasts, no straps, my collar tight on her neck. The material has some sort of minuscule glitter particles in it, because she shines with every move she makes.

Her platinum hair is down and wavy, and she even put some makeup on—smoky eyes and faintly contoured lips that make her look like a goddamn supermodel. She’s the most beautiful thing I’ve ever seen, and I hate how much I need her to know it. I’m only just realizing I can make my wife shine to the true power she harbors inside her. A raw, primal need pulses through my chest, wanting me to keep doing it.

I smile to myself, choosing not to bother with what I just overheard in the garden. Whatever it was, it can wait. I just want to get the fuck out of this madhouse.

I take her hand, tapping a finger to my mouth to silence her as I lead her away from the scene and back into the driveway. When we’re too far from them to hear us, she asks–

“What was that all about? They’re… fighting?”

I open the door to the passenger side for her. “They don’t always see eye to eye.”

She bites her lower lip, eyes sliding back over to the garden, as if she can see them.

“You know, maybe you could find some middle ground with him.”

“With Mikhail? I told you, he and I–”

“I know. I know. It’s just… I don’t know. I was never close to my sister. And if she had thrown me a branch at any point, I would have taken it.”

I smile, loving how sweet and caring she is. With me, of all people.

“Let’s go.”

She tilts her head at me, as if to accuse me of not hearing her out. I am. But this conversation can wait.

***

The moment I help my wife out of the car, I know every man will look at her. And I know exactly how I’ll deal with it if they do.

I didn’t let Ilia drive us this time, wanting to be alone with Victoria. I don’t know why, since I didn’t initiate conversation, and she seemed to be elsewhere the entire ride. I kept wondering what she was thinking about, but never asked.

Now, we’re here. And it looks like reality is dawning on her.

She looks around at the bustling city—a steep contrast from the sheltered, mountain-side estate in Alemont City where I’ve been keeping her. Cars flash and honk, people hurry places, shops blink with lit signs. I watch her take it in, before taking her delicate hand in mine.

“Thinking about running, love?”

She keeps silent for a moment, staring at the sidewalk. Then her lips part, and without looking at me, she says, “I know you well enough by now to know you’d find me. Drag me right back and start all over.”

Had she said this a few weeks ago, I would’ve thought she’d given up, like that week she refused to eat and get out of bed. I hated seeing her like that. Breaking her wasn’t nearly as interesting as I thought it would be. But now? She’s not giving up. She’s accepting defeat graciously, making the best of what she has.

My lips curve upward. “Let’s go inside.”

Victoria’s heels click softly against the pavement as I take us into the restaurant. I look over my shoulder at the trail of my men following close. Usually, there’s not so many of us when I come to New York for business. But with Victoria here, I didn’t want to take any chances.

Rival families are always looking for opportunities to put a bullet in my head. I won’t give them the satisfaction when I’m out with my wife.

Le Ciel Noir is a restaurant I always come to whenever I'm in the city. I’ve known the owners for the past fifteen years, and they’re possibly the only two people in the world who smile when they see me. Even if they know who I am and what I do.

Coming here is like coming home for a warm meal after being on the road for too long. Which is why I never bring anyone with me—not for business, not for fun, and especially not for show.

“Good evening, Mr. Rykov,” Julian, the usual server, greets us. He looks at me with a plea in his eyes, and I nod, letting him know it’s fine to address her. “Mrs. Rykov,” he says, bowing his head. “Please, follow me. I’ll show you to your table.”

I pull her gently behind me, scanning the restaurant with my eyes. It’s already been cleared by Ivan, but I take the extra precaution. When we get

to our table, facing Central Park, I pull her chair out, and she takes a seat, whimpering a little from the object still in her ass.

The sound shoots right to my cock, giving me an erection I'll have to hide by sitting the fuck down.

Before I do, I lean down to her ear. "You make that sound again, and I'll have no choice but to kick everyone out. Even in my favorite restaurant, you're still the only taste I crave in my mouth. Remember that."

Her eyes widen, then glance around as I take my seat opposite from her. It's kind of romantic, you could say, with the sunset falling over the city, leaving trails of burned orange all around the pristine tables and the candle-lit space.

Julian comes in, pouring us my favorite wine and taking our order before I'm alone with her again.

"You haven't looked at me once since we arrived," I tell her.

Her fingers are steady as she reaches for her glass, eyes wandering everywhere else but in my direction. Is she being shy because of the plug? No, that's not it. She always blushes when that happens.

"I'm just seeing who's here."

"You think I'd bring you somewhere I can't protect you?"

"No." Her eyes slide slowly over to mine. "I think you like the idea that someone might try."

I leave out a hum of what I can only describe as satisfaction. She's not wrong. Not one bit. But that's not what drives the feeling. It's the fact that she's starting to know me. Understand who I am. If given the choice, would she choose to stay? Or would she bang her fists into my chest, demanding I

let her go? I guess we'll never know since I don't intend to give her that freedom.

"Did you wear that to test me?" I ask.

Her face leans on her palm, as if she's bored, a sly smile spreading on her full lips. "If I wanted to test you, I would've worn less."

My nostrils flare. I sip my wine, hoping to cool off. But it only makes the fire in my veins burn harder.

One moment she's sweet, obedient, and licking herself off my thigh. And the next, she's slow, deliberate, cunning—letting me see all facets of her. I'm finding it difficult to decide which one I like more.

"You told me something," she says, her finger drawing a large circle against the rim of the glass. "Last night. In Russian."

I pause, wondering where she's going with it. Of all the things I've said to her—threats, commands, filth whispered into her skin—she remembered *that*.

"I remember."

Her lips twitch. "So do I."

I frown, studying her. The way she says it sounds like a trap. Like she wants me to show all my cards when we're still in the middle of the game we play.

I look into her baby-blue eyes, at her long lashes closing in on them slowly and opening up again. And I know I should lie to her. Tell her it meant nothing. But the truth is, I know what I said. Why I said it. And I especially remember how her breath hitched when I did.

My hand tightens on my glass.

“You told me it’s getting hard to remember why you started all of this. That you don’t know what to do with me anymore. Did you mean that?”

I ponder my answer carefully, but I know there’s only one.

“I don’t say things I don’t mean.”

She tilts her head, surprised I confessed. “Then tell me one thing. And don’t lie.”

I smile. “Never.”

“What will happen to my family? I assume my father can’t get off that easily, with just me being married off.”

I look down at my glass, then back at her. A muscle ticks in my jaw. She wants to know if she can trust me. And I want to tell her the truth, but I don’t know if I can trust her either. Besides, this isn’t the time or the place. Anyone could hear us, and the information could easily reach Father. I won’t be as stupid as to reveal my cards out in public.

“You’re hesitating. Are you afraid to confide in me, Wolfgang?” She laughs under her breath. “Maybe I don’t give myself enough credit.”

Afraid, no. Cautious, maybe. She’s a powerful woman, even if she doesn’t realize it.

“I can’t answer that right now,” I say, watching her expression change into what looks like surprise, or misbelief. Or both. “You’re just going to have to trust me.”

She squints her eyes. “Trust you? Just like that…?”

I admit, I expected her question to have some bite to it. But it didn’t. It’s almost as if she *wants* to trust me, as if all she needs is for me to say yes to that. Maybe I’m closer than I thought to owning her heart.

“Yes. Just like that, love. I think deep down you know you can.”

She opens her mouth to say something, when–

“What a small world,” a man’s voice says to my right. I slide my eyes away from my wife to land on Luca Moretti, the Italian pianist playing at almost every party on the Upper East Side. Wrapped around his arm is Isadora Vellin, the daughter of an investment banker notorious for engaging in insider trading with his sister-in-law.

They’re not a threat, so I’m not surprised Ivan and the rest of our men let them in without texting me first. In fact, by the look on my wife’s face, it seems like they’re quite an interesting appearance. Or, at least, Isadora is.

“Where have you been, Wolf? We rarely see you at any parties these days,” she says, fluttering her lashes at me. The hand on Luca’s arm loosens, and she keeps shifting until she’s closer to my side of the table.

Luca doesn’t seem to mind—it’s not like they’re together, not really. Nobody is a real couple in Manhattan these days.

“Busy,” I say. “Besides, they’ve always bored me. You know that.”

Isadora laughs, this time planting her entire manicured hand on my shoulder, as if to keep herself from falling over backwards. Victoria squints her eyes, her face contorting, displeased. My eyebrows rise.

Is my wife… is she jealous right now?

I watch her closely as I keep throwing random answers into the conversation I can’t seem to get rid of. She’s a little flushed, but not the horny kind. No. She’s annoyed. And the way she leans back in her chair with her arms crossed proves that.

I smile, and she throws me a murderous look.

My satisfaction vanishes instantly when I tune back into the conversation to hear Luca say—

"…at least five men who would want to take turns with her all night. She's a pretty little thing. Would look good on camera for the world to see. Wouldn't you, sweetheart?"

My entire fucking body goes taut.

Fire licks at my veins.

I turn to look at him fully, and even Isadora steps back.

"What the *fuck* did you just say about my wife?"

VICTORIA

I can tell this place means something to my husband.

I wasn't looking for threats earlier—I was looking at the middle-aged woman in the back who seemed to smile our way every chance she got. She didn't come to us, but I figured she was the owner by the way she carried herself.

Who is she to Wolfgang? And why did he bring me here in the first place? Because in the next few seconds, he's about to cause a massacre. And if this place really means something to him, he'll regret doing it.

I shouldn't care. But I think I'm coming to terms with the fact that I do. With the fact that things are exactly as he said—my husband is my only ally right now.

Sasha can’t help me. My parents can’t—won’t. So I might as well make the best of what I have.

I look at him, rounding my eyes at the corners. Dipping my chin. A silent plea for him not to do what he’s about to do. It’s not the place, nor the time.

When he watches me, I don’t fail to notice the anger simmering there, behind those whiskey-colored irises. It makes them burn that much brighter.

“Wolf…” I say, carefully, then shake my head.

The man who came to our table stands quietly, awaiting a response to the disgusting things he said about me. Did it bother me? Honestly, not really. Because something tells me my husband would never do that in a million years. His possessiveness knows no limits. His rage doesn’t either.

“Don’t,” I tell him again.

Relief washes out of me when he smiles. “Anything for you, love.”

My heart skips a beat. Does he really mean that?

Then it all happens so quickly, I practically have no time to scream or react. Neither does the woman standing nearby.

The man’s hand is dragged onto the table forcefully. Wolf holds it in place, picking up a knife with the other one. And in the next second, the white tabletop is stained in blood. The hand is pinned to the wood, the knife’s handle sticking out of his crushed skin and tendons.

Quietly, as if he knows better than to make a scene, the man cries out. And shakes. Regrets every word he spilled from his mouth. “M-My hand. My hand…”

I sit in horror, watching him cry. In our brutal world, I’ve never seen a grown man do that.

Wolfgang presses down on the knife. “My sweet little wife here asked me not to kill you, so I won’t. But what I’ll do, Luca, is give you a warning. If you *ever* disrespect her again like that, I’ll take your other hand too. See who hires you then.”

I look behind my shoulder at the owner now staring at us. At the scene we’ve caused. She approaches, and when I look back at Wolf, his knife is back on the bloodied table.

“Mariette,” he says, “Please accept my apologies for the mess. Send our order and bill to the hotel suite upstairs. We’re leaving.”

Mariette shakes her head in disbelief. Wolf’s men come in to clean up the mess and take Luca back outside.

The woman he’s with continues to stare at my husband for a second too long.

“You can leave now,” I tell her, and although she scoffs, she complies.

Getting up, Wolf extends his hand toward me. I take it, and it’s warm—a stark contrast to his cold, cold heart with which he slashed Luca’s hand. When I stand in front of him, he draws me into his hard body. Right here, next to this bloodied table, in front of all these people. What is he thinking?

My pulse picks up. “If you kiss me… everyone will know.”

“Know what, love?” he murmurs. “That I want you?” He strokes my chin, his eyes darting down to my mouth. His head tilts to my ear, where he places a kiss so soft it sends a shiver down my spine. “That you’re mine?”

His mouth finds mine, his hand going to the back of my head, fisting my hair, pulling me close until my lungs ache for air. The kiss is gentle, but hard at the same time. He licks inside my mouth, bites my lower lip, and makes a complete mess of me.

I don’t know how long it lasts. All I know is that when he’s done with me… I’m not the same woman he brought into this restaurant.

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VICTORIA

I don’t know how high up the last floor is, but when I look down from the balcony of the suite, Central Park looks smaller than I’ve ever seen it. I step back a little, my head dizzy, colliding with Wolf’s hard chest.

“I’m sorry we had to leave, love. I never bring anyone to Roy and Mariette’s. And the first time I do, I make a fucking spectacle in the middle of their restaurant.”

I draw in a long breath before letting it go. “I told you not to. It wasn’t necessary.”

“No. You told me not to kill him. And I didn’t.”

It’s true. Though I’m surprised he understood just from the look on my face. I turn to him. His eyes shift across my figure, a question brewing.

“You’re not upset. Not as I thought you’d be.”

I shake my head. “I knew you’d never consider doing what that man said.”

“Did you, now?” He tucks a strand of hair behind my ear. “And why is that, Victoria?”

He looks so handsome. Under the dying light of the day, his jaw looks sharper, eyes darker, body bigger. More intimidating. I press a palm to his chest, letting my fingers brush the edges of his shirt, right where the buttons meet, down to his belt.

I don’t know what I’m doing. Or where I suddenly got the courage. But if what happened earlier proves anything, it’s that he wants me. And God, I want him too.

I want him on my skin, in my mouth, in my core, and everywhere else he’s willing to claim me.

I get to my knees, tilting my head back. His breath grows deeper, hungrier. He’s never seen me like this. *I’ve* never seen me like this. He watches me closely, not letting a single movement slide by as I slowly fumble with his belt until the buckle is undone. Then his button. Then I pull his boxer briefs down. His hard cock springs out, so big it fills my vision. All I see is him and how much he needs me.

I inch closer, darting my tongue out, giving it a soft lick. Salt and warmth seep into my senses.

“Because you own me,” I answer. “Even if this is all we have. I want it.”

Opening my mouth, I take him in. My lips round and stretch around his erection. It hurts a little, but I don’t care. The taste of him on my tongue and the way he groans above me make it up for it tenfold.

My pussy throbs, the plug in my ass turning everything to a new level—one I’ve never experienced.

He was right when he suggested I’d never had a cock in my mouth. I haven’t. And I don’t know how I’m supposed to do this, especially since not

all of him fits.

Instinctively, I take my hands and wrap them around the rest of his length, sliding them up and down as my tongue flicks across his head.

I pull him in. Push him out.

In. Out.

“Ah, fuck, Victoria… fuck…” he whispers.

His hand comes to the back of my head, his hips thrusting forward, all the way to the back of my throat. He holds me in place while tears form at the corners of my eyes. I can’t breathe.

“In through your nose, love. Breathe for me.”

He grunts in pleasure when my tongue wraps around the bottom of his length. And I try to do what he said—taking long breaths in through my nose. I relax, letting my hands come down to his thighs for stability. Then he thrusts again, faster, hitting the back of my throat.

I gag and he stops once more, caressing my hair.

“You…” he murmurs. I look up at him, his head dipped back, lost in his pleasure. “What have you done to me, Victoria?”

The way he says my name makes me ravenous. Something grows in my chest, a heat behind my ribcage igniting. I moan around his cock, then suck him faster. Eyes burning from my mascara running, I look up at him through tears, loving the way I’m making him come undone. Me. Not that woman who kept flaunting herself to him earlier.

He looks down at me, our eyes meeting. And he laughs. Laughs and groans as he spills his seed in my throat, losing control.

“*Christ*,” he says, chest pushing heavy breaths. “Don’t swallow. Stick your tongue out. Let me see it in your pretty mouth.”

Leaning back on my heels, I pop his cock out of my mouth and show him what he did to me. And how much I loved it. My tongue darts out, layered in his cum, some of it sliding off the edges.

And my husband… he watches me with a hunger I can’t describe. It’s as if the whole world stopped, and I’m the only other person alive with him right now. It’s thrilling. Raw. Dangerous.

I pull it back inside and swallow.

“I see you. And I know I shouldn’t want you, Wolfgang… But here we are.”

WOLFGANG

Wanting. Craving. Is this all we have? She suggested as much, but I know it’s not just that for me.

It’s the way she stretches her palm across my side of the bed when she wakes up. The way she looks up at me from under those long lashes, fire in her eyes. The way she listens. The way she defies. I’ve only had her for a few months, but I don’t remember who I was before she showed up.

I’ve failed. Taking my throne… punishing her family… it’s all going down.

She’ll be the one to ruin me.

And I’ll let her. What the fuck other choice do I have?

Brushing my thumb over her full lips, I swipe the last bit of cum she missed. She picks up on it, her mouth wrapping around my thumb, sucking. She's warm and wet, and it reminds me of her cunt. *Fuck*. My cock twitches, revived by the image that made me come—her tear-streaked face, the mascara shadowing her pretty blue eyes, and her pouty lips.

"Go lie on the bed. We're not done, you and I."

I help her up and tuck myself in, but only to unbutton my shirt and start getting undressed. Walking into the suite, I follow her small, deliberate steps. Clothes get thrown, pebbling the floor leading to the bedroom. She's never seen me like this.

I've always been careful, controlling what she saw, making sure she only ever witnessed what I chose to present to the world. But not tonight. Not after telling me she sees me for who I am… and choosing to stay.

She's splayed out on the sheets, waiting on her elbows with her legs spread, her perfect body, the collar, and the small diamond poking out of her ass making me rock hard again. *God*, fucking look at her waiting for cock like this. She's perfect. And she's all mine.

"Touch yourself," I say, keeping my eyes on her soft, glistening cunt.

"Wolf…"

"Do it, love. I want to see. Then I'll fuck your sweet little ass."

Her face flushes that familiar dusty pink. She looks away, timidly bringing her long, elegant fingers to her slit. Barely, just barely she touches that spot, a small whimper echoing from her throat.

Poor thing—she must be so worked up with the plug moving inside her every time she walked.

Her fingers glide up, then down, gathering her arousal until it makes a wet, ticking sound. She's drenched. I could drink her up.

"Please…" she hushes out.

"You're so fucking beautiful right now. Keep going. Keep fucking that pretty cunt."

She bites her lip, writhing in the sheets, hand between her legs. Her whimpers turn to moans, and I can't help but stroke myself as I walk toward her, then kneel on the bed, keeping her knees apart with mine.

"I've got bad news, love," I tell her, sinking into her drenched cunt. She wraps and stretches around me, the friction unbearable. It takes my fucking breath away.

"Oh my God…" She arches off the bed, rubbing circles around her pussy while I fuck her.

A moan rattles my chest. "We don't have any lube here."

"What…? I don't care. I don't care about that right now."

"You should. Because it's not going to stop me from fucking your ass."

I press my mouth to hers, tasting her warmth. When I pull back, she arches for more.

"You already told me it will hurt."

I know what I said, but she simply doesn't realize how tight her asshole is. And how much my cock will stretch her, especially without a proper lubricant.

I press my hand into the mattress beside her head and nudge the plug. Her whimpers return, and so do the circles drawn around her pussy. What a

good fucking girl.

Slowly, I pull the plug out, watching her struggle to breathe through the new sensations happening to her. My cock stuffing her pulsing cunt, the plug sliding out of her ass. Her fingers on her clit. I only wish I had something with me to fill her mouth with, but there's always next time.

Sliding out of her fully, I flip her over until her ass is facing me.

"Spread your knees, love."

She does, and I use both hands to knead her round ass cheeks before pulling them apart. Her small, puckered hole clenches slowly, still under the sensation of the plug. I lower myself to her body, licking from the bottom of her cunt all the way up to her ass.

She thrashes, not expecting it. "W-What are you—"

I groan, stuffing my face with her as my fingers dig into her soft skin.

"Tell me to stop, and I will. Otherwise, be quiet, love. Let me devour you in every way I can."

My tongue darts out, touching her hole, and she buries her face in the mattress, moaning through it. When I spit, she thrashes, but doesn't tell me to stop. So I get up on my knees and lower my cock to her hole, guiding it with my hand. Almost instantly, she cries out. I didn't even probe her with my fingers. I just want to be inside her right now.

"I know, love. I know. But you'll have to let me in. Relax." I kiss her shoulder, then her spine. She shivers, melting down with a mewl. "That's it. That's my good girl," I whisper above her, pushing myself another inch, watching how well she takes me. It won't go all in, that I know. But she'll take it, and she'll come with her little ass stuffed and thank me for it. And I'll reward her some more.

I push into my knee, supporting myself with one arm on the mattress as I sink into her a little deeper.

“I feel… so full,” she mumbles. “I’m so…”

I smile, feeling her hole stretch around me and suck me in like it’s supposed to. I can only imagine how much it burns. She’s being so obedient. So sweet.

“Look at you, love, getting fucked in the ass,” I say shifting back a little, thrusting again. Her delicate hands grip the sheets, only loosening when I stop.

I do it again. And again. Until my cock gets the friction it needs, and I lose myself in the feeling altogether. Pleasure shoots through me, making me harder, as I try to satisfy my need. But with Victoria, it’s never enough.

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VICTORIA

I brush my fingertips over his tattoos, the ink deep, faded. Various patterns—like old roots—curl around his arm and biceps, crawling up to his neck and down to his abdomen. I stop on his shoulder, where two small circles get my attention. Wounds.

I tilt my head up, brushing against his chest, only to catch him watching me.

“Snake bite,” he says, his voice low and deep, rugged with sleep. His hair is beautifully tousled, jawline shadowed with the beginning of stubble. I can’t take my eyes off him.

I smile. “Makes sense.”

“Why is that?”

Wolf swipes his hand over my naked hip, caressing me, and I can’t help but nestle myself deeper into him. He’s so warm and big—being in his arms makes my surrender taste sweet. In here, everything else is meaningless. And all the pain I harbor inside is suddenly gone.

“It’s the kiss of the devil,” I say, stretching like a cat. “He favors you.”

He puffs out a laugh.

“What? Have you never heard of the devil’s luck?”

“I have. But I don’t think it’s that. Because I make my own luck.” His hand cups the side of my face as he leans down to kiss me. When he pulls back, our eyes lock, and we stay there for a few moments.

This… is new. And I’m trying not to get my hopes up… because I don’t know what he’s thinking, and I won’t confess more than I already have. But for the first time in months, I’m happy. I’m held and worshiped in a way I’ve never been before. So I’ll take it.

“Does it ever keep you up at night?” I murmur. *The killing.*

He shakes his head, understanding.

“I was raised this way, Victoria. I don’t see the world in black and white—there’s a lot of gray in between. What is a tragedy for one man is the fortune of another. And the other way around.”

Like my father. Wolf took me from him, causing his tragedy. Is this his way of saying I’m his fortune? I stay on his rising chest in silence, thinking about it.

“And you? Does it keep you up?”

My eyes flick upward. “What exactly?”

“Not being able to ride. I took that away from you.”

As if on cue, I tense up, not knowing how to answer it. It doesn’t just keep me up. It rips me apart. Every day, I see those meadows, the forest, the

mountains. All I can think of is that feeling… the wind howling in my ears, the sun kissing my skin, my breath catching in my lungs. It's my drug.

I feel like I can trust him with the truth now, but at the same time, he's the one who took it from me in the first place. So I'm not sure how to answer him.

"Forgive me," he says, taking me by surprise. "I shouldn't have done that."

"You're… apologizing? I thought you never…"

"I don't have any regrets in my life, Victoria. None. Except the way I've treated you since I got you caught up in my life."

"But not forcing me to marry you."

"No. Never that."

"I hope you know how much of an asshole you were to me that day. After we…"

A slow, regretful nod. "I was. And I'm sorry about that too. But what I said wasn't about you. You got under my skin, and I hated it. You took away my sanity…" He sighs. "Threatened to destroy everything I've ever cared about."

"Which is what?" I whisper.

"It doesn't matter now," he says, disappointment squeezing my chest. Does he still not trust me? "I'll fix it. And you, love, are getting more than a small apology for what I've done."

A lazy smile spreads on my lips, my own voice, too, still hooded with the spell of sleep. "I'd love that, but I'm still so sore from last night…"

He kisses me again, and again. “Go get dressed. Let’s get you a horse, then we’ll head back.”

***

Hay. Leather. Hoof polish and barn.

In here, I can smell my childhood… my whole life.

Inhaling, I hold on to the scent like it might disappear if I close my eyes, like I’m not quite believing this is happening and the man who swore to ruin me is the one making my heart grow right now.

My husband’s hand is on the small of my back, leading me from stable to stable, but not stopping in front of any. I don’t care which one we get. I just want… want to nuzzle my face into one’s neck, inhaling the calming scent of their coat. And take them home.

Home. What a strange thing to say. But if he truly means it—if he’ll really do this for me… then maybe I can make the Rykov Estate my home. It’s the only place I’ve ever been wanted, after all.

The stable owner—Jack Mulligan, as he introduced himself—walks in front of us, answering Wolf’s many questions about the horses he picked out for me to look at.

“Brought in three options from the bloodlines Mr. Kasparov recommended. All fit for trail, calm temperament, light jumping experience,” Jack says.

I slow down, unsure of what I’ve just heard. But Wolf throws me a knowing look, confirming it. He didn’t just bring me here on a whim. He talked to Sasha. Asked him about my needs, so he knew what I’d want.

The thought that the two of them were in touch to discuss me brings tears to my eyes. The stables become webbed, blurry. And the next thing I know, my husband stops in front of me, his thumbs brushing my wet face.

“What’s wrong, Victoria?”

I shake my head between his wide palms. “I’m sorry. I just… you don’t know how much I needed this. I haven’t…” I inhale, letting the air out slowly.

“Everything alright?” Jack asks.

Wolf never takes his eyes off me as he says, “Go without us. We’ll find you.” His voice lowers, just for me to hear. “Talk to me.”

I swallow hard. “Every morning when I woke up, I had this… this empty hole in my chest. And no matter how much you distracted me with everything… at night… the feeling would wait for me to be alone again. Then it would…” I sob. “Tear m-me apart.”

“Fuck,” he mutters, pulling me into his chest. I wrap my arms around his torso, burying my crying face into his shirt. He smells so good, so familiar, it makes me cry harder. “I’m so sorry, love. I’m so, so sorry,” he whispers, his heartbeat strong and steady.

The rhythm grounds me, emptying me of pain. And it dawns on me now that although Wolfgang wrecked my heart and made a mess of it since dragging me into his world, he’s also the only one who knows how to mend it. I don’t need a home to come back to.

I’ve already got it.

And he’s right here, in front of me.

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WOLFGANG

I'm out in the garden, sitting across from an empty seat, waiting for Ivan to show up. Over the past week, business has been going on as usual.

The Irish territory is still with us—they haven't retaliated yet, and I don't expect them to do it for a while. They're having issues getting the next heir to his rightful throne. Turns out, he doesn't want it and I can't help but wonder if a woman is at play.

Still, we're on alert even though Kiril reported he found no one snooping around the house. But that doesn't mean we're just going to forget about it. In fact, it's exactly why I'm meeting Ivan—if he would ever show up on time.

I don't mind it, though. This way I get some time. Time to think about Victoria, about how much she's changed both of us.

She picked a dapple-gray mare with a long, black mane—a confident horse, but grounded enough to match her temperament. Out of all the ones Sasha and I picked for her, Alaska was the most curious, the most responsive. Plus, she seemed to have an instant connection with my wife.

Every day since then, I go by the stables to watch. The way Victoria rides—like she's one with the wind, and the sunrays, and the floating petals and dandelion fluff—makes my chest grow and ache.

I knew there was so much more to her the moment I spotted her on my stallion a few months back, but this? I never expected this. I've never seen her like this. And it's the kind of thing that gives me life.

She asks me to join her, and I want nothing more. But I know better. I don't deserve to step into the fucking light, and even if I did, I wouldn't know how.

Loud steps and voices register from somewhere to the left, snapping me out of my thoughts. In a few seconds, Ivan shows up with a bunch of armed men on his trail. What the fuck?

He shouts at me, and I make up the words "shooting" and "south side."

Exactly where my wife is riding right fucking now.

Before he has time to finish the sentence, I'm already running to her, heart beating strong in my throat. To the meadow. To the stables. To everything that matters to me right now.

My blood roars in my veins, turning me into the man I've always known—the man whose darkness knows no bounds, no limits to protect what he owns.

The house fades in the distance, and upon seeing the fields roll out, the thought grinds against my mind like iron on iron. *I'll scythe through everyone and everything if I have to.* She'll never even know the monsters lurking in the shadows for her. Because I may dictate that I own her, but the truth is… I, too, belong to her now.

VICTORIA

Stretching my hand out in front of me, I catch the sunset between my fingers.

The field bathed in an orange glow smells of daisies and tuberoses, wafting in the air all around me. A small, soothing wind brushes the hair off my shoulders and off Alaska's head. Her snout raises to the sky, a soft nicker rumbling from her warm body. She loves it. And ever since Wolf bought her for me, this kind of experience has helped us bond.

"I know," I say from my saddle. "I'm happy too."

My chest grows and grows every day on these meadows, making me whole again. Fixing parts of myself I didn't know were broken—not because of what Wolf did to me initially, but because everyone always took from me, never replenishing my love with theirs. I never realized just how empty I walked through life until now. Until I wasn't empty anymore.

I never thought I'd say this, but I've built up a little routine here that I enjoy.

My days are filled with the smell of freedom, of letting loose under my husband's hold over my body. And every night, when I return from the stables with the wind in my hair, he licks between my aching thighs, praises me and stuffs me with his hard cock, stretching me out.

We have coffee on the balcony every morning now, and he tells me things he's never told anyone—the things he's done, the things he dreams about. I haven't told him this yet, but I think… I think I want my husband more each day and the life he laid out for us.

I let Alaska take me down into a small valley peppered by small bushes and wildflowers. The day is ending, and we should be heading back. A thrill flashes through me at the thought of showering with Wolfgang, of being held by his strong arms while he bends me over and…

A loud bang shatters the silence.

Alaska freezes, her ears flicking back.

In the next second, she rears up, pushing off her hind legs with a violent force, lifting her body—and me—into the air.

Her sharp neigh cuts through the air as she bucks, and despite my grip on the reins, I'm thrown off, tumbling to the ground. Alaska stands, tense, snorting, her chest heaving as she recovers from the shock.

"It's okay, girl. It's okay," I tell her while I push into my arm.

I'm not hurt, I don't think, but I could also be running on adrenaline right now.

Someone shot at me. At us. And they missed, which means… they'll attempt it again.

But Alaska looks too frightened for me to get back on the saddle. No time for comfort, I push into my limbs and stand up, gripping the reins in my left hand while I pull her with me, protecting her from the direction of the bullet.

She doesn't have to think twice—as soon as I start running, so does she. She's faster, and I haven't done this in a long time, but I have to try. For her.

Because if anything happens to her, not only will I never forgive myself, but I…

“Victoria!” a faraway voice calls out. A voice that’s deep and desperate, and one I’d recognize out of a million. I squint my eyes and see my husband running toward me at full speed. He calls out for me again, and again, and again, and every time he does it, I know we’re a little closer.

Another bullet flies off somewhere around me and I fall to my knees in horror, screaming.

Alaska pulls the reins so hard they fly out of my fist and I can see her running in front of me. She’s not wounded. She’s not. If she were… then she wouldn’t be running. She wouldn’t.

Once again, I try to get up, but more bullets fly by.

They seem to be going right past me.

I scream, and scream, and stay with my eyes closed until…

Strong hands wrap around me, pulling me close. “Hey. You’re okay. Look at me, love,” Wolf says, his body solid against mine. “Victoria.”

My trembling eyes crack open, and my husband’s face comes into view. He looks focused, cold almost, a stark contrast to the warmth emanating through his hands. His gaze shifts across my body, as if to check for any scratch.

“A-Alaska. She ran off…”

“Ivan and the others were behind me. Someone got her, love. I promise.”

I shake my head. “You don’t know that. Please… she could be hurt.”

“You’re shaking. Come here. Let me hold you.”

I protest, and he holds me against his chest until my voice quiets down and my breathing returns to its normal pattern. Safe. Being in his arms is safe,

and if he’s here, it means I have nothing to worry about. I know that much.

The sound of many footsteps sounds around us.

“Ran off?” Ivan asks as he catches his breath.

Wolf’s voice reverberates through his chest, right against my ear. “Killed one. I don’t know how many there were.”

“We’ll find out who it was.”

“The horse?” Wolf asks, and my heart skips a beat.

“Yeah. Someone’s taking her back to the stables. She wasn’t hurt.”

I sag against his body, relief washing over me. The footsteps walk by us, fading away.

When I feel my strength has returned, I pull back. “I was riding and then… there was a bullet, and…” I frown, confused, as my heart picks up again. “Wolf, what’s wrong?”

“I…” He exhales, closing his eyes for a second before opening them up again.

I press a palm to his heart, knowing just what I want to hear from his lips, encouraging him to say it, even if I haven’t said it to him either. Maybe he doesn’t feel the same. Maybe I’m deluding myself.

Or maybe this is all real.

“You scared the shit out of me.” He sighs. “Never do that again.”

I offer a faint smile. He just saved my life. That should be proof enough he cares about me now. But then why do I need him to spell it out?

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VICTORIA

Alaska eats her mix of timothy, orchard, and teff in silence in her stable. Wolf's black stallion is here too now—he said he took it back from my father's—bringing back memories from when I was failing to ride him. Both horses look unbothered as they enjoy each other's company. I guess I'm the only one still rattled by yesterday's events.

My husband came back to bed late at night, but only to check on me. He hasn't slept at all and left pretty quickly. In fact, I haven't even seen him around at all today. I don't know where he disappeared, but I assume it has everything to do with the shooting.

Who was that? And were they trying to kill everyone on the property, or just me?

I poke around my Caesar salad with a fork, not having an appetite, then chew on a small piece of chicken, trying to stop myself from spiraling.

I haven't gone riding again. Not because I didn't want to, but because Alaska might not be ready yet. I don't want to push her unnecessarily, so for now, I choose to give her some space. Besides, I have no idea if the grounds are safe. When Wolf comes back, I'll ask him.

Gravel crunching under boots gets my attention.

“Is she okay?” Ekaterina asks, making her way to me.

I clear my throat, rotating my body to face her. “She seems okay. I just… don’t know.”

“If she wasn’t hurt, she’ll be fine. Horses are a lot tougher than we sometimes give them credit for.”

I sigh, forcing myself to smile. “Yeah.”

Her hand brushes my arm as she leans back against the wall, her lips pressing into a thin line as if to say she’s sorry. I let the corners of my mouth twitch upward, forming a genuine smile. We haven’t talked much, her and I, but every time we have, she’s been nothing but kind and supportive.

“I think I owe you an apology.”

Her brows rise. “Me? What for?”

“Misjudging you. When I came here, I thought I’d be surrounded by monsters. I thought everyone here was out to get me. I was wrong. You’ve been very kind to me, and I wanted to thank you.”

She waves a nonchalant hand in the air. “I don’t blame you one second for thinking we’re monsters. Because you might not be ready to accept it, but we’re not good people, Victoria. To be honest with you, I think we might be too far gone, and that’s why we’ve come to terms with it.”

“Bad people aren’t kind to strangers.”

She laughs, nodding. “I guess they’re not.”

We spend a few moments in silence, only the soft nickering of the horses stretching between us. I pick up another piece of chicken and put it in my mouth, my appetite returning a little.

“Can I ask you a question, Victoria?”

I swallow, looking back up at her. “Yeah. Of course.”

“How did you find it in yourself to forgive him?”

I place the fork in the salad bowl, thinking about the answer. Because honestly? I don’t know. I thought he ruined my life when he forced me to marry him, but the truth is… he made it better. Despite everything.

“He made it easy,” I tell her. “And I think… I might have fallen for him.”

She blinks. “You have? That’s… unexpected.”

“I know you have your differences, but he’s not a bad man, you know?”

“Isn’t he?”

I scowl, taken aback by her reaction.

“I mean… after what he did to your mother and sister…” She inhales. “I would’ve thought you hated his guts. But if you forgave him after that, I mean, you really are better than us, Victoria.”

“My mother and sister? What are you talking about?”

“You don’t know?”

My heartbeat picks up. Wolf said to trust him, and I did.

“I’m not sure what you mean.”

“Victoria,” she says, her lips tightening into that sympathizing smile again. Sympathizing or… pitiful. I can’t tell the difference right now. “They were sold to the highest bidder on the black market. They’re gone.”

A rush of nerves explodes in my stomach, making my breathing pattern a mess. I step back, dizziness clouding my thoughts.

“What?” I hush out, shaking my head. “No. That can’t be true. Wolf and I have been…”

“Oh, darling, please don’t tell me you fell for his antics. You must have known him marrying you wouldn’t be the end of his revenge plan, right? Oh, my God…” She frowns, concern emanating from her voice as something dawns on her. “Listen to me, Victoria. You did nothing wrong. This is what he does. You can’t blame yourself for this. Look at me.”

She tries to touch me, but I pull back.

Why should I believe her? She has to be wrong. Wolf and I haven’t just been fooling around. He saved me. Bought me Alaska. Brought Sasha to me.

He told me I was safe to trust him. Why would he lie?

Sure, he never gave me any details after that quick conversation we had, but…

My pulse hammers stronger.

What if… what if he only said that just so I didn’t ask questions down the line?

No. Ekaterina is wrong. She’s wrong, and I can’t let myself think otherwise.

“I know what this is. Wolf told me all about Mikhail and his ambitions.” I shake my head. “You’re just trying to help your son wear my husband’s

crown. And you may have been nice to me, but I won't let you ruin his life."

"How on earth would I be doing that by telling you the truth? If that were the case, I would be overjoyed with the thought of the two of you being in love. Because that would mean Wolfgang is…"

My mind conjures up the answer against my will. "Distracted. Off his game."

She nods. "You don't have to believe me. But if you simply go and ask him, he'll just deny it."

"And how exactly do you propose I cross-reference this bomb you just dropped on me?"

She takes out her phone, extending it toward me. "You know how."

I glance down at the object, knowing exactly who I need to call. It strikes me as odd that she knows I trust Sasha more than anyone else in this world. But even so, she's right. If anyone can confirm what she's telling me, it's him. I snatch the phone from her hand, moving to walk away.

But her next words stop me in my tracks.

"If you want to help your family, Victoria, understand that Wolfgang *cannot* be crowned. So find out what he's up to, and I'll see to it myself that your family is back—because your sister and mother are innocent in this man's world, just like you and I."

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WOLFGANG

I flick my wrist, sending the blade of my pocket knife swinging around its axis. Flip. Swing. Flip. Swing. I repeat the motion again and again as I sit in the car with Ivan and Kiril.

After yesterday's break-in, I tripled our forces around the estate. Only then did I feel good enough about leaving Victoria at home while I went out into the city to figure this shit out.

There's a body in the trunk wrapped nice and tight into multiple bags, which we're about to deliver to the Albanians.

Turns out the guy I killed yesterday was with them. Question is—why would they attempt something so fucking stupid in the first place? Not only are they outnumbered, but their resources are nowhere near as abundant as ours. Any war with us would be over before it even started.

"You think they went to the Italians after all?" Ivan asks steering through a curve.

"Unlikely. The don wouldn't give them the time of day without knowing they have a solid plan. They wouldn't risk that again after what happened

with the Romanovs.”

Kiril shuffles in the back seat. “Maybe the guy was working alone.”

Alone, no. But for someone just as insignificant—maybe.

My first thought is that maybe Victoria’s father fought back for once. I just took his entire family away from him, after all. And he’s a proud man—he wouldn’t go out without one last swing, even if it killed him.

“Here is good,” I tell Ivan.

He stops the car behind an old bar that belongs to Enver Morina, the Albanian head I met with a while ago, before we took over the Irish territory. We get out, and I open the trunk, the stench of death hitting me in the face. Just another fucking Tuesday.

Ivan and Kiril pull out some of the bags as I take the one with the head and walk right inside.

Scratchy radio tunes fill the alcohol-infused air. The bar is nearly empty at this hour, with just a single bartender. He’s wiping a beer pint with a cloth and halts when he sees me. His eyes lower to the object hanging from my hand, and when he glances back up, I’m already walking toward him.

“You came here to gloat?” he asks, now appearing disinterested.

I throw the bag on the counter with a thud. “I came here to warn you. Didn’t think I needed to.”

“You came for nothing. I don’t know anything about that. It has to be a mistake.”

I squint my eyes. Bartenders working for the Mafia know everything and everyone—it’s an unwritten part of their job. So what he’s saying makes no fucking sense, because the guy in the bag is definitely Albanian.

He jerks his head at the object. “Who was he?”

“Why don’t you have a look? I’m sure you’ll recognize him.”

The bartender stares me dead in the eye and prompts both hands on the counter as he leans in toward me.

“I’m not doing fucking anything. I told you, whatever you think happened, it wasn’t us.”

I mirror him, leaning in. “Then maybe you’re losing your flair, *Agron*. Maybe I’d be doing Enver a favor if I took you out right here, before the next shift starts and the bar gets crowded.”

His jaw clenches, muscles tense as he pushes off the counter and unties the goddamn bag. Almost immediately, a curse spills from his lips.

“This isn’t…” He pulls it under the counter before any curious eyes land on our interaction. “Zemer worked alone. Mr. Morina kicked him out ten months ago. You have my word—we’re not trying to poke the bear. It wasn’t us.”

“Alone,” I echo, musing. “And why exactly would he do something like that?”

“I told you, he was kicked out—lucky we didn’t kill him then. He was alone, needed money. If there was someone desperate enough to pay him to take you out, why not take the offer?”

“That better be true, Agron. Because if I find out you’re lying, I will hunt you down like a fucking cockroach, and you’ll end up in a bag of your own.” I turn around and start walking to the door, then halt. “And make no mistake—you fucking owe me one. So you make sure Enver Morina knows that when you show him the rest of this corpse waiting in your private booths downstairs.”

As if on cue, Ivan and Kiril appear at the top of the staircase, and we all walk out through the front door under the lingering gazes of the daytime drinkers.

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It's late, and I'm pretty fucking drained after close to 48 hours of being awake and looking for answers.

When Father asked about what happened yesterday, I told him it was handled, even though it's not fully true. The shooter is dead, yes, but I still need to find the other asshole he was working with. Tomorrow. Right now, all I feel is the need to lie down with my wife, sink into that pretty pussy of hers, and fall asleep with her in my arms.

Honestly, this whole thing couldn't have come at a worse time.

Victoria was finally finding her peace here, in our home. And the throne was almost secured without impediments. Now, if word goes out about the attack—and I expect it already has—the Irish might retaliate. I, too, would take an opportunity like this if I needed to. What better time to attack your enemy than when they're already being attacked?

There goes my fucking chance of taking my throne easily so I could finally relax.

But I will get this shit done, regardless. And when I do, I'm taking Victoria away for our honeymoon, which we never got. We didn't need to, given the circumstances of our wedding. Now… things have changed.

I want her so fucking much I know I need to lock us both in a room together until I have enough. I smile at the thought on the way to our bedroom, knowing I'll never get enough. At this point, I crave her all the time—I'm insatiable.

I crack the door open, and it’s dark inside.

The windows are open, the curtains flapping against the gentle wind in the night. My wife is in our bed, tucked under the covers, sleeping on her side.

My chest tightens at seeing her safe and sound. I want to pry her legs open and lick her out, but I step into the bathroom instead. I need a shower before I touch her delicate skin. Mine is still smeared with traces of death.

When I’m done, I walk back into the bedroom and put on a pair of boxer briefs. She’s in the same position, a sign that I haven’t woken her up.

I lie down next to her, pulling her to my chest. Her hair smells like lilies, and I groan, my face stuffed in it. She’s so warm, so soft. So mine.

My shoulders finally relax, and my mind goes empty as I’m dragged under her spell again. And it dawns on me that I haven’t felt so at peace in this house since my mother passed.

“She would’ve loved you,” I murmur, cupping Victoria's breast from behind.

I brush my thumb over her pointy nipple, feeling it harden up. God, I want to flip her over and pull it into my mouth. Bite her. Lick her. Claim her for the thousandth time. I press my hard cock into her ass, groaning as the need overpowers me.

She stirs, and I stop in my tracks when she speaks.

“I’m not in the mood, Wolfgang.”

Her voice is low, but steady, and unlike someone who just woke up from sleep. She was awake the entire time.

“Anything happen while I was gone?”

It hasn't—my men would've told me—but maybe someone talked to her and made her upset. I fucking hate it when I have to leave her here by herself, but it's safer for her this way.

"No. I just want to sleep."

"Why weren't you sleeping, then?"

"I was. You woke me up."

"No, you weren't. Look at me," I say, flipping her over so I can see her face.

She's been crying. And she looks angry more than she looks sad. I pinch her chin with my fingers and force her face up. "You tell me who got you so upset, love, and I'm going back to kill them right now."

She blinks, a fresh tear smearing her cheek before her eyes finally meet mine.

VICTORIA

My body trembles with indescribable rage.

He holds me, but it does nothing to quiet the storm that's been brewing inside me. It entices it. Brings it up to the surface, threatening to drown us both.

Sasha told me the truth—I called him this morning, using Ekaterina's phone. And he confirmed my worst fear—my mother… my sister… they're gone… sold into slavery like objects… to be used and disposed of when they break.

He even sent a video from the security cameras of my father's house. I saw them struggling, saw them beg for mercy that never came. Saw the tears on Anya's cheeks and the screams erupting from Mom's mouth.

The thought of Wolfgang and his men shoving them into cars rips through my heart, causing havoc as my stomach churns. It's bringing me to the edge of my sanity.

How could he do something so vile?

Everyone in Alemont City knew what happened to them. I was the only one who didn't while I stupidly convinced myself Wolfgang Rykov was a man worthy of my heart. He isn't. Never was, not even for a goddamn second. He's a monster.

I'm such a goddamn fool.

My throat throbs with the pain of unspoken words. Of all the things I want to shout in his face but don't. Not yet.

This last bit of sanity I have left is going to have to keep me going, so I can brave this storm tactfully. Get my mother and my sister out of the country. And run away from this evil family once and for all. From this monster looking at me with his cold, calculated eyes. The eyes I fell for like an idiot.

"Victoria," he says, and the way my name rolls off his tongue breaks another piece of my heart. It's tender, caring, almost sounds genuine. If I didn't already know the truth, I would believe him again. And again. And again. I would give myself over to him for the thousandth time.

More tears spill on my cheeks, wetting the pillow and the hand he has on my chin.

The words shake on my lips as I lie to him, hoping he won't see right through me.

“You fucking left me alone in here. You knew how rattled I was by the attack, and you still left. Now you come in here as if nothing happened, wanting to fuck me. To chase your own high.”

He blinks, taken aback. He looks exhausted, and on a night like this, I’d give him anything he needs… because I love him. I love him, and this couldn’t be any fucking harder. He might have been the man who put me back together, but now he’s breaking me harder than anyone ever has.

I expect him to turn cold, tell me he was busy, but his eyes warm up when a smile stretches across his lips. My heart skips a beat. But I know better than to believe his lies now.

“I hate every goddamn second I’m away from you,” he whispers, pressing a kiss to my trembling lips.

It’s soft, tender, and I mewl as my mind resists the urge to lean back for more.

“But I had to leave you here today, so you were safe, love, while I chopped up the body of the fucker who shot at us yesterday. Yes,” he says when he sees me frown, “This is why I couldn’t take you with me. I might have dragged you into my world, but that doesn’t mean I won’t protect you from seeing its horrors. Your job is to be happy and loved.” He tucks a strand of hair behind my ear, his warm skin touching mine, a sizzle of electricity coursing through me. “Mine is to make sure I create a safe space for you, so you can do just that.”

His eyelids grow heavy as he says it, and a long, deep sigh leaves his chest. It pains me to do it, but I jerk my chin away from his touch. Retreating to the edge of my pillow, I look up at the ceiling, at the shadows swaying in the dark.

“It’s alright, love,” he murmurs, his voice softer than a whisper. “You’re my good girl. I’ll take care of you…”

Sorrow slides in and out of my body with every breath. I squeeze my eyelids shut, trying my hardest to keep it together. I should ask him about what happened to Anya and my mom. But didn't Sasha already confirm it? What other confirmation am I looking for? Why can't I just do what needs to be done?

Because you love him. Because you're still clinging to the hope that he's not the monster you thought he was.

I think about all of that, reeling with my indecision.

"Will you even be here tomorrow?" I ask, a shred of guilt seeping between the cracks of my heart because I know damn well what I'm doing right now. I'm prying. Getting anything from him that I can use if I decide to go to Ekaterina for help.

This is all *his* fault.

"I had to lie to my father today. I told him I took care of the problem, but I only did that partially. I just wanted to come home—to you. I'm tired, love, and you're the only one who can put me to sleep right now."

He looks away, then back at me, appearing vulnerable for the first time since meeting him. Like he's giving himself over to me with what he's telling me.

"You have to understand. One wrong move, and I lose everything I've worked for. They're all waiting for me to slip up once." He sighs, his shoulders slouching under the weight of all the stress and responsibility he carries around. My eyes soften, but I keep my heart locked. "I know it means nothing to you, and I don't blame you after everything I did to you, but if I do this… maybe my family will finally accept me."

And there it is. That shred of guilt again.

It grows, and grows, twisting around me like a serpent until my lungs beg for air.

If he truly is lying to me about my family—and he *is*—how can he be so sincere now?

We lay in silence for the next few minutes. I don't know what to do. I don't want to blow my only chance at getting my family out of this mess by letting him know I know the truth. But at the same time, he's… Wolf. He's my husband.

Maybe I really am an idiot for giving him this one last chance, but my heart begs me to. I don't feel like I have another choice.

"I need you to tell me the truth," I whisper, still looking at the ceiling. I take in a deep breath before I exhale it slowly. "Did you do what they say you did…? Did you sell my sister and my mother to whoever wanted them?"

I wait for the answer in horror, my body locked in place, waiting for the truth to drop. I want him to laugh at the absurdity I'm implying. Anything would be better than it actually being true.

"What?" he asks. When I turn to him, his eyes are squinted. As if he's taken aback.

"You heard me."

"Victoria…" He sighs. "What did I tell you back at the restaurant?"

My heart hammers in my chest. "To trust you."

"And up until tonight, you didn't seem to have a problem with that." He gets up, sitting on the bed with his back to me.

"I saw you." I swallow. "Videos were sent to me. People told me what you did to Anya and my mom. I saw everything, so forgive me for not feeling

like I can trust you too much right now.”

“You saw me…” he echoes. “And what exactly was I doing in those videos?”

I don’t hesitate. “Your men were shoving them in cars forcefully. Took them out of their beds in nothing but nightgowns. And you were there, walking alongside them, giving out orders. Like I said, I saw everything.”

“Of course you did.” He scoffs. “Who the fuck showed you? Who *told* you to watch them? No, actually, don’t tell me. It doesn’t even matter.”

“You’re right, it doesn’t. But is that all you’re going to say about it?” I shake my head. He did it. And he’s not even trying to defend himself. Why else would he be deflecting?

“I come home after doing everything in my fucking power to find the man wanting us dead, and you pretend to be upset about that, when in reality, you’d already made up your mind about whom to trust. And it wasn’t me. Not one bit.”

I sit up. “No, it wasn’t, because like I said, I have proof. And you don’t! So what am I supposed to believe, Wolfgang? Are you asking me not to believe my own eyes?”

“How can you…” He laughs, and it’s chilling. There’s nothing amusing about this laugh. “How can you even ask me that? Fuck. You know, Victoria, maybe the reason nobody back home wanted you around is because you’re incapable of understanding who’s actually on your side.”

My breath leaves my lungs all at once.

“W-What? How can you say that to me…?” A wave of sadness flows through me, bringing my shoulders down. If anyone understands how it feels to be unwanted, it’s him. So for him to use that against me…

Wolfgang gets up, and it’s clear he doesn’t want to be around me anymore. He’s leaving. And I’m losing parts of myself right now, before his eyes.

“Sure. Leave. Run away,” I say, tears lodged in my throat. “Once again, you’re showing me I was right not to fall for your lies.”

His head turns to me, eyes thunderous. I hold my breath, unable to look anywhere else.

“You’ll believe whatever you want to believe, love. And you’ll do whatever you want. Maybe all of you Romanovs are the same, after all.”

“*Maybe*,” I seethe, crawling on the bed until I’m closer to his side. “I wouldn’t have to believe what others tell me if you were straight with me for once!”

He turns fully, but halts. As if he’s reeling with himself on how to handle the situation.

“Are you seriously saying that if I told you none of what you saw happened, you’d believe me?”

I open my mouth to answer, but no words come out. Sasha always taught me to believe my own eyes. Especially in a brutal world like ours where things are very matter-of-fact. And the truth is… the proof is indisputable. Unless Wolfgang specifically shows me otherwise. But he doesn’t seem like he’s defending himself at all right now.

By the time I think of something to say, he's out the door.

Pain like I’ve never known seizes my chest and my throat. My shoulders shake with sobs, and for the first time in months, I feel alone again. As if we’re right back where we started.

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VICTORIA

At the crack of dawn, I trudge to the stables, hoping Alaska can calm me down. I haven't slept all night, and I don't know what else to do or where else to go.

I still haven't decided what I'm going to do about Anya and my mom.

My anxiety comes back in waves. I can't just sit here and do nothing. Every moment I'm not trying to bring them back is a moment they spend in pain. And while they didn't lift a finger to get to me, it doesn't matter. They're still my family, the people who raised me for better or for worse, and as it turns out, I don't have another one, anyway.

I'm restless the entire time I'm in the stables. It doesn't take long before I say goodbye to Alaska and go back inside, the smell of iced tea hitting my nostrils.

A loud, chirping laugh pierces the air, followed by more just like it. When I enter the dining room, Ekaterina is sitting at the table with two other women.

“Mmm,” she says, swallowing a sip of tea. “Victoria. There you are, darling.”

I approach the table, feeling the lingering gazes of the other women on me.

“I need to talk to you.”

To my surprise, she puts down her cup of tea and nods, her jolly expression fading.

“You’ll have to excuse me, ladies. I have something to take care of. Same time next week?”

She doesn’t wait for the others to confirm it. Just gets up and wraps her arm around my shoulders, inviting me to walk forward, away from them.

“Let’s go into my husband’s office. We can talk there while he’s gone.”

My anxiety picks up again as she drags me with her into Yuri Rykov’s office. It’s bad enough I have to be in his house. But in his personal space? A shiver runs through me at seeing all his belongings plastered all over the room—books, and glasses. Images of him and his sons. Of Wolfgang.

Guilt wraps around me like a tight shroud. I probably shouldn’t be here with his step-mom. If he cared about me at all, knowing I’m confiding in her would hurt him. Though I’m pretty sure he doesn’t give a fuck. Not after what he said to me last night. Besides, what else can I do? He’ll get his throne eventually. But Anya and my mom… they might not live to see another day if I don’t act now.

“Here we are,” Ekaterina says, closing the door behind me. “Don’t tell me. You told Wolfgang what you know, and he flipped out?” She walks to the desk and leans her hips against the edge, watching me from under her sculpted eyebrow.

I close my eyes for a second, inhaling sharply. “We had a fight. He said some things…”

“Of course he did. Look. I know he hasn’t been entirely horrible to you, but you have to admit, the way he handled this situation wasn’t exactly right.”

No, it wasn’t.

“My guess is he took your mother and your sister before he developed any feelings for you. And now he’s upset that you know the truth, because he knows he can’t bring them back. So…” She shrugs. “He flipped out. Made it seem like it was all your fault. Tell me I’m wrong.”

It’s almost as if she was right there in the room with us. Maybe she knows him better than I thought.

Which would mean she’s probably right… about everything.

“It doesn’t make sense.” I sigh, my breath trembling out in front of me. “He did so much to protect me…”

“You’re important to him. It’s obvious. But you have to understand, it’s only so that he can secure his throne. So he can show the world Nikolai Romanov’s daughter is his whore.”

I flinch at the last word. He's never called me that. Never made me feel that way. There must be something deeply wrong with me because I enjoyed every second of being his, regardless of what he was trying to show the world.

Still, as much as I hate to admit it, Ekaterina’s words resonate.

“Did you ask him for the truth?”

I nod. “Yes. And he was… angry. He never…”

He never specifically told me what I saw wasn't real. He never even defended himself. Then he took my pain and twisted it, making me bleed in front of him. Said I was no different than my Father. That I deserved being unwanted by the family I was trying to protect.

I don't realize I'm crying until I hear Ekaterina say, "It's alright, darling. It's alright."

But it isn't. Nothing is alright anymore. The man I love doesn't love me back, and my family is gone.

A decision settles in me, and suddenly, I'm no longer on the fence about what to do. I take one last deep breath before I fold my arms and tell Ekaterina everything. How Wolfgang lied to the *Pakhan* so he could spend the night with me. How the shooting hasn't been fully debunked. How he'll be gone tomorrow to keep searching. She nods through it, saying just enough to make me believe she'll keep her word. I don't feel relief yet—not until she comes back to tell me Anya and my mother are saved.

Then she leaves, and I'm empty, and I wish the ground would just swallow me.

I betrayed the man I love… And I hope he never knows it was me. Because if he does, he won't even have to kill me. I'll wither away on my own anyway.

For now, I keep telling myself I did the right thing, even if something inside me already knows I just burned the only bridge I've ever wanted to keep.

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WOLFGANG

"The Italians keep undercutting our costs in Boston," I say, drumming my fingers on the table in front of me. "They want to win on price, so… let them count their pennies while we take their whale clients."

I lift my gaze, taking in the men filling the rest of the seats. Everyone is here, all our money launderers—except Victoria's father—and other allies, like the Romanian, Polish, and Bulgarian heads. It's our quarterly meeting where we evaluate finances, cut down expenses, and look for ways to increase profit.

Almost every single time someone suggests we go into the skin business, but I don't fuck with that. Not only is it not as profitable as everyone likes to think, but it also gives me the fucking ick. I can tell some are itching to propose it as a solution to what I just said.

But I already know what we need to do. I'm simply here to let them know out of courtesy.

Enver Morina studies me. He must have been surprised I called him in after I left the corpse at his bar. Still, he came, which tells me he understands where he stands. Maybe the bartender was being honest, after all.

“And how exactly do you propose we do that?” Enver asks. “We can’t just bang on their doors and force them to buy from us.”

“No, we can’t. Which is why we’re going to make them *want* to shop with us.”

The Bulgarian senses where I’m getting at and nods. “Won’t the Italians figure out it was us who messed with their shipments? We’d be starting a war, Wolfgang.”

“The war started when they colluded with the Romanovs to steal our profits–the big, fat paychecks you’re getting at the end of every month. In fact, how’s your daughter, Viktor? Got her that Ferrari for her birthday yet?”

His jaw clenches, but he doesn’t look away. He knows I’m right.

Besides, the Italians need to know we haven’t forgotten their stupid fucking stunt.

“A fire at the docks would delay their shipment. So would an explosive mounted on the ship,” the Romanian chimes in.

The others join the conversation, and I take the opportunity to look at my phone, expecting a message from Ivan. He’s out, still trying to figure out who the Albanian rogue was working with.

Still no answer, and it’s been hours. What’s taking him so fucking long?

My mind then goes to my wife. I hate the way I left things with her. I’ve been trying not to think about it, but who am I kidding? She’s all I ever want at the front-end of my mind, regardless of our fight.

I was so fucking angry last night.

First, that she lied to me about what really bothered her. Second, that she dismissed me so easily, like I could never be more than a monster to her. Like there’s no world in which she could trust me, believe in me for all that I am.

It was so gutting that I ended up throwing ugly lies in her face. I don't think I'll ever forget the disappointment and shock plastered all over her pretty face.

I exhale slowly, hating myself for it. She didn't deserve being treated that way. No matter how angry or exhausted I am, I can't fucking let my darkness seep out of me like that. Not when I risk laying it out on her.

As I listen to whatever the Romanian is saying to the others, I'm growing impatient to return home. To make things right with her.

This whole situation with the Irish, the Italians, and the shooter is starting to piss me the fuck off. It always feels like I'm close to wrapping things up, then something new pops up. There's always a new fire to put out before I can finally take what I've earned. And I'm getting sick of waiting.

Maybe I don't care about becoming *Pakhan* anymore. Not if it means crawling for scraps of respect from a father who's never wanted me to win. Or lying to the world about hating the woman I love.

But I'm not walking away. *I* built this fucking empire. And if I burn for it, it won't be for him… or for Mikhail… or for the woman who raised me like she wanted me dead the moment she stepped into our home.

It'll be for me. For Victoria.

For the future we can have together if I stop pretending, and just take what's already mine.

I look up from my phone, the decision nailing itself into my flesh and bones.

I tell the others, "Set it up. Tonight. I'll pay whoever does it one percent more."

Just then, the door opens to my left, and my father comes in, drawing all the attention to him.

What the fuck is he doing here?

“We won’t be doing anything like that,” he announces. “You must excuse my son, gentlemen. He’s been rather… distracted lately.”

I follow him with my gaze as he walks deeper into the room. Mikhail is right on his trail—a rare fucking sight—strolling in with a smirk on his face. Annoyance surges in me, and I’m this close to telling them both to fuck off.

Even though I’ve been the one running the business for the past couple of years, Father made sure to preserve his power through things like this. Blindsiding me is his specialty. And he can be very unpredictable because most of the time, he has no real strategy at all.

But this… *this*. To bring Mikhail with him is new to me. And it pisses me off.

“As you all know,” he says, “I’ve been thinking about retirement for a while now. I deliberately left Wolfgang in charge because I needed to know if he was the right person for the job. But as it turns out… he’s not.”

My jaw clenches on its own accord. Everyone listens, but no one dares look me in the eye. Yet, my father does. I hold his stare unflinching, and he holds mine.

“I won’t go into detail. We don’t need to bring personal matters into this. But I came here to make an announcement. To tell you all that from now on… Mikhail Rykov will be your *Pakhan*.”

Every atom in my fucking body comes to a halt. I stop breathing, and it takes every bit of sanity I have left to keep my calm. I imagine flipping over the tables. Smashing the chairs into the windows, into his head.

How. Could. He?

After everything I’ve done for this family, after everything I’ve endured for him. For us.

I watch as every man in the room gets up to shake hands with my brother. Everyone but me. I pay close attention to him as he goes through the motions, surprised to see his smirk gone. His brows are furrowed, and for a moment, his eyes slide over to mine. If I didn't know him better, I'd say he was blindsided too, but I'm not buying his sheepish act.

No fucking way he didn't have a role in all this. It's what he always wanted, isn't it?

I didn't see this coming—and I've got no one but myself to blame for that. Not because I let Victoria in… but because I didn't end this charade with my father sooner. Because I didn't put my foot down when I had the chance.

As if on cue, my phone vibrates and I peer down, a text splayed out on the screen from an unknown number. And with every word I read, my shields—the ones I put down for the first fucking time in my life last night—go up again.

One. By. One.

> **Unknown:** I told Ekaterina about the shooter. I think she told your father… He knows you lied to him. I'm so sorry, Wolf. Please… just be ready.

VICTORIA

I walk through the dark, empty halls of the house, aimless and on edge.

He's not home yet, and I don't even know if he got my message. I keep the new phone in my hand, constantly checking for a sign of any kind. But there's only silence. And it's pressing down on me like a mountain I can't take off my chest.

I stop by the open door of the library, but I don't go in. My hand stretches out, touching the nearest wall for support. I haven't eaten anything today. Barely had a sip of water.

My heart aches for Wolfgang, for acting behind his back, even if he did the same to me. You don't hurt someone you love. Not like that. Not by going to the one person that terrorized them their entire life. I close my eyes, reeling in the guilt as best I can, except it won't stop. There's no getting out of what I've done.

I've seen this house silent before, but now it's too much. Too still. As if something irreversible happened between these walls, and it's here permanently. To haunt me. Taunt me. Bury me in pain.

I wish he'd come back sooner, so I can explain… Explain what exactly? How I betrayed him? How I took away the only thing he's ever needed to find peace in his life?

Some goon appears at the end of an empty corridor, blocking my way. He sees me and squints his eyes, as if he knows. As if he's no longer supposed to refrain himself from causing me harm. Good. He should do it—kill me right here, splay my blood all over these walls. But he walks by, as if he only saw the ghost of Wolfgang Rykov's wife.

Eyes closed, I shiver with regret, guilt clawing at my throat.

I urge my useless legs to take me outside—I need to breathe. And I can't fucking breathe in this house.

But the moment I go down one floor… I feel it. The scent that carries me to sleep every night. My heart cries out, banging against my ribs, begging me to find solace in the same place I lost it—in my husband's arms. I walk toward the big, empty living room, the click of glass and the pouring of liquid luring me in like a death knell.

He's here.

Somehow, he came back, and I didn't see him through the window because I was too afraid to look at times. The silence is unbearable, and I break a little more each time it settles deeper between us. Why isn't he yelling at me? Why won't he say he hates me, that I ruined his life?

Turning away from the decanter with the scotch, he brings the glass to his lips and stops. Just for a moment, our eyes meet, telling me more than his words ever could.

"W-Wolf…" The name trembles on my wet lips, breaking in half.

He takes back his seat near the fireplace—cold and void of fire, as if he didn't care for anything but the strong drink in his hand. His jaw tightens. He doesn't speak. And that silence is worse than any word he could scream at me.

"Please…" I gather my hands in front of me, pulling at the edges of my blouse as I approach him with small, quiet steps. I don't have words to tell him how sorry I am…

He murmurs, his tone low and indifferent. "Did you enjoy it? Gutting me in front of the world like that?"

I shake my head, approaching him more. He looks at me as if he wants me to stop. And I do, because I've never seen him look at me like that.

"I never meant to hurt you," I say, my voice the only stronghold keeping tears at bay. "I never wanted to go to her. But I had no other choice…"

He chuckles, and it scares me a little. Because it's filled with pain.

"I let you in, Victoria. Gave you a piece of myself so that you *always* had a choice. You must have known that. You must have seen what I was willing to do for you."

"Yes," I hush out. "Everything… everything except keeping the only people I care about safe."

“I asked if you’d believe me over the others, and you didn’t respond.” He drains the rest of his drink, ice clinking against the glass. “You believed Ekaterina. Ran to her instead. Tore out my fucking heart.” He exhales. “The problem with that, love, is that everything she told you is a huge pile of crap.”

I listen, and not a single muscle in my body moves as I cling to his words.

“They’re safe. Your sister, your mother, they have been safe. I sent them off to Russia, set them up with a home. With money. Everything they might ever need to make a life for themselves. I did what you asked before you ever asked it. But I guess I’ll always be a monster to you, won’t I?”

“Wolf… I… I didn’t know. I…”

“Nah. Save those pretty little tears for someone who cares.” The words hit me right in the heart. They’re cold, so cold and hateful. There’s nothing left of his mocking, flirty demeanor.

I swallow hard as he gets up, downing his drink. “Because you might remain my wife on paper. But you and I? We’re done. Take your stuff out of my bedroom. And enjoy your fucking life.”

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VICTORIA

Love is patience. Love is denial. Love is suffering. Love is staying when you're not wanted. It's plucking out your heart and leaving it out on a tray for the one who owns it. It's knowing you might never get it back, or worse, that he'll never even want to touch it. Never smear his hands with your pain again.

Love… is giving everything you are and not expecting anything in return.

If you're lucky, it's reciprocated. If you're not, you die.

It's where I am now. Living through a slow, painful death.

It's three in the morning, and I'm in front of Wolf's bedroom door, waiting on the hard floor.

I lean my head against the wood behind me, hearing nothing from the other side. Either he's in there and he's ignoring me… or he hasn't come home at all. Regardless, I'll be here when he shows up. I need to talk to him. Even if he has completely shut me off.

The letter is clutched in my hand. Two pages–not enough to say everything I need to, but long enough to get my foot in the door. If only I can get him to listen… to let me tell him how sorry I am…

I don't deserve his attention, I know that. I took away the most important thing in the world for him, and all he did was love me, protect me—even when I didn't even know he was. It's selfish, perhaps, my persistence. But I can't just… go on with my life. There *is* no life after Wolfgang. I don't want it. Never again.

The sound of steps makes my pulse quicken. It's quiet, muffled, and I would've missed it had I not been prickling my ears for a sign of any kind.

"Wolf?" I say, my voice breaking through the silence of the night. "I know you're in there. I know you locked your door to keep me out."

I get to my knees, sniffing as I stretch out the folded paper. It makes a shuffling noise in my trembling hands. "And I know you don't want to see me right now… I—I understand. So I wrote you this," I say, sliding the letter under the door and pushing it inside.

I put my palm against the door. "You don't have to talk to me at all. Just please… read it? Please. I'm begging you."

I wait in silence for his response, so fucking sick of only hearing my own voice. I need him to say something, even if it's just telling me to leave him alone. I just…

Minutes pass, and eventually, I rest my head back against the door, curling up with my knees at my chest. My head dips every now and then, exhaustion gnawing at me. But I force myself to stay awake. What if he changes his mind? What if he chooses to come out and talk to me? I can't miss that.

But my traitorous fucking body does it anyway. Because the moment I open my eyes again, I'm not seeing the hallway. I'm seeing my window, the

curtains drawn back the same way as I left them yesterday, the sun shining into my eyes.

A long, pained sigh leaves my chest.

How did I even end up back in my room?

As I get up on my elbows, the answer rings in my head, breaking my heart into even smaller pieces. Just like the pieces of the letter I wrote last night. They're scattered everywhere. On my body, on the bed, on the floor… my words now float into a space where no one's ever going to hear them.

He got my message. Carried me to my bed, tore up the letter, and left.

"Because you might remain my wife on paper. But you and I? We're done."

He took care of me, but only because he takes care of things that belong to him. He told me this over and over. My heart yearns to read more into this gesture than what it really is–an obligation. Something he forced himself to do because the law binds us. Because we share a last name.

I hate it.

And yet… he touched me, carried me. I wish I'd been awake to feel him on my skin.

Getting up, I push the remains of my letter off my chest. Sadness washes over me, and I reach for my new phone on the nightstand.

I dial Sasha's number and wait… And wait.

Pick up. Please, pick up.

"Hello?" he says, his voice bringing tears to my eyes instead of making me feel better. Now… I'll have to confess to my mentor as well.

“Hi, Sasha.”

“Victoria… ? Where are you? Are you hurt?”

I nod, even if he can’t see it. I’m hurt. Just not in the way he’s asking me.

Letting out a shaky breath, I say, “I messed up, Sasha. I ruined everything.” I bring my hand to my mouth, sobbing into it.

“Hey, hey,” he coos. “It’s alright. It’s okay. Tell me what hurts.”

“Everything. I… I… We got it wrong. Wolfgang never harmed Anya and my mom. He lied to everybody.”

Silence hangs between us.

My chest heaves, and I curl into myself with the phone at my ear, trying to calm down.

“Whatever you did, you couldn’t have known…”

“Do *not* pamper me! You’ve never lied to me, so don’t you dare start now.” I grip my phone tighter. “I ruined him. And he won’t talk to me, won’t even look at me. Sasha… I need you to tell me what to do. I need…”

“Where are they, then? If he didn’t sell them, where did he take them? Are you absolutely sure this is true?”

“Yes. Yes, I’m sure. I believe him. He sent them off to Russia.”

Sasha lets out a sigh. “After he called me to get you that horse, I should’ve known…”

“Know what?”

“That he loves you. Of course he came up with some sort of plan, even if he never told you about it. We didn’t see it coming because… well, his reputation precedes him. He’s not exactly known for being a good man.”

I turn on my back, wiping the trails of my tears with the palm of my other hand.

“Maybe he did love me then. But now… trust me, it’s all gone. He wants nothing to do with me.”

“Come on, sweet girl. Surely, I taught you better than this. Didn’t I?”

I sniff, my body slowly coming down from the height of my emotions.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean… if a door closes, you kick down the next. And if you can’t do it, then you bring out an axe. And if you don’t have an axe…”

“…then you find stone and wood. And if you can’t find that, then you give up the axe. And bring a machine gun.”

“There you are.”

“I know, Sasha. I know all of this. But there really doesn’t seem to be anything I can do to get him to listen to what I have to say…”

“Yes, there is,” he says patiently. “Find your machine gun, Victoria. Find the one thing he cares about and give that to him. He still loves you. Love doesn’t go away in the blink of an eye. All you need to do is make him remember.”

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Wolf doesn’t come home the next two nights. I kept waiting in the hallway and he never showed up. And when I asked Corinne, she told me he was, indeed, gone—to New York.

Now, he’s back, right here behind his office door. He’s not alone. I saw him come in with people—men I’ve never seen around the house. I have no idea what their meeting is about, nor do I need to know.

I thought about Sasha’s words a lot since we talked, and I might be wrong, but I figured the best way to show Wolf how sorry I am would be to put myself in the same situation I put him. He was blindsided that day. Humiliated, and at the mercy of the family who never gave him love.

This is me now, doing the same thing to myself. He might still not want to talk to me, but at least he’ll see me, and he’ll know I’m not giving up on us. No matter what it takes.

Heart pounding in my chest, I wrap my hand around the handle and push the door open. Four big, muscular silhouettes come into view through the small crack it makes. And in between their heads, my husband appears sitting at his desk, talking to them. His eyes slide over to me, squinting before resuming his conversation as if I’m no one. Hurt flashes through me, and I swallow it down, advancing into the room.

“What can I do for you, Victoria?”

My heart pulses faster. He can’t ignore me now.

The other men turn their heads slightly, taking me in, then turning back to Wolf. I hold my husband’s stare, getting closer, closer, closer, until I’m by the desk, and I can feel his energy rolling off him in waves. He’s so imposing, so big. So hurt.

I lower myself to my knees. His jaw clenches, nostrils flaring as he follows my movements. The way I fold my hands in my lap. The way I continue to

look at him. The way I sit down on my heels in a room full of men, submitting to him.

“I’m sorry,” I say, hyper aware of everyone watching me. But I don’t care. I don’t care what they think, what they’ll think after they leave. All I care about is that my husband forgives me. “I’m sorry, Wolfgang. Please…” I swallow. “I’m begging you to forgive me.”

“Get up.”

I shake my head.

“Victoria… love of my life…” he mocks. “Get up and leave the room before I do something we’ll both regret.”

“Do it, then! Do whatever you have to do. I need you to—”

“I’m afraid we’ll have to reconvene at a different time, gentlemen. Seems my wife woke up in some kind of mood.”

Some kind of mood… as if we’re not going through something. As if I’m not literally at his feet, begging for forgiveness. We’re back to where it all started—to the part where he doesn’t care about me. Only this time is worse, because all the fascination he may have had about me before is gone. Spent.

When the other men are out of the room, he turns to me. “I thought I made myself clear. We’re done. Why are you still here?”

“Because we’re *not* done!” I shout, still kneeling as I look up at him. “We’ll never be. And I’ll spend the rest of my life making it up to you if I have to. In the end, Wolf, you’ll have no choice but to forgive me. Because I love you, and you know it, and I made a mistake—a terrible, terrible mistake that I’ll regret forever…”

“You’re not going to give up?” he asks.

“No. Never.”

He smiles—that cold, empty smile of his that reminds me of our first encounters—and gets up, shoving his hands in his pockets as he towers above me. I hold my breath, waiting for something—anything. Praying he’ll give me something to hold on to—hope.

“Then I wish you luck, Victoria. Because one thing you should know about me is… once I’ve moved on from something, there’s no turning back.”

And then he leaves me there, breathless, aching, and alone.

I blink, and he’s gone.

I don’t cry, and my shoulders don’t shake this time. I’ve done that enough. Instead, I sit here, on his office floor, feeling empty, numb.

I don’t want to get up. I don’t want to be here, nor there. I feel like a ghost. Like a shell with no life in it. I’ve never experienced this feeling before.

Minutes— maybe hours—pass. My knees hurt, and my stomach growls. And suddenly, out of nowhere, hands wrap around my shoulders. Someone’s kneeling with me. Calling my name.

“What?” I ask, shifting my attention back to the present, to the man in front of me.

“I asked if you were okay,” Mikhail says.

“I don’t… I don’t know.”

“He can be such an asshole. Come on, let’s get you up.” I let him pull me up, holding on to his forearms. When I’m back standing, I come back to my senses. And I step back, away from him.

“What are you doing? Why are you here, cornering me?”

“Is that what you think I’m doing? Cornering you?” I don’t reply. And he sighs. “Look. He’ll come around. You just need to give him some time.”

“Why the hell do you even care? You got what you wanted. I don’t need your pity or your advice. Just… go. Leave me alone.”

I look to the side, but not before I notice a flicker of something traverse his face. Hurt, maybe? No. Why would my words have any effect on him?

“Did I get what I wanted? Or did my mother get what *she* wanted?”

What’s that supposed to mean?

“Wolf told me all about you two trying to steal his position,” I say.

“My brother may be smart, but he’s not omniscient. He can’t know what he never asks about.”

“Meaning?”

He shrugs. “I don’t want this. Never did.”

“Yeah, right.” I snort a laugh. “And you expect me to believe that?”

“You can believe whatever you want. I’m telling you the truth. My mother dumped her life goals on me the moment I was born. And for the longest time, I followed her lead, because I didn’t know who I was, or who I wanted to be. It drove a wedge between me and Wolf, and now it’s probably too late to take it out, but… yeah. I don’t want to steer this ship. And even if I did, I wouldn’t be as good as him. We are what we are.” He smiles bitterly.

I don’t know what to say to that. It feels like a confession of sorts, like he needed to hear himself say that for some reason. Maybe to give him peace.

“And to answer your question,” he continues. “I care because I know my mother set you up. And I hate to be the one to say it, but…”

I nod, my shoulders slackening. “I know. You warned me about her…”

He walks to the window, looking out into the distance.

“Do you really think he’ll come around?” I ask.

“I think that when he’s ready to forgive you, he’ll hate himself for all the time you two have lost.”

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VICTORIA

Six days have passed. Maybe—I don't even know. Each day merges into a vacuum of futility, and I'm just a soul being dragged along aimlessly. If I were dead, I wouldn't know the difference.

I wake up, I look for him, he doesn't come. He never comes back for me.

The hardest part is leaving this room—the one he locked me in when I first arrived. Because I know what's out there, beyond these walls. A house void of him, of his presence, of everything I loved. A house that breathes with malice, in which I can't trust a single soul. He was right when he told me he was my only ally. I didn't listen.

The rubies he gifted me on my birthday stare back at me from the vanity.

Sunrays swim in the red of them, luring me in like sirens. I get out of bed, approach them, and stretch out my fingers until they're in my hand. I bring them to my face, inhaling what's left of his perfume from when he held them. They used to smell like him, and I used to hate it because it reminded me I belonged to a monster. Now I crave him on me—on my skin, on my lips, everywhere…

I stretch out the necklace, bringing it to my neck, watching myself in the mirror. Seeing what I used to look like when I was his. But when tears blur my vision, I put it back on the desk, my head lowered under the weight of the hollow space in my heart.

The only thing keeping me going is finding out whether or not he fixed my mess and got himself the throne he earned. I haven't heard anything of such, but then again, no one talks to me anymore. Either they know what I've done and they're avoiding me… or he told them they're supposed to just tolerate me.

I'm hoping for the latter, because that would mean he did it out of hate. Not indifference. And I'd rather burn under his rage than wither away slowly knowing he no longer cares.

I pull a hoodie over my body, feeling the chill of what's looking to be a cloudy day. My stomach grumbles, begging for food, but I ignore it. I don't know why I'm doing it—maybe it's easier to feel any kind of physical pain than the loss I carry with me.

Outside the room, my eyes land on the door in front of me—of the bedroom we used to share. He's probably not in there, but I still can't muster the courage to walk back in time and see it, to remember what we used to do in there. So I just breathe and walk away until I'm on the ground floor, and hearing voices.

I flinch, not wanting to be seen, and especially not wanting to see the woman who started all of this.

I yelled at Ekaterina after the fight with Wolfgang. Got her to confess she was just using me. Turns out she was happy to stop pretending. She told me I was on their side now, and I told her to go to hell. If I meet her again, I'll cause another scene.

Ultimately, I chose to betray my husband—and I'm owning that. But even if she didn't force me to do it, she's fucking heinous. She put this whole

thing in motion, and I fell right into her trap.

Thankfully, she's not here. But my heart skips a beat when I see Ivan in the door frame reading something on his phone. He's not my husband, but seeing him here means Wolf is close by. That I'm somewhere in his proximity, where I can breathe a little easier. Pretend he's still mine.

"What can I do for you?" Ivan asks, without taking his eyes off his phone.

"I… is Wolfgang around?"

He looks up. "He is."

"I need to see him. Is he in his study?"

He considers it, watching me in silence as I wait, my breath held tight in my lungs. I haven't seen him in so long. It aches not to be near him. But the look Ivan throws me next—of pity, of powerlessness over the situation—shows me he was already instructed of what to say if this ever happened.

"I'm sorry, Victoria—"

"Why aren't you with Kiril? I messaged you," my husband's voice cuts him off from somewhere to my left. He passes me by like a dark silhouette, each step deliberate, filled with control. The trail of his subtle perfume strangles me. His name clings to my tongue, tasting bittersweet. I swallow, eyes trained on him—only on him.

Please forgive me, they tell him. But he won't even spare me a glance.

"Sorry, boss. I was just on my way now."

Ivan leaves, and before Wolf follows him out, I get his attention.

"Wolf… please, we need to talk."

To my surprise, he turns to me, but there's nothing of him that I remember. He looks at me the same way he looks at everyone else now. Like I'm just one of his subjects.

"Tell me how I can make this right," I whisper.

"You want to make things right? Then stop making my men late when I need them."

I blink, feeling the sting of his words everywhere. I bet he sees it—the pain written all over my face. But he still turns and walks away. And I think… I think for the first time ever, he doesn't see me as his wife… or his pawn in a revenge game. He sees me as a mistake.

Although every atom in my body wants me to retreat, to hide in a corner and cry, I rush after him and grab his hand. He halts, and when his eyes slide over to me, fire blasts through them. All for me.

"Please…"

"Say it. Say what you did."

I grip his hand tighter, whispering, "I–I betrayed you. And I'm so…"

He shakes his head, snorting an incredulous laugh.

"You're not even willing to give me a confession, yet you beg for my forgiveness."

I grind my teeth together in shame. There's so much shame coursing through me right now, when he looks at me. He's right. I can't give him a confession, because even *I* can't believe how much I hurt him. Neither of us can.

"I told Ekaterina…" I say, my body weakening, barely standing up. "I told her you lied to your father, because you said you couldn't afford any screw

ups. I told her that, and she told him, so that you'd never get…" I choke on almost every word, holding on to him so I don't fall. "So that you'd never get your throne. And I m-made a mistake. I lost you. I lost you. I lost…"

I sob, covering my face with my hands, dropping to my knees. I sob, and I break, and I swim in my own pain, hearing the sound of his shoes as he walks away.

I thought I knew pain before, that I had lived through plenty of it throughout my life. But nothing—absolutely nothing compares to the kind I'm feeling now. It's excruciating. And it keeps on growing inside me, like a demon making a home of me, turning every chamber of my heart into hell.

"…you," I murmur, even though I know he's no longer here to hear it. "I lost you."

***

Hours later, I'm back in bed, staring into nothingness. The room is dark, cold even, a gentle rain splattering on my closed windows. I guess summer is really ending.

I've cried so much the past week that there are no more tears left in me.

I turn on my left side, letting my eyes close. Hoping sleep will grab me faster tonight. But when I do, a muted thud downstairs makes me open them back. The house is always so silent—nothing ever happens inside. It strikes me as odd, but who knows? Maybe someone dropped something, and that's what the sound was.

Except it wasn't, because it happens again.

Angry voices come with it, one of which I recognize. Ivan. And maybe Kiril… and some other men all barging into the house. I get up on my arms, the sheets shifting with me. Something is wrong.

Are we being attacked again? I didn't hear any gunshots.

Draping my legs over the mattress, I jolt out of bed and open the door, peering into the semi-lit hallway that captures some of the lights from downstairs. The voices pour in more clearly now—and they sound agitated. Not angry, but… desperate. Curses follow almost every other word, and panic grips me when I start making sense of what this is.

"Get me a fucking doctor!" someone shouts.

A loud groan overpowers the voice. "I said no. Get out. All of you! Out!"

I don't wait to hear more. I bolt down the stairs, expecting the worst. And when my bare feet touch the last stair, I see him around the corner. A whimper leaves my chest at the blood on my husband's body as he lies there on the floor with a grimace of pain.

I rush toward him, pushing large, solid bodies away as best I can.

"Victoria… don't," Ivan says, extending an arm forward to stop me. He can try all he wants. I'm not going anywhere, no matter what threats he wants to make. "You have to leave."

I look him dead in the eye. "I'm his wife! You're insane if you think I'm leaving him. What the hell happened?!"

He runs a bloody hand through his hair, cursing out loud.

"We were attacked, and then… he just went fucking crazy, all by himself. He got shot, and now he won't let us call a doctor."

“Call the doctor,” I say, leaving no room for debate. “*Now*, Ivan. And take everyone out.”

I don’t know what else happens around us because the moment I shift my focus to Wolf, everything else fades away. His face has new cuts, lines in which the blood is still fresh but stagnant. His eyes are closed, but he’s breathing. Grunting as he pushes into the floor, trying to get himself up.

“Tell them no,” he says. “No doctor. The bullet only grazed me.”

I shake my head, my vision blurring at seeing him in this state.

“A doctor *is* coming,” I snap. “You’re not dying. You hear me? Be mad at me all you want, but you are *not* dying!”

The faintest smile pulls at the corner of his lip. He groans, and more panic floods me.

“Wolf, what did you do? What did you do…?” I put my shaky hands on him, gently, so I can unbutton his shirt and see exactly where he was shot. “You’re bleeding too much,” I whisper.

He doesn’t say anything.

But then his eyes finally open—and for the first time in days, he doesn’t just look at me. He finally sees me again.

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WOLFGANG

She's here. And she's touching me with shaky hands, soothing my pain as she drags me back under her fucking spell. The scent of iron fills the air, but I can still feel the fragrance of those flowers emanating from her hair. Lilies. What is she doing here, so soft and clean, and perfect, smearing herself with my blood and descending into my hell?

Tears wet her pretty face, and whenever I open my eyes, she's all I see. All I want to see right now, when I'm bleeding all over this fucking floor. The pain… I don't really feel it. I don't even remember what I did to get to this state. All I remember is thinking about her—constantly, like a thorn in my back that I could never pull out.

I told her she meant nothing to me anymore, and maybe I meant it at that moment. But the truth is, there hasn't been a single second when I didn't want her. I still feel her on my sheets late at night. Breathing behind that closed door. When I look up at the fucking sky, her blue eyes blink in the dark of my mind. Showing me I still want her.

"You're bleeding too much," she whispers. "Please… let me help you."

Her sweet voice keeps me awake and I cling to it, not because I'm dying—I've been dodging death for way too long now, and this isn't going to be the night it takes me—but because I want us to pretend there's still something left. That she didn't gut me in front of the world, and I didn't throw all my anger at her.

"Then you do it," I grunt, and her worried gaze locks with mine.

"W-What? I… I don't know how. I'll hurt you."

"You won't. Listen to me, love," I say, and her watery blue eyes brighten at hearing her nickname again. Fuck. I love seeing her so raw. Maybe she's starting to care. And I hate that I cling to that, but it is what it is. She's already made a home in my heart, and she won't be going fucking anywhere.

"I need you to take a deep breath, love. Calm yourself down. Yeah, that's it. That's my good girl." Pain shoots through me with every small move, but it's nothing I haven't felt before. I can bear it. It's just the fucking bleeding that needs to stop.

"Put pressure on it, and it will stop. Use your hands. Press as hard as you can. Okay?"

She looks at me, bewildered, but snaps out of it quickly and nods frantically. More pain—thicker, stronger—ripples through my shoulder as I feel her do exactly what I asked. I don't take my eyes off her. Off the way she leans that perfect body over mine, in her pretty little nightgown, drowning herself in my blood like she's giving herself over to me willingly.

"That's it, love," I murmur, fighting my vision from going black. "You're doing so well…"

"Wolf? Wolf, please…" Although her sobbing intensifies, I can barely hear it. "Please!"

Her voice is fading.

Her face, too.

I'm not dying. But I don't have the strength to tell her that.

***

I wake up to the sound of embers cracking in the fireplace. Even with my eyes closed, I can see the lights flashing against my lashes.

Something warm and soft covers my leg and side. I breathe in, and I know it's her. So I don't open my eyes just yet. Instead, I pull on my wounded shoulder so I can bring my arm over her body. She feels so small, so fragile. Has she been eating at all? Guilt punches me in the gut. She's still my wife, and I didn't take care of her. Regardless of everything, I *always* take care of her.

"Wolf?" she murmurs below me, her delicate hand brushing my naked abdomen.

Christ. My cock lengthens just at the sound of her voice.

Finally, I open my eyes, the dark room basking in a deep orange glow. We're in the living room, on our side of the house, lying on a divan sofa. Everyone else is gone. I don't have to look to see that my shoulder is wrapped up in bandages—tight and clean, as if a doctor eventually came in.

"Are you alright?" I ask her, my voice thick, groggy.

She lets out a long, heavy breath, burying her face in the crook of my neck.

"You got shot… you fainted… and you're asking me if I'm alright?"

I caress her head. “This isn’t my first rodeo. But it was for you.”

“Wolf… you scared the hell out of me. I thought…”

“I didn’t. I won’t. You were the one who told me I have the devil’s luck.”

I can feel her lips stretching into a smile against my skin. And my whole body tells me to put my mouth to it. I want to see her face light up with that smile, reminding me of the days we were happy. Of the days we were still us.

Grunting from the pain of my stupid fucking wound, I pull her face up by her chin, her big, teary eyes meeting mine. They glance down at my lips. She doesn’t think she’s allowed to kiss me. But I’m already hers, and she knows that. She ruined me, and I’m still here, craving her taste in my mouth.

I lean down, pressing my lips to hers.

She whimpers, and before I get to kiss her sweet tongue, she pulls back.

“I’m sorry. I’m so, so sorry,” she whispers, her breath warm on my face.

I bring her closer to me again. My shoulder pounds with pain, but I don’t give a fuck. I kiss her more, snaking my hand between her legs, feeling them part for me like they always do. Pulling her panties to the side, my fingertips touch pussy. She’s slick, plump. Warm. Begging to be licked and fucked.

“Why did you do it, Victoria? Why did you go to her instead of trusting me?”

She shakes her head, swallowing. “I was scared, confused. And she was there for me when I thought I had no one. And Sasha sent me that video and… and… he always taught me to believe my own eyes. To not let myself get swayed easily. I guess I really fucking suck at that.” She sniffs.

“I just need you to know that if Sasha hadn’t confirmed what she told me, I would never have believed Ekaterina alone.” Her palms touch my chest, covering my heart. “I was wrong not to trust you, regardless. You are a good man, Wolfgang… and you have done so much for me that I know I don’t deserve your forgiveness. But I can’t live without you, so I’ll ask for it anyway.”

Her breathy words flow between us. I press my fingers to her slit and she calls out my name, shifting so she can make room for me to rub her cunt. I draw circles on her small clit, applying just enough pressure to make her arch for more. Then I let my fingers slide down, until her flesh buries me inside. In that place I long for, even when she’s out of sight.

Her moans sink me deeper, slowly, until my knuckle disappears into her heat.

I stay there for a moment, unmoving. Enjoying the silky feel of her on my hands.

“I miss you.” She tells me that while I’m inside her, as if it’s as normal as breathing air. *Christ*. The action gets me harder, making a mess of my mind and pulling at my mental restraints until they unshackle. She missed me… and I’m fucking dying every day without her.

“You haven’t been riding. Alaska whines for you all the time, and you’re not there. Why is that, love?”

Deep down, I hope she doesn’t fully hear me because I don’t want her to know I’m looking for her every day by the stables. On the meadows. Everywhere.

She shakes her head, her pussy pulsing around me. “I can’t. It hurts too much because I know…” she moans when I pull out a little, then push back inside. “I know you don’t care…”

“Mmm. But shouldn’t you be happy without me? It’s what you’ve always wanted. I’m giving you that freedom… so why won’t you be a good girl and take it?”

Her eyes fly open, looking up at me, all drowsy and submissive.

“Tell me what to do, Wolf, and I’ll do it. Everything… except that. Don’t ask me to forget you when you’re the only thing on my goddamn mind.”

I listen but don’t react, because her words hurt more than what she did. It would’ve been easier if she didn’t want me. At least then, I could’ve told myself I wasn’t enough. But she’s telling me she’s mine, and that twists the knife deeper into my scars. The ones she made when she threw me to the wolves in this house.

But none of that matters now. Not when she’s all whimpering with my fingers up her sweet cunt.

“Then why don’t you turn around, love, so I can stuff that pretty pussy with my cock… and make the aching stop?”

VICTORIA

I do what he says and it’s second nature. Like I never stopped. He hooks his fingers under the edge of my panties, pulling them down to my thighs. I pull them lower until they’re pooling at my feet—or somewhere on the floor. I don’t give a damn.

Behind me, I can feel my husband taking out his cock from beneath his boxer briefs. Then he’s pushing against my entrance—his head smooth and sleek with pre-cum. I arch into it, moaning deep and raw. I press a hand to my mouth, and I hear him chuckle.

“Nah. Let them hear what I do to you, love. Let them know I got what they’ll never have.”

Love. He says it like it’s true, like I am the love of his life.

But people say all sorts of things when they’re lusting. And I know how much I’ll hurt again later, when this is all over and he remembers what I’ve done. But for now, I'll take it. I’ll let him call me love, chasing his affection like I was born with no other purpose than to make him mine.

His strong arms wrap around me, offering me the safe space I never thought I’d get back. A hand cups my breast, squeezing my nipple as he guides his cock farther inside my pussy with ease. I’m wet and pulsing, ready to take him everywhere.

A thrust so hard and sudden makes us both groan. My back rubs against his hard abdomen and chest as I bring my hand between my legs to seek all the friction. I feel alive again. For the first time in God knows how long, my heart beats stronger, like it was never broken in the first place.

He fucks my pussy, and I cry out his name. My wetness spreads in all the places it can get—down to my ass, on my inner thighs, and on his pelvis. I’m entranced by the sounds we make when he’s claiming me—raw, and dirty, and primal. The kind of thing no sane person would give away.

Yet I did. I betrayed him.

“Don’t cry, love,” he speaks into my ear, goosebumps erupting on my hands and back, feeling the reverberation of his voice on my skin. “You know I’ll always be here.”

I fight to believe him as he pushes two inked fingers past my lips. Closing my eyes, I moan around them, giving him my pussy. I take and take, and take, and he gives. Moments later, I tense up against him, legs twitching with pleasure as I secretly wish for this orgasm to wash away my sins. His

cock throbs inside me, pulsing with his cum until I feel it hitting the deepest parts of me.

Then we're both breathing with each other, coming down, not wanting to remember where we left things. His fingers leave my mouth, and he buries a kiss into the crook of my neck.

"Don't pull out," I tell him, terrified of being the only one trapped in this trance. "Stay inside me a little longer. Please?"

I hold my breath in anticipation, my body tingling with the sensation of him still filling me. And to my surprise, he responds by squeezing me tighter to his chest. Turns out… I'm not the only one not ready to leave.

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WOLFGANG

My wife is curled up on the sofa we shared last night, sleeping peacefully. The early morning light warms her face, casting light shadows under her lashes and lower lip. Her body rises and lowers with quiet breaths under the blanket I covered her with. Right there, where I fucked her, and she let me.

I fell asleep with my cock inside her after she asked me so sweetly. How could I ever refuse her? I never will, no matter how much it hurts me.

But as I sit here, a drink in my hand that I shouldn't be drinking, all the mess in my head starts tangling again. And I remember all we've lost… all that I'm not sure we can ever be again.

I almost died last night because of my stupidity. I went off the rails. The thought of not having her by my side almost killed me. And when I came back in that state, she was the only one who truly cared about it without a motive. She just did.

I want to believe we could rebuild from here, but fuck… she betrayed me. And she could've told anyone else… but not that wench living under this roof. Not Ekaterina.

I take a large sip of the scotch, feeling the burn through my throat and into my empty stomach. It's good. This pain is good.

Instinctively, I turn my gaze to the archway, seeing Mikhail come in. Thank fuck I covered Victoria up.

"You look like shit," he says.

He's wearing a four-piece suit today—a steep difference from how miserably I must look with this bloody bandage around my shoulder. But it's alright. We may have our differences, but I'm always glad to see him step into the man he's meant to be.

"Rough night, huh?"

"If you wake her up, I'll kill you," I murmur.

His brows rise, surprised. Then he takes a seat and looks at me.

"What the fuck happened? Heard you started a killing spree. Mind filling me in?"

I shrug. "We were attacked—I shot back. What do you want me to say?"

"You had men with you. There was no need to go on a suicide trip. That was dumb."

"Keep your fucking voice down."

He's right. Though I wasn't trying to die. I just… I needed an escape.

We sit in silence, with only my wife's soft breathing filling the air. And maybe it's exactly her softness that keeps us civil right now. I realize this is the only time my brother and I have sat in the same room without fighting.

“How long are you going to keep this on for?” he asks.

I gulp the rest of my drink. “You’ll have to be more specific.”

“She’s your wife. You wanted her.”

“What do you want from me, Mikhail?”

He crosses an ankle over his knee and looks away. A moment of silence stretches between us.

“I want you to take the reins from me. I don’t want them.”

My jaw clenches. I don’t fucking want to talk to him about that.

“I just wanted to have a shot,” he says. “No, don’t look at me like that, because we both know I never stood a chance against you and that… fucking brain of yours.”

“It doesn’t matter how smart I am if I have to fight against windmills every day of my life. You and Ekaterina made sure of that.”

He sighs. “Maybe. But that’s exactly why you’ve earned it.”

I look at him, not quite sure what to say to that. Isn’t this what I’ve always wanted? Their stamp of fucking approval? I never even knew why. It just felt like the missing piece of my life. Until…

I look at my wife, and last night’s events run through my mind.

The missing piece was her… She has been… all along.

Still, for Mikhail to say these things to me now… The memories come back to me in pieces—how he and Ekaterina fought that day, in the garden, how

shocked he looked when Father made him *Pakhan*. How he comforted Victoria when I left her in my office… Corinne told me.

“It was hard for me too, you know? Being in your shadow from the moment I was born.”

“What?” I hold my breath.

“What, you think I had a perfect childhood? My mother is a fucking bitch. She never looks at me like I’m enough. And let’s be honest, you’ve always been Father’s favorite.” He scoffs, sounding bittersweet.

Have I truly not seen him all these years? My brother… he’s supposed to hate me. It’s what I’ve always known. Now he’s telling me he feels utterly alone in this world.

He shakes his head. “We were kids. And we were pitted against each other for the longest time. Fuck, I don’t know what else to tell you, but just… end this bullshit with Victoria. Because unlike me, you actually have someone who loves you. Don’t be an idiot and give that up.”

I’m lost for words as he gets up. Have I been so wrapped up in my own pain I never saw his?

I follow him with my eyes until he’s almost out of the room.

“She betrayed me. I don’t know how to get back from that.”

He halts. “Yeah, I know she did. But like I said… My mother is a cunt. She played her, and you know it.”

VICTORIA

I’m in the shower upstairs, watching the water slide down my body and go down the drain.

Today, I don’t feel empty—I am terrified. Wolfgang could’ve died last night. I could’ve lost him for good, and I have a feeling this is my fault. I hurt him. So badly that he didn’t care what happened to him. That he looked for pain elsewhere because maybe he didn’t know how to deal with the one we share. I don’t either.

All I know is I want him, and the only thing last night managed to do was make me crave him harder, not make it go away.

I finish showering and check my phone.

He hasn’t replied to any of the messages I sent this morning, making it pretty clear where we stand. What we did was a fling. A distraction, maybe. But it wasn’t forgiveness. He’s still punishing me, and all I can do for now is take it.

I put on some clothes and dry my hair before I trudge out into the hallway. I need to get out of here, to soak in what’s left of the summer sun before depression fully takes me to the point of no return. Besides, I miss Alaska.

I feed her every day, but I haven’t ridden her in a while. Not that I will today—I can’t—though I can at least spend more time with her in the stables.

A low, eerie voice stops me in my tracks when I’m almost to the main door downstairs.

It’s a voice I rarely hear in this house. Because Yuri Rykov is like a ghost—we all know he’s here, but he rarely makes himself known. As if he enjoys keeping you on your toes, enjoys seeing the fear poking through your skin as goosebumps at the sound of him.

Normally, that’s exactly what I would be feeling right now, since I’m alone. But something else ignites in me. A rage so quiet, so deadly, it stands no chance in the face of that fear.

If anyone is to blame for all the shit going on in Wolfgang’s life, it’s this man right here—his father. Someone needs to straighten him out fast.

Still, that tendril of fear is there, begging me to back down. Only my feet don’t listen. They move on their own accord, each step heavy, weighted, heartbreak still coursing through me.

Lightheaded from what can only be an obscene amount of adrenaline, I step into the door frame of his study.

He’s looking down at some papers scattered on his desk with his grizzled hair and the worn out body of an ancient god of the underworld. He’s clean of any cuts, flawless, not inked and scarred like Wolfgang. Or Mikhail. I don’t know if I should be even more scared by the fact… or relieved.

Either way, I’m here, and my heart is in my throat. Because his eyes are no longer on the papers. They’re watching me. And he looks like he’s about to draw blood.

“You…” he says, taking off his glasses. “You’ve got some fucking nerve to show up here, girl.”

My heartbeat's so loud, his voice is muffled, like he’s underwater.

“Stole my son’s future…” He gets up. “Caused chaos in my business…” He rounds the desk slowly, as if he’s being extra careful with the corners. “And on top of that, you did what women do these days—played Wolfgang like a two-faced cunt. And he fell for it.”

The words sting, but it’s nothing compared to the rage building quickly inside me. Not for me—for my husband. What Yuri is implying is that Wolf is weak and naïve, when we all know he’s anything but.

Yuri stops in front of me, his watchful eyes shifting across my face. He could hit me. I know he could. But I won't give him the chance to do so before I tell him everything I've been bottling up.

"He's your *son*," I tell him between clenched teeth. "And you pulled the rug from under his feet when he was doing everything in his power to earn your love. To do what you wanted him to do in the first place and take the goddamn throne!"

"What I wanted him to do has nothing to do with what he did." His voice is calm, quiet. Completely different from mine—a shaky, loud mess. It scares me even more, but I don't back down. He adds, "I needed him to be more. And instead, he made himself happy." He puts on a mocking smile. "Do you know what that tells people, girl?"

"That he's the richest man in the goddamn world."

"No. No… It tells them he's human."

I blink, taken aback. He can't possibly be that far gone…

"It tells them…" he continues, "That he's a simple man, just like them. And simple men don't build up empires. Their blood is too warm—they have blind spots, weaknesses. But monsters? We don't care who we step on. We keep our eye on the prize. As he should've done if he wanted the throne so badly."

A smile spreads across his face, resembling Wolfgang and Mikhail's, but not fully. Something is seriously wrong with this man.

"None of my sons deserves to be king, Victoria. One of them doesn't even want the title. The other wants it, but he's too weak. Do you know how hard that is for a parent to realize?"

The words roll off my tongue faster than I can control them. "You're a fucking hypocrite."

His eyes squint, but he keeps silent.

I wonder if anyone as insignificant as me has ever challenged him.

“You like to hide behind these stupid metaphors, but in the end, you *are* a simple man, just like the rest. You have a wife. You have sons. And you can lie to yourself all you want, but we both know the real reason you initially wanted Wolfgang to take the throne is that you still haven’t gotten over his mother’s death. She was the love of your life. He’s the only proof she ever existed. That she could love a monster like you.” His jaw clenches, but he still listens. I’m letting it all out, even if I don’t know how much of it is true. It’s just what I think. But based on the look on his face, it seems my words resonate with him, that I’m telling him the truth.

“If you were really being honest with yourself,” I continue, “you’d realize the reason you’re so angry with him isn’t that he was showing the world he’s weak. It’s that he was happy, that he had everything he ever wanted—the kind of life that slipped between your fingers when your ex-wife died, and you never found that love again. Because it’s rare!” I shout, tears lodged in my throat as I slap my chest with my palm. “That love is rare, but you still had it. And now your son has it, and instead of wishing him well and giving him his birthright… all you’re doing is showing the world what a sorry ass man you are.”

Silence stretches between us. So much so that I get the chance to take a few deep breaths and calm myself down a little. In the end, I point a finger in his direction, my voice finally low. Collected.

“He earned that throne. And you fucking know it.”

Yuri stares at me, frozen somewhere in time, with a tight jaw and the look of a man who’s bleeding for the first time. In front of a stranger. In front of the daughter of the man who betrayed him and started everything.

I walk out with my head held high, knowing he won’t do anything to attack me now. Only when I reach my room on the second floor… only *then* I

close the door behind me… and break down.

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VICTORIA

A shooting star splits the sky in half, a trail of glitter fading in its wake.

I watch through the open windows as I lie in my bed, when a patch of light from the hallway stretches on the wall. The door opens, someone coming in quietly. I don't have to turn to see who it is. I know the sound of Wolf's steps, can feel the scent of his body wafting over to me, subtle and alluring like it's always been.

The mattress dips behind me. He doesn't lie next to me. He sits. And when his scarred hand brushes my side in a gentle caress, I close my eyes, holding on to that feeling.

"You really went to war for me, didn't you, love?"

I let the question linger unanswered, my mind focusing on that last word. I wonder who told him.

"It's not every day that someone tells my father off the way you did. The entire house heard it. Corinne told me."

Right. Of course she did.

Squeezing my eyelids tight, I ask him, “Did you get it?”

“At the next meeting. He’ll step down and appoint me. I don’t think he wants to do it, but… Mikhail said no, anyway.”

I let out a sigh of relief, and I swear my body actually feels lighter. Like a huge stone has been taken off my chest, and I’m finally allowed to breathe. I can’t believe I got through to his father. Or maybe I didn’t. Maybe it was something else that did it. I don’t care—I’m just glad he finally did the right thing toward his son.

“I didn’t deserve it,” Wolf says. “What you did for me. And you shouldn’t have put yourself in danger like that. He knows better than to lay a hand on you, but still, he’s a dangerous man, Victoria. And you went in there all by yourself.”

I shake my head against the pillow. “I don’t care. I know this doesn’t fix things between us, and it’s not why I did it, but it had to be done. Whether it was me or someone else, someone had to tell him those things.”

“Why, then, love? If you didn’t do it so I’d forgive you, why did you?”

I shift, deciding against telling him. “It doesn’t matter. I’m just glad it worked out.”

“Victoria,” he says, and I swear, the way he says my name heals something in me. It sounds so tender, so raw, as if he’s tired of denying me. Tired of the sadness he carries with him. I recognize it— and I’m tired too. “Come to me.”

Hesitantly, I turn on my other side, facing him. His eyes are bright under the moonlight and I bore mine into his, not knowing what I want to do next other than knowing I want him. All of him, forever. My life before him seems far away, unfamiliar.

“Wolf…”

He shakes his head. “No, love. I don’t deserve a single apology from those pretty lips. It was me. It was always me who had to say I’m sorry.”

“That’s not true. I…”

“You did nothing wrong. All you did was try to help your family. And you wouldn’t even have had to do that if it weren't for me. If I hadn’t kept things from you. If I hadn’t… fucking deluded myself into thinking I didn’t love you.”

“What?”

“You…” he breathes out, his control seeping from him like smoke in the air. “You have made a fucking mess of me the moment I brought you into this house. I don’t know who I am anymore when I’m not with you, and I don’t even want to remember it. All I want… is you.” His jaw clenches, and I suck in a breath because the aggression with which he says it says more than the words themselves. He means it. “All I crave… is you. And it runs so deep, this craving, that I don’t know how to tame it.”

I listen, heart lodged in my throat.

“It’s true, Victoria,” he says, dragging a hand through his hair, his voice hoarse. “I don’t mean to scare you, but I would drown this fucking world in blood for you. And not even you could stop me.”

My mouth parts, my very soul trembling on my lips, about to give itself over to him. I move to a sitting position, facing him. He’s breaking right here, in front of me, peeling layers of himself he’s never let anybody else see. Anybody but me.

“I’m sorry. I’m so fucking sorry for shutting you out. It was never about you. *I’m* fucked up…” He looks up. “I couldn’t see anything past the hurt,

past the rage I felt when you went to her behind my back." He swallows. "But even then… I never stopped loving you. How could I?"

My first tear falls, sliding down my cheek.

"You love me," I say, voice breaking. A statement, not a question.

I never realized just how much I needed to hear it. To confirm it. Because deep down, I knew. I just never let myself believe it. Didn't want to give it the power to crush me.

"Are you going to make me pay for my mistake?" I ask. "Because you should. You should…"

His gaze is raw, vulnerable. Such a strange sight on such a big, powerful man. On what was meant to be a monster, a cold-blooded criminal. He keeps silent, his Adam's apple bobbing.

He leans in, reaching for me, and when our skin touches, his face twists with something I can't name—relief, desperation, love, maybe everything at once.

His arms wrap around me, behind my knees, behind my back. And in the next second, he's pulling me into him like he can't bear the thought of being apart any longer.

WOLFGANG

My restraint is so brittle I barely make it to the door across the hallway.

I kick it open until it hits the wall, then let my wife's body bounce on the mattress before me. I pull my t-shirt above my head and get rid of it. When

I have her in my sight again, she’s there, legs spread, hair splayed over the sheets, watching me. Her chest expands and retracts, her pouty lips parted, waiting for me.

I’ve never in my life seen something so beautiful.

I close the distance between us, unbuckling my belt on the way, slipping out of my pants. Leaning above her, I push her leg up with my knee, opening her up more. She mewls, brushing her hand down my naked chest until it reaches between us, fumbling for my cock beneath my boxer briefs.

I’ve rarely been naked around her. I used to just pull out my cock and fuck her bare. But that won’t do right now. I need to feel her everywhere, want her pressed so tight against my skin neither of us breathes properly.

I pull her nightgown up above her head, and she helps me by removing it fully. Her breasts are round, plump, ending with pointy nipples that graze against my chest when I lower on top of her. I groan into her neck, inhaling her scent, feeling her soft body under mine.

“My pretty girl,” I whisper against her neck before pulling her skin between my teeth. Her flesh sinks under the pressure, delicate. Raw. She arches, whimpering, and I lick the same spot for comfort. She stretches her neck, showing me more skin, giving me more of her. Sweet, submissive, and even when I have her, I want her more.

I bring my mouth down, the sweet scent of her pussy drawing my tongue there. She’s pink, open. I can’t wait to stuff her with my cum. To see it swollen and white as she pulses through her orgasm. For now, I swipe my tongue over her entrance, groaning as I push it inside. She’s already wet, and when I pull out, I can feel her arousal dripping onto my chin.

My tongue darts out, catching it so I can swallow it. She whimpers, arching her pussy upward. And I give her everything she needs. Simultaneously, I slip out of the boxer briefs, taking my hard cock in my hand. After stroking it a few times, I straighten up and guide it to her entrance. The moment it

touches those soft, sensitive walls, I close my eyes, lowering my head into the crook of her neck.

“I love you.” I push in all the way, and we breathe out in tandem.

She’s locked in place now. And nothing could take me away from this moment. My peace… my sanity… it’s all here, between Victoria’s legs, above her perfect body, where she chooses me again and again. I thrust deep and slow, finding parts of me I never truly met. Hope… longing…

My humanity.

She takes everything I give her, moaning through every stroke. Her warm voice spreads out into the room, into the hallway. I grab her throat, and she gasps. Then I put my mouth to hers, swallowing her whimpers whole.

“I love you,” I tell her again.

I flip her over, hovering above her back as I guide my cock back inside her.

“I love you…” I say once more.

Goosebumps spread across the surface of her skin. I dig my hand into her ass cheek, pulling, kneading as I fuck her. Her nails rake against the sheets, stretching her arms above her head. Wrapping my hand around her hair, I pull her head to me.

“Say it, love. Repeat what I just said.”

A whimper. “Y-You love me.”

“I do.” I breathe out, pulling my cock out of her pussy, sliding back inside. “Yes, that’s right, Victoria. Your husband fucking loves you, and this needy pussy, and everything you are and ever were.”

“Oh, God…” Her throat catches, body arching back into mine. “Wolf…”

I let go of her hair, pushing two fingers into her mouth, keeping her bent backward toward me. Her eyes slide to mine, hooded and with a soft crease between them.

She’s close. And fuck, so am I.

“Mm-hmm.” I whisper in her ear, voice scattered by my own broken breathing. “Come all over your husband’s cock, love.”

I ram into her a few more times, her channel wet, warm, and pulsing. I slide in and out with ease, looking down between our bodies. My cock is smeared with her wetness, and the smell drives me fucking crazy. Sweet and erotic. I could wear it on my skin, so everyone knows we’re one.

She cries out, the sound muffled by my fingers. When she comes, I come with her, spilling my cum deep inside her. She finishes before me, sliding back down on the bed. But I’m not done stuffing her.

Her little pussy takes and takes, and I swear it grips me tighter, squeezing every last bit I give her. It’s already spilling out of her, even though she’s plugged with my cock. She shifts under me, mewling, as if she’s still seeking friction. So I don’t pull out.

I lie down next to her, pulling her with me until I’m spooning her.

“Shhh,” I say, caressing her soft breast, cupping it with my palm. “Don’t move, love. We’ll wait right here, right as we are, until we can continue. Until I can slide right out of your pussy and sink into your ass.”

Her chest expands beneath my palm, and she nods as she regulates her own breathing, nestling deeper into my arms. Minutes later, when my cock lengthens once more, I wrap my hand around her hip and lift her leg on top of mine, sliding out of her cunt slowly.

Cum gushes out with it, and it’s enough to lubricate her tight little asshole. Enough to stretch it without hurting her.

“Good girl,” I drawl, praising her through it, kissing the lobe of her ear. Keeping her tight at my chest as I sink inside her. “Now say it again. Tell me how much I love you, so I know you believe it.”

She sucks in a breath, her ass clenching around me.

“Y-You love me. And you forgave me. A-And you want all of me. My husband loves me.”

Fucking hell…

I close my eyes, burying my face into her hair. I speak to her, my voice muffled now as I fuck her ass, not even knowing if she can understand it. But I repeat her words back to her. Then I beg for her forgiveness, because without her, I’m just a man. A man with no purpose, no aim. A man I never want to be again.

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WOLFGANG

I wake up with Victoria's naked back against my chest. The mornings are getting colder now, and the small goosebumps on her arm say she’s cold. I pull the sheets around us, and she nuzzles deeper into me, seeking my warmth.

She’s so soft, so perfect. How the fuck did I end up with her?

I caress the skin on her abdomen in slow, lazy circles, eyes still closed. I don’t want to get out of this bed. Everything I need is here now, and the thought of doing anything else than this is obscene. Everyone else can go fuck themselves—today, tomorrow, and for the rest of our lives.

All I want is to fuck my wife into oblivion. Watch her radiate when she’s out, riding her horse. Watch her belly swell with life. Watch her be my wife and do whatever it is that makes her feel alive. Because that’s exactly what she’s doing to me just by being by my side.

She shifts in my arms, and I loosen my hold on her. When I open my eyes, I see hers—big, clear, and blue like the morning sky—staring up at me with what I can only describe as contentment. Love. She’s not incredulous, like I thought she’d be, given everything I did to her.

My wife knows I love her now. She believes it.

And it makes me the happiest fucking man in the world.

“Good morning, love,” I say, leaning down to kiss her pretty mouth.

She smiles, and her whole face lights up. So beautiful.

“You’re still here.”

“I’ll always be. I hope I made myself clear last night.”

“I don’t know… I feel like maybe I need to hear it a few more times. You know, for good measure.”

“For good measure…”

In a swift movement, I flip her on her back. She yelps, laughing, and I plant myself above her, between her naked legs.

“I’m kidding, I’m kidding,” she says, squirming under me.

“Not convinced.” I press a kiss to her neck, pushing her leg up with my knee. I’m already hard for her. All I’d have to do is lean in a little more and —

“You love me. I’m your whole world,” her sweet voice rings in my ears. “Without me, you’d perish… your life would cease to exist. Am I convincing now?”

She says it jokingly, but she isn’t wrong. I’ve never cared much about my life. Being born into a family like this teaches you money trumps it. Money and power trump everything. So if I ever died in the pursuit of it, I wasn’t going to complain about it.

Now… that’s different. My life means something because she’s in it. And I don’t want to die or end up in a world where she’s not. So she’s right—my life would cease to exist without her. There would be no point for me anymore.

I slide my cock inside her, wrapping my hand around her neck.

“You don’t know the half of it, love. But that’s alright. What am I here for, if not to show you?”

I fuck her slow and deep, giving back her oxygen in increments. I need her to remember every time I’m inside her. Need her to know I meant every word I said to her last night.

When she comes, she does it peacefully, whimpering in my ear as she squeezes my cock with her pussy. I love it—love it when she takes me hard, love it when she mewls and submits instinctively. Love it when she fights me, when she leaves me laughing in a room after she just stabbed me.

Memories of the past few months fly through my head, and when I come, I come with her in front of my eyes, in my mind, wrapped around my cock. She’s everywhere I need her to be. And she’s here willingly.

“Wolf…” she says, breathless and warm beneath me.

“Hmm?” I kiss her jaw, still inside her.

“I love you too, you know. I never said it, but I…”

“I know, love. You didn’t have to. Not after what you did for me, which is more than anyone ever has, and more than I could’ve asked of you. Come here.”

I slide out of her and pull her into my arms, on top of me. Her breasts are pressed to my chest, and the addictive smell of her skin envelops me.

“What happens now?” she murmurs.

I’ve thought about it. “I want to be done with this shit with my father—get him to step down, then move us out of here. And then… I want us to go on our honeymoon. Enjoy it like normal people.”

She shifts her head up, showing me her eyes. “Normal people?”

“What, you think I can’t be normal?”

“Are you still going to stab people for looking at me the wrong way?”

“Yes.”

She laughs. “Then no, you’re not *normal people*. But I can’t say no to honeymooning with you. I guess I’ll just have to keep you in line.”

I smile, caressing her back, my heart full.

“I guess so.”

We lie together in silence for a bit, neither one of us ready to get up. I still have to settle some things, but fuck, I need this. We both do.

“I know my father is still not dealt with,” she says, as if she’s reading my mind. “You sent Anya and my mother away but… you never said anything about him.”

I pause but decide to tell her the truth. Maybe it’s better for her to know, even if it’s ugly.

“That asshole that shot at you in the fields… he was working with your father. They were trying to take us all out.” She gets up from my chest to look at me. “I’m sorry, love. I have him trapped somewhere, still haven’t decided what I should do with him.”

“It was… him?”

I nod.

“And the attack that almost got you killed?”

“That… was the Irish. They retaliated after…” I sigh. “It’s a long story.”

She looks away, and I can see the wheels turning in her mind.

“What will you do with my father? You say you haven’t decided, and I know it’s only because of me.”

It is. The only reason I haven’t killed the asshole is because I didn’t want her to suffer.

“What do you want me to do?”

“Honestly?” She shakes her head. “Whatever you see fit. I was willing to forgive him for tearing our family apart… but I can’t forgive him for what he attempted to do to us. To you… After everything, he’s still only trying to save himself. And I’m done, Wolfgang. I’m just… done.”

I hold her stare, seeing the decision etched there firmly.

Good. Then I know exactly what I need to do.

***

A few days later, Father organizes a party in the city with everyone in our inner circle.

He tells them he's stepping down, that I'm his next successor, and that Mikhail will be given a different role. No one has anything to say to that.

Not even Ekaterina, who stands in a corner, drink in her hand, watching her son with what looks like resentment… or fuck knows what. He went against what she wanted, after all. I wonder if she knows what he did for Victoria and I.

Across the room, my wife smiles at me, wearing a crimson-colored dress and the ruby necklace I got her for her birthday. She's fucking beautiful, a sight to behold. No wonder all these fuckers can't take their eyes off her. Her brows rise, as if to ask me "what?" so I mouth the answer to her.

"You."

Her pretty face lights up instantly. She's so sweet, this girl. I don't know how the fuck she puts up with me. I'm fixated on her face, on her figure, and it's beckoning me closer. We don't have to sit through all this shit—the announcement is done, and I can do whatever the fuck I want. Right now, that means taking my wife out of here and spending the day with her.

"Before you go," my brother says, appearing in my peripheral vision. "I need to tell you something." I can see Father watching us from his chair, probably wondering if we'll cause a scene and shit. But I don't intend to, and by the look on Mikhail's face, neither does he.

"What is it?" I ask, turning my attention to him.

Whiskey swashes in his glass between the ice. "I'm going away."

I frown. "I don't want to hear it. Just because I'm in charge now, it doesn't mean—"

"Nah, it's not that." He downs the rest of his drink, then places it on the tray of a passing server. "I got something to take care of."

“Where?”

“Los Angeles.”

Fuck. “That’s Italian territory and you know it. They’ll kill you on the spot if they see you.”

“I won’t be there long enough for them to figure it out. And I’m not here to ask your permission. I just thought you should know.”

I sigh. “What the fuck has gotten into you?”

“Starts with *Cecilia*. Ends with *Ferrara*.” He grins.

“You’re going after the don’s daughter? Are you out of your goddamn mind?”

I know there’s no getting through to him. Once Mikhail makes up his mind, good luck changing it. And good luck reeling with his impatience. Cause if he’s telling me he’s going, he already has a flight.

“Relax,” he says, cracking his shoulders. “I have a plan. Now, if I were you, I’d be careful with Cazimir over there.” His eyes flick to my wife. “Is it me, or did he just make her laugh?” He pats my back, and I watch him walk backwards to the door leading outside. “Enjoy your big day. I’ll see you when I see you.”

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WOLFGANG

Eight months later

It’s April. The smell of blossoms floats in the air, the birds fully returned to the forest surrounding our new home. It’s nice and quiet here. No one ever bothers us, and my wife gets to enjoy all the time she wants outside with the horses.

Her birthday is in a few days. I haven’t told her yet, but I’ve arranged for Anya and her mother to come visit. They should be here soon. And so will Sasha. The message from Ivan pops up on my phone—they boarded the plane, and they’re on their way.

In the distance, I hear the gallop of a horse. If I were to guess, I’d say it’s Cerber, the black stallion I gifted to Victoria's family that first day I met her. She learned to appease him, and he’s completely under her spell, needing her constantly. So much so that Alaska whines when she sees them together, even though most of Victoria’s attention remains on her.

I walk around the manor, her silhouette coming into view. Her hair is out, blowing in the wind behind her as she bounces on the stallion's back seamlessly. Alaska follows right behind them, but she's not ponied. She used to be for a while, until she got used to riding along Cerber, but not anymore.

I stop outside the fence, watching them, my wife's back to me.

It reminds me of the first time I saw her—when she turned and finally saw me… I'll never forget the look on her face. She was scared, her lips and the tip of her nose rosy from the harsh winter temperature. Scared, but contained, as if she knew better than to show that weakness in front of someone who could've harmed her.

I loved seeing that fight unfold inside her. The defiance she greeted me with was what piqued my curiosity in the first place. She doesn't look at me like that anymore. Now, when her pretty blue eyes are on me, she lights up like a ray of sunshine. Looks at me knowing my demons will never get to her. Because they won't.

When it comes to my wife, I'm worse than that stallion—every moment I'm free, I need her. Crave her. I have to go to great lengths to give her space to be herself without me. And I do it, because fuck, I love this woman.

"Haven't we done this before?" she asks, catching her breath, jumping off the horse.

I raise a brow. "I have no idea what you're talking about."

"Yeah, right." She smiles. "I thought you were going out with Ivan."

She says that with a knowing tone. She knows what she did that made me cancel that meeting.

"Come here, love."

She takes a sip of water from her flask. “Nuh-uh. I’ve got practice with the kids in an hour.”

She started training our men’s kids to ride shortly after we came back from our honeymoon in the Bahamas. It’s always been her dream, so I made it happen. One day, I’ll be seeing her teach our kids how to do the same.

“Perhaps you should’ve thought about that when you messaged me a picture of your pretty pussy this morning. What, did you think I’d forget?”

Her lips purse. “No, I knew you wouldn’t. In fact—” She approaches me, tilting her head up to speak against my lips. “I was counting on it.”

I look down, the corner of my lips tilting up.

She’s toying with me. And I’m already hard as a fucking rock.

My voice is low, demanding, filled with need. I don’t hide it from her—she needs to know what she’s doing to me. “Leave the reins, Victoria. Or I’ll have to strip you bare right here, on this field.”

“So dangerous,” she drawls, exiting the fenced meadow, latching the gate behind her.

She goes around me, brushing my body with her hand as she turns. I close my eyes, my restraint almost gone from every inch of my body. I reel with it a bit longer, because I enjoy this little game she likes to play with me. But it won’t be enough. I need her.

“Victoria…” My jaw clenches when I feel her hands on me again. On my abdomen, trailing down, close to the proof of what she’s doing to me.

“Yes,” she whispers. “You’re right. We shouldn’t…”

I laugh to myself. She’s good. She’s fucking brilliant.

But now it’s my turn, and I do like to win.

I catch her wrists with one hand, stopping her movement. She gasps behind me, and I turn to her, lifting her chin with my other hand so I can see her eyes.

“I’ve thought long and hard about that picture today, love. About the things I want to do to you.” I leave her chin, unbuttoning the front of her riding breeches, then unzipping them. I slide my hand beneath her panties, finding her warm pussy with my middle finger. She sucks in a breath, melting into the touch. “So when I tell you to come here, you come. You know what happens when we play this little game of ours.” *I get fucking ravenous.*

A smile stretches her lips, her eyes fluttering. “Why do you think I started it?”

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x Rhea Harp

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